

Advait

in
everyday life

*"You are not
missing
the secret*

*You are
missing
The Obvious"*



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PrashantAdvait Foundation

Creating a new humanity through Intelligent Spirituality

Advait
in
everyday life

Series of discourses by
~ Acharya Shri Prashant

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~ **Restlessness** ~

*“To a mind lost in imagination
Reality causes a great deal of confusion.”*

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~ Chapter 1 ~

The pull of the world versus the call of the Center

Question: Why do we get easily influenced by others?

Speaker: Our entire constitution is like that. Our entire configuration is like that. Everything in nature just lives dependent on everything else. Your eyes do not mean anything if they do not look outwards. Which direction do the eyes look at? For the eyes to exist and have any meaning, they have to look outside, right?

You have been made like that. What can you do? If you have eyes that do not look outside at the world, will you say that you have eyes? And does anybody have eyes that look inwards at himself? What do your ears hear?

Listeners: Outside things.

Speaker: Things from outside. What does your skin touch? The outside. This is regarding the body.

Now look at the mind. The mind is full of and built-up of things from the outside. Look at what you are thinking of all the time. What are you thinking of all the time? This. That. There. So, we are designed to be influenced. Nature wants you to get influenced. Nature wants you to get attracted and conditioned. That is why the world is like this, and that is why it rarely happens that one goes inwards. You put a pebble in a lake. Do you see how that wave travels? How does that wave travel?

Listeners: Outwards.

Speaker: Outwards. That is how nature operates. Very rarely, very-very rarely does it happens that a wave reduces radially and ultimately comes to

its centre and disappear. That you do not see. Have you ever seen that?

But that is the whole point of wisdom. Nature wants you to be just engaged with the outside. Wisdom lies in travelling inwards, coming to your center, and then disappearing. Are you getting it? So don't blame yourself. There is no need to feel guilty about it. We are built like that. The day the child is born, in which direction does he look?

Listeners: Outwards.

Speaker: And even on the very first day of the birth, he is already conditioned to know that if he wants food, he should cry. Is he crying out to himself? He is crying out to the external world. He already knows. You see, no knowledge has yet been supplied to the child by the society, he is so small. And yet he already knows that for his sustenance he needs to connect to the outside. He knows. He already knows. We are designed like that. Are you getting it?

Listener 2: Sir, you have said that it is easier to get influenced by others. Similarly, it is easier to get motivated by others. How can one then be self-motivated?

Speaker: It is rare, very-very rare. How to be influenced by others? How to be motivated by others? These are very easy questions to answer. How to be motivated to go towards the self? This question cannot be answered. No process can be given. When you say, "How to?" you are asking for a method, a process. No process or method can be given. You just have to be still.

Know that there are forces that want you to expand, and then you have to leave the rest to existence. No method can really be followed. Because if I

give you a 'How to?' a method, a process, again that method will come from outside. And that method will make you move outwards only. Even that method will not bring you inwards.

What is it that brings you inwards? We call it 'Grace'.

What is 'Grace'? Something that you just get because Somebody loves you.

Who is that Somebody? That we don't know.

Just as there is the force of nature and then the force of society as well, which pulls you away from your Center, there is also Somebody sitting at the Center, who loves you so much that he constantly pulls you towards Himself.

He calls you. He invites you. He even tempts you to come back. You just have to accept His invitation. You just have to answer His call. And you don't answer His call by doing something! You answer His call by stopping the outward movement, which is anyway always happening.

The outward movement, does it really help you? Does it give you peace? You know it is a very stupid movement. Why is it a stupid movement? Because you start from your Center, and then you keep moving outwards, and outwards, all your life. And do you know why you keep moving outwards? To search for the Center. And where is the Center? From where you started.

Why did you start at all? Was there any need to start? There was no need to start. But since you have started, you have already traveled some distance away from the Center. Now you have to come back, and there is Somebody at the Center who is calling you to come back. But you don't respond to His call, you only keep expanding outwards.

And the more you expand outwards, the more you suffer, the more restless you become. You don't even know why you are restless and frustrated all the time. You don't even know why you are afraid all the time.

Have you not seen people who would do this and that, but at the end of everything they would still experience a background tension. And if you ask them, "Why are you tensed?" they would not be able to tell. Why? Because they don't know.

There would be a fellow who has everything, and yet he would be very uneasy. There would be no lightness in his movement. There would be no simple Joy in his living. And if you ask him, "What is missing in your life?" he would not be able to explain. But, he would say,

"Something is missing. Alright! Let me buy a new car."

"Well! Something is missing. Maybe when my daughter will be married-off, then I will be at peace."

"Well! Something is missing. Let me win the next election."

He would not even realize what is missing. And that which is missing is always calling, always calling. It is that call which will bring you to the Center. There is no other 'How to?' He is calling you all the time, and that is why you are drawn towards peace all the time.

Don't you want peace? This urge to be peaceful is the call of the Center. Getting it? Always remember, there is Somebody who loves you greatly. And He loves you without demanding anything from you. And you have no qualifications to be loved. He loves you unconditionally. You have not done anything to deserve His love. And, whatever you do, he still keeps calling.

You are close to the Center, and He calls! You are away from the Center, He still calls! But, whether to respond to the call is in your hands. He is not a dictator. He will not force you to come back. He will just call and wait. That is the 'How to?' That is the only method.

To respond to his call...

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~ Chapter 2 ~

Why is life not lively?

Speaker: Prateek is asking, “What is this thing called ‘boredom’? Why is life not really interesting? Even when there is a period of interest, why does it fade away?”

Boredom comes because you are somewhere else. All the fun is right now, here, but you are missing on all the action. It’s like a great party that is booming here, right now, and you are somewhere else. The party is Real; the place you are at is imaginary. You are missing out on all the fun, on all the celebration.

So, your next question would be, “If I really know that there is a great feast going on here, then why would I miss it?” Yes, nobody wants to skip it. The thing with this is that, we have been trained and educated, conditioned thoroughly, to live in the future. Especially as a young man, our education and upbringing is all about looking towards the future.

Let me give you a few examples from our own life. We study for the sake of results, and results are in the future. Now, as you are sitting with your book, go into it; what really matters to you – the book or the result? The real thing? You are with the book so that..?

Listeners: We can get good results.

Speaker: You realize that. Correct? Now, when the result is the real thing, and the result is in the future, what will happen to the quality of life right now?

Listeners: We will be more worried, tense.

Speaker: Now, when you are always looking there (indicating future), this (indicating present) will automatically become boring.

Now assume that you have something splendid coming your way at 4:00 p.m. today evening. It's not yet come, but you are imagining it to come, it's not yet real but it's a thought in your mind. This session would not be able to give you anything, because your mind would constantly be there. Are you getting it? You would just be somehow passing this time in order to reach the 4:00 p.m.

Now, if you are in the campus just for the sake of a degree, a job, a recognition then the real thing will happen in the fourth year, right? Because that's what we are waiting for - to get a degree and a job. And right now, we are in the first year. That's too bad. "Wish we could just skip everything and move to the fourth year! Can't we have a system where the university directly admits in the fourth year?"

Won't it be great? Why pass through these three unnecessary years? After all, the real thing is going to happen in the fourth year. So, why pass through these three wasteful years? Obviously, the quality of my four years would be poor, because I will study so as to get marks. I will come to college, just to mark attendance. I will enter into the classroom just because I have to pass that course. I will always have an eye on proxies.

Now, how can life be interesting then? How can life be interesting when in your mind you have pegged the real thing to the future? And I am not only talking about this infatuation towards job or degree. In every other way, it has been taught to us to be result-centric, to be future-centric, and we see this all around us. People are working for the sake of the future. And it's quite puzzling. You must ask this question, "Sir, you are living in present,

and you are occupied with the future. Life is right now, so what is happening with your life?” The future is not there, the future is an imagination, right? “For the sake of the imagination, what are you doing to the reality?” But then because we see everybody doing this, we don’t ask this question.

You know what do we do? We think that this is the ‘norm’. We think that life must be like this. If everybody is doing something, not everybody can be wrong. As they used to say in China, a while back, and they would say it with great pride – “One billion Chinese cannot be wrong.” China was the first country to hit that one billion mark. And they would say it with great pride, “One billion Chinese cannot be wrong.”

Do you look at that mentality? What are they saying? They are saying that everybody is doing this, a billion people – how can it be wrong? And that is what we also think. Because everybody is doing this, the media is full of it, the newspapers are full of it, our families, the entire society, the entire education system, the corporates, it’s happening everywhere, everybody is living in future, then we say, “Forget about one billion Chinese, seven billion people cannot be wrong. The entire population of earth is living this way, how can it be wrong?”

No, not really. You see, Truth does not depend upon the opinion of the majority. Does it? If the entire earth declares today that gravity is not 9.8 m/s^2 , it passes a resolution that we will have gravity at 11.8 m/s^2 , let all seven billion people, without exception, say this, would that have any difference upon gravity?

So, Truth is not really a democratic thing. Truth cannot be decided through votes or through majority’s opinions. Be not bothered, at all, with what

everybody is doing and saying. You are fully grown up now. Utilize your own intelligence and there is great fun in that, right? And such great freedom. And you would smile when you will really look at the world with your own eyes, you will really have good fun. I assure you. When you see all the stupidity going around, it's very-very funny. And you are standing outside of it. It's like watching a circus and all these jokers are performing their comic tricks, and you are watching it and you are smiling.

What do you want? To become a part of that pack of jokers or to watch it and have fun?

Watch it, have fun. Be here.

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~ Chapter 3 ~

Why do I keep repeating mistakes?

Question: Why do we keep repeating the same mistakes again and again?

Speaker: There must be some pleasure in repeating those mistakes. Otherwise, why would you want to do it again and again? It's just for namesake that you are calling it a 'mistake'. Actually, it is not a mistake at all for you. It is a pleasurable activity, may be even some kind of an accomplishment. Had it really been a mistake, would you have allowed it to be repeated?

It is just to keep a good social face, that we call it a 'mistake'. "Happened by mistake", we say. And now we are preparing for it to happen again.

(Sarcastically) "Such a nice mistake! May I be mistaken again and again?"

Look into this. Admit this. Do you really want to be free of mistakes? Do you really want that mistake to go away? After not waking up at five in the morning, when you wake up at eight, you say that you have made a mistake. But what were you saying at five o'clock? Was it a mistake at that time?

No. It was a decision. It was a decision; it was not a mistake at that time.

When is it a mistake - at eight o'clock or at five o'clock? At eight, it becomes a mistake. Because now you have to talk to yourself, and now you have to talk to the world, and now you have to somehow justify why you couldn't get up at five. So, now that act becomes a mistake. Was that actually a mistake? No, it was a very pleasurable thing at that time. "Just keep sleeping, great pleasure!"

To call a mistake, a ‘mistake’, is probably the only mistake. It is never a mistake. It is always a deliberate take.

That is why it is extremely important to be free of guilt. At eight, be a man! Have the guts to admit that, “I decided not to wake up.” And then like a man, take the consequences.

First of all, you regaled yourself with the pleasure of sleeping, right? At five, you gave yourself the pleasure of sleeping. And at eight, you want to give yourself the pleasure of feeling good about yourself.

(Sarcastically) “No, my intentions were pure. I actually wanted to get up. It was just a mistake.”

Now that you have had all the pleasure, just stand up and admit – “I decided to sleep. Now what is the punishment? I want to take it. It was not a mistake. I did it. And now whatever is the consequence, I must and I will bear it.” Take it. Don’t feel guilty.

You have had a hearty meal at the restaurant. Don’t you want to pay the bill? Don’t you want to do that? Now, like a man, pay the cheque. Why say – “O my god! It was a mistake. You know, I just wanted to have lemon soda. But instead of that I ended up having a four course dinner. It was a mistake you see. I never wanted to eat anything”?

(Laughter)

Just say- “I was the one who opted for pleasure, and I realize that pleasure comes with pain. So I will bear the pain now. In any case I don’t have a choice.” Having had the pleasure, pain is inevitable. So what is the point of running away?

Spirituality is not an insurance against paying bills. Most of us turn to spirituality after having had the dinner. And now when it comes to paying the bill, you want to be spiritual. Now you say – “Can I get rid of the consequences of my past actions?” No you can’t. Pay the bill.

Most people turn to Spirituality only for this reason. The past is full of rubbish and they are clinging to that rubbish. There are unfinished tasks, there are incomplete actions. There is a lot of carry-over, and you don’t want to get rid of it. You just want to escape from it.

Spirituality is not a refuge against paying the bill. I am repeating, whatever you did, you must now pay for it. Like a man, pay for it. But in paying for it, if you are conscious, if you realize that you are paying for it because of your own follies, then paying for it is less of a suffering.

What does Kabir say? “The intelligent one bears in understanding, the foolish one bears in suffering”.

You will have to pay for your mistakes. Now don’t cry. Pay smilingly. Why are you crying? Don’t even call it a ‘mistake’. Calling it a mistake is a form of crime. “I made a mistake. I did it. Being what I was, I had no option. I did it, and now I am bearing it.” The moment you are so honest and so clean, your emancipation starts. For the first time you are not making a mistake.

In calling the mistake a deliberate decision of what you are, you are now not making a mistake. Things now change. Something happens. Again, not that you won’t have to pay for it; you will still have to pay for it. But probably you won’t be crying anymore. And that is not a small relief. That’s a huge relief.

“Yes, I am paying for what I did, but I am not crying. I am standing up to it.”

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~ Chapter 4 ~

Why am I always thinking of the society?

Question: Why am I always thinking of the society?

Speaker: We give consideration to society because whatever we are doing is usually for the sake of society.

Listener: Sir, even in our personal actions, we include the society?

Speaker: Yes, what you call as your ‘personal’ actions, the horrible fact is that, even they are social actions. We may think that when we are alone in our house, let’s say, in the kitchen or in the study room, then whatever we are doing there, is a personal action. But it is not a personal action at all, because it is still being dictated by the society.

For example, there is a student who is in her study room preparing for an engineering entrance examination. But she is preparing just because of social pressure. Now is this preparation, is the moment of preparation when she is alone in her study, is this a personal action or a social action?

Listener: It is a social action.

Speaker: It is still a social action, even though the society does not appear to be present. The society is physically not present, but it is very much present. Where? In the mind. So even when we are doing something very personal, we are still guided by the society.

Marriage, you would say is something totally personal. Marriage and love are both called as ‘personal’. But are we not guided by the society in all these matters? So, are our marriages personal? Is our love personal? No, it is totally social. Society, religion, class, all these things are guiding even

our most private and intimate matters. And when our matters are all social, it is but obvious, that we will have to care for the society.

You look at all these matrimonial portals. People who want to marry put their profile there. When you put your profile and fill the profile form, it has sections for your religion, for your caste, for your gotra. It asks, “How much salary do you expect from your would-be spouse? What height, what kind of complexion? Whether he should be living in a joint family or a nuclear family?”

Now, are all these things not social? Did you decide your religion? Religion is a totally social thing which is handed over to you by the society, and now you allow religion to come in the way of your love. Is love then social or personal?

You are saying, “I will marry a boy of my gotra.” Now you didn’t decide your gotra. Did you? So, are you marrying the boy or is the gotra marrying the boy? Obviously, one gotra is marrying the other gotra. Where is any personal thing in this? It’s all social, you are not present in this. It’s a crowd.

Society has taught us what kind of features to look for in people. Now, because of years of colonization, in fact, decades of colonization, in India you have a great emphasis on fair skin. There are all these companies that sell fairness products in India. And believe me they cannot easily do that in any other country of the world. No country of the world is so mentally enslaved about complexion that you can sell a fairness cream, and people would also buy it.

Elsewhere, people will say, “It is fine that I am dark. Being dark is alright.” But you go on a date and you meet a boy who has very fair skin, you would

choose him. But it is not you who has chosen him, it is the society that has chosen him for you. So, it's not actually you who is dating him, an entire crowd is dating that boy. It may appear that two persons are meeting, but the two persons are not meeting, two crowds are meeting. Where are you in all this?

What we call as 'ourselves' is nothing but a crowd – mother, father, relatives and the entire world. Even when you say that I am doing something personal, the entire crowd is present. We are afraid of the society because we are not at all ourselves. We are just the society. What we need to ask is that is there anything that I am doing which is coming from my own free will? Is there anything that is arising out of understanding?

“Actions, thoughts, beliefs, which I consider as ‘normal’, are they really normal or are they just conditioned?” You generally say, “It's very normal to behave this way.” What is ‘normal’? Just because everybody is acting foolishly, foolishness becomes the norm. So what's so good about being normal?

Remember J.Krishnamurti's quote, “It's no measure of good health to be well adjusted to a profoundly sick society”.

“It's no measure of good health to be well-adjusted to a profoundly sick society,” but we are all very-very social and we take pride in that we are so well-adjusted. Have you not seen people who say, “I am a very social man”? He is actually saying, “I am a very sick man and I am proud about it.” He is actually saying, “I am a very sick man.”

When you will do something which is not social at all, believe me, in that moment you will not be afraid of the society. Whenever you will find something which is not social, which is not corrupted, which is entirely

yours, in that moment there will be no fear, in that moment you will be the most fearless person. Even the thought of others will not come to your mind.

Thought of others comes into our mind because the very action is for others, influenced by others and for the sake of others.

So, don't be puzzled when you find that you are afraid of the society all the time. It is obvious that it would happen. A slave will all the time be afraid of the master. Till the time you are a slave, you are bound to be afraid.

And in the moment when you are not a slave, you will not even ask this question because when there is no fear, then there is no question to ask.

Think of these terms that you said, 'personal', 'individual'. Think of what you call as the most central element of your life and ask yourself, "Is this really individual or is this a product of society and social influences?" Let us say, 'Education'. Have you really asked yourself, "Why am I studying here?" Have you really asked yourself, "Where will I go from here? What is the source of all my plans? Why do I want to pursue a post graduate degree?"

Employment, work, job, money! Have you asked yourself, "Why is money important and to what extent is money important? What is money?" The society has told you that money is important and is important to this and that extent, and you keep running after it.

You spend your individual life in a pursuit of a social goal. Is that not stupid? You are spending your individual life pursuing a social goal, a goal given by the society.

Whose life is it? “Mine.” Whose goals are they? “Society’s”. Is that not a wastage of life? Your life is spent in pursuing a goal given by others. Whose life is being wasted? “My own life.”

Have you asked yourself, “What is the meaning of work? What is the relation of work to life? Why must one work? What is the relation of work to money?”

Have you asked yourself, “What is employment? What is meant by one man serving the needs of other? What is meant by one man accepting a salary from another?”

Have you asked these questions? You all are adults.

Have you asked yourself, “What is meant by love? What is sex? What is body? What is marriage? What is reproduction? What is family?” Have you ever asked these questions?

No. And you will blindly move into them because the entire society blindly moves into them. A particular age and you are fit for marriage, and you must have a family. Do you ask yourself, “What is all this? This one body, what am I doing with it? This one life, what am I doing with it?” But the society has clearly laid down the norms and you will follow those norms.

When you are following the norms given by the society, obviously you will be afraid of the society, because the society has now become your master.

Have you asked yourself, “What is meant by settling down? What is meant by the so-called good life where you have a car, an apartment, two kids, a nice job and a particular reputation?” What is meant by all these?

Have you asked, “What is religion?” You go and celebrate festivals. Would you ask yourself, “What is religion? Why am I following a certain religion? What is meant by following a religion? Is religion individual or social?”

Religion must be totally individual, but the religion that we follow is completely social. Even our God is a social god that the society has given us. Have you found out God? No. But you are blindly following certain scriptures that the society handed over to you, a social God. It’s like I am sitting over here, all of you dream up a God, make certain pictures, create certain stories and then come to me and say, “This is God. Start believing in this and live your life according to this.”

When everything is social, when every breath is social, why wonder that why am I afraid of the society? You will continue to be afraid till the time you don’t let intelligence function.

Let intelligence function and then there will be no fear.

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~ Chapter 5 ~

How do I get rid of my restlessness?

Question: Restlessness doesn't really leave me. Why am I so restless? How can I get rid of my restlessness?

Speaker: Cars these days come with the auto-pilot feature. You can put the car on the cruise mode, especially on long drives, and the driver can relax. There was a research conducted on the vehicles that have this auto-drive feature. It was found out that people who buy cars having this facility do not really use it. Because this facility takes away from them the sense of being the driver. The sense of, "I am the one who is driving," this car takes that away.

Now, you have set the speed of the car to sixty kilometers per hour, and the car is cruising. And all your pleasure of increasing the speed from sixty to fifty then seventy, for no reason, that is gone. You cannot do anything. And those cars are more expensive than the normal, manual cars. People pay extra money to get that facility, and then they don't use that feature. Why? Because there is a restlessness, something needs to be done.

(Sarcastically) How can the two feet just stay calm, resting on the floor of the vehicle? They are not being used properly. "God has given two legs, one for the accelerator and the other for the clutch. How can I let them go waste?" So, something needs to be done. Similarly the fingers are there. They must do something. So, what does the restless mind say? "Give me the remote control. Some button have to be pressed. Otherwise the fingers are going waste! What is the point in having fingers if they are not doing something?"

“What is the point in having a throat and a tongue and lips?” Something has to be said. If you have not said something for five minutes, then you have wasted your throat and tongue for five minutes. Will these five minutes come back? Such a sin! It’s like having rented something and not using it. You are paying the total rent and letting the thing go waste. How can you let your throat remain unproductive? So, you must gossip about something.

Same with the mind! “How can the mind remain unproductive? The factory must continue to produce goods.” So, thoughts must keep coming and going. The circulation must continue. Otherwise the asset is lying idle. “I have an asset and it is not producing anything.”

“Fingers are not playing with the remote, or any other thing. Legs are not pressing the accelerator. Mind is not thinking, and calculating, and manipulating. All my assets have gone to disuse. Let me do something. Let me do something.”

“What is this body for? Look at the function of each part and exploit it to the maximum. The tongue is for tasting. So, give it all the tastes that it can have. The abdomen is for digesting and assimilation. So, let it digest everything and assimilate everything that can go down my throat. Lizards, dogs, dinosaurs, aliens whatever I can lay my hands on I will eat. Plastics, stones, nails, bangles, body parts – I will eat.”

“What is the use of having these organs of procreation in the body? Two days without ejaculation. Oh my God! My asset is going unproductive. What is the point? The uterus is there to produce babies.” And women of old days, they were always pregnant. Not even for one month would they allow their machine to remain idle, one baby after the other. There would be households where a couple would have twenty kids, of which only two

would remain alive. Obviously when you have twenty, only two would be left alive.

All this is nothing, but a gnawing feeling, a perpetual threat to your existence. You keep feeling as if time is slipping away, as if you are losing out on something. You cannot be blamed for feeling that way because you hope that in the end something is possible, which will not slip away.

Your mistake lies in not recognizing that there is nothing that will not slip away. Everything will slip away. So, there is no point in trying to clutch anything. There is no point in feeling restless.

Restlessness lives on the promise of an eventual rest, that, “Eventually I will get rest somewhere.” There is no eventual rest. When you recognize this then restlessness cannot stand on its own. You understand this? You will not get any rest, anywhere, at any point in time. When you see this, then you enter into rest right now!

Do you get this? There is no great future waiting for you. Nothing golden is going to happen to you at some time. Nothing! Absolutely nothing! **This is it.** If you are an idiot right now, an idiot is what you are, and no wisdom is waiting for you in the future. If you are lonely right now, lonely is what you are, and no great company is waiting for you in the future.

You have nothing except what you think you have right now. This is it! Come to terms with it. Make peace with it.

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~ Chapter 6 ~

This futile search for happiness

Questioner: Sir, at every point in our life, we want to get rid of the burdens of our life, and become happy but that point doesn't ever come. How to achieve true happiness in our life?

Speaker: Now that you have realized that happiness hardly ever comes by wanting to be happy, the obvious thing is to not to want to be happy. For so long, we all have wanted to be happy, tried to be happy, without being happy.

It has been years, years and decades that you have been wanting to be happy, trying to be happy, trying to achieve happiness, and planning for happiness and none of that seems to be working – not for you, not for me, not for anybody else. So obviously, this ought to be futile. Drop it, don't follow it. Don't want to be happy. Not sure?

Recall your moments of ecstasy, when you were so joyful that you had forgotten everything else. Recall those moments. In those moments, were you still trying to be happy? In those moments, were you planning about the next day?

Who plans for happiness? The one who is not happy. What is happening is that, in planning for happiness, you are constantly telling yourself, "I am not happy". In constantly looking at a great future, you are telling yourself that there is something wrong with this day, this moment. When you are constantly telling yourself, "I am not happy right now, there is something wrong with this day", then what is happening? You will always end up

finding something wrong with this day. You will always end up finding some reason to be unhappy.

The one who is happy, is just happy. He does not want to be happy. He is just happy.

What is this business of ‘wanting’? What is this business having a ten-point charter of happiness?

“How to be happy?”

Step 1: Run.

Step 2: Climb the stairs...

What is all this?

Happiness is happiness. What prevents you to be happy right now? Challenge it. What prevents your happiness every moment? Ambitions, notions, beliefs about happiness, prevent you from being happy. If you have told yourself, “I will have the right to be happy only when I attain that dream job,” then you have condemned yourself to live in sorrow till you get that job. Is that not what we keep doing? Is that not what parents keep telling their children? “You will be worthy, and sometimes even worthy of love, only when you will get that particular result.” And that result is always in future.

By telling someone that you will be good enough, you will be lovable, only if you turn out in a particular way, you are telling him that you are not alright as you are right now. You are giving the child a deep inferiority complex. You are telling the child, “Unless you win the race, you are worthless. You don’t even deserve our love. Even our love is not

unconditional. Go ahead, become something. Only then you will get our love. Only then you will get respect.”

You have taken that all that in. These same notions have been internalized by you. You constantly tell yourself that happiness is a goal. You have told yourself that happiness is a goal in the distant future. You have told yourself that only achievers have the right to be happy. You have put a condition in front of yourself, “I will be happy on that particular beautiful, special day.” But that special day never comes. So, when will you be happy?

Stop trying to be happy. Stop wanting happiness. That special happy day will never come. That special day is either right now, today or never.

A desire of happiness is the sure shot recipe for unhappiness. The desire of happiness certainly leads to unhappiness. It comes from unhappiness, and it furthers unhappiness.

You are young and you are lucky that nothing is missing from your life. You are born in the information age. The weather outside is beautiful. What prevents you from celebrating? What prevents you from being alive to everything? Even when you walk down the corridors, what prevents you from bearing a faint smile? You are sitting over here, it is neither very hot nor cold here. Everything is alright. What prevents you from taking this as a festival? Every moment is worthy of celebration. Why can't it be that way?

The existential party is on twenty-four hours. It does not start at any particular time. It is continuously on twenty-four hours - the party of existence. What prevents you from enjoying that party? You are invited. You are always invited. Go ahead and enjoy the party.

Do not become a sulking kid who is always waiting outside the party lawns. Everything is dancing, enjoying. The entire existence is rapturous, and the child is waiting outside and saying, “I am not yet worthy of entering this party. I will enter this party only when I become something. I am not allowed to enter.”

You are allowed to enter. It is a party of happiness. You are invited. Come in. But you want to be happy. You won’t be happy, right?

You want love, you will not be in love. You want freedom, you won’t be free. It is such a nice escape. “You know what? I am trying to be free. You know what? I am planning love.” Good wonderful, keep planning.

Do not plan happiness. Do not strive to be happy. Just be happy.

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~ Chapter 7 ~

Observe your own life, and you will know the Truth

Speaker: The first requirement of living intelligently is to close the mind from the external occupations, to ask it to find out its own truth.

What are you doing?

Why are you so noisy?

Why are you always so bored?

Why are you confused and frustrated?

What is the quality of your decisions?

What is quality of your relationships?

Why are you so often afraid?

Why are you so insecure?

Why are you always looking for the company?

Why you can't be alone with yourself?

That's what an intelligent mind does. It asks itself what is happening.

Why are you so keen on gossiping?

Why does silence scare you?

Why can't you listen?

When you look at the future, why do you either see fear or hope?

Can't you stay in this moment?

Have you ever loved?

Do you understand living?

Ask these questions to the mind. These questions are not from the outside, these questions are from your daily life.

If you are not totally sleeping, if you are not an escapist, a coward who wants to run from himself, you confront yourself. You ask yourself, "Is this what I am doing from morning till evening, in the classroom, in the office, on the road? Why do I always want entertainment? Why am I so keen to get entertainment?"

As an intelligent mind does, it would come to see that to ask for entertainment, it keeps feeling bored all the time, that it is never present in the moment, it is missing life.

Life is here and now. Your own daily life is what you must observe, not my life, not somebody else's life. If it is your life that you are observing, not a dictated life, then the questions that would come to you would be really authentic.

How do I feel?

What is core thing about all this?

Why I am often lost?

The moment I see my dependencies being taken away, why do I get scared?

Why do I always want to belong to a community?’

These are the questions that I must ask. “Why do I study only when the examinations approach? That means I have no love for what I am doing.” You have taken this as a regular routine of your life. You have understood that life is like this only. Can we look at it honestly, intelligently?

(One of the listeners raises his hand)

If you are raising your hand, if your hand is still up, it means that you are not listening. You are not sharp enough to see that you are not listening.

My own life, my one single precious life - observe it. Observe it just like you observe in science, without interfering, unbiased, unmotivated. Just observe what is happening, what is this whole drama about. You deserve to understand. It is your obligation towards yourself to understand.

You have a life to live. You deserve to understand. Only then there is good fun in life. Real joy!

All that you know right now is a little bit of pleasure, which amounts to nothing. That joy of freedom, that vitality, you can know only with that intelligence. You deserve that. It’s your birthright in some sense. Don’t deny yourself of that.

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~ **Mind and Thoughts** ~

*“The meditative mind
knows all that is essential.”*

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~ Chapter 1 ~

Why should I understand the mind?

Question: What is the need to differentiate between the self and the mind?

Speaker: To make it easier for you to understand, I will rephrase the question for you.

What is the need at all to understand the real Self?

Only by going through this process will the distinction come that the mind may not be the real Self. Ultimately his question is, “Why must I know myself? What is the need of self-inquiry? Life is going on pleasantly, nicely. There seem no hiccups. I have a self-routine. I have my normal spectrum of pains and pleasures, and I am cruising along. So why must I find all these things - the self, and the mechanic of the things? Why must I understand them at all?”

Why must we understand all this? Because all this is the process of understanding, and in this process of understanding, we come across this distinction - there is the mind and that mind may not be ‘me’. Let us see. How many of us young, free, men and women want to live a life of slavery? Hardly anybody. Who is the slave? Whom do we call as slave? A slave is someone who has no free-will of his own. His actions happen due to the influence of others. This is what a slave is. Simple, that’s a slave. Now let us understand the way in which we function.

What is the way in which our mind functions? This brain, the human brain is the product of millions of years of evolution. It is nothing but the journey it has travelled, the journey that it has undertaken. It is nothing but a collection of all the experiences which have happened during the course of

its journey. It knows nothing but all that it has gathered in the journey, during the past. It is in that sense nothing but a database of experiences, and also a program that has been told how to deal with that database. It is very mechanical in nature. You don't have to ask it to do certain things. It keeps on doing all those things. It does not ask for your sanctions or for your free-will. It operates on its own basic functions of the body, our basic reactions. Not only that, it operates in the basic way, in which we perceive the world.

You perceive space to be a three-dimensional thing not because it is in three dimensions. It is because the brain is configured to perceive a three-dimensional reality. You live your life in time not because there is an independent, objective Truth called 'time' but because your brain is configured to read time, just as the compiler of a computer system is configured to read a particular language. That is how the body operates. The brain is the part of the body. That is how the brain makes the sense of the body. The brain has been pre-programmed and the body too has been pre-programmed which is called as physical conditioning. In physical conditioning, surely as an intelligent student you would see, there is no free-will involved. The brain already knows what to do. Are you getting it?

There is another conditioning which is called as the social conditioning. Physical conditioning is the hardware that you are carrying, social conditioning is the additional and multiple layers of the software that has been layered upon it. The social conditioning includes all your beliefs which you have attained from your culture since childhood, tradition, language and lot of other things. The entire accumulation of thoughts is social conditioning.

Wherever there is conditioning, there will be no free-will and the absence of free-will is nothing but slavery. Right? A very unfortunate event that can

take place with every human being and does take place with most of us is, that we do not realize how deeply we are conditioned. We start identifying with our conditioning. Freedom from slavery is not at all possible, unless you look at the process of the mind and realize that you are not acting on free-will and intelligence.

“I am acting in a programmed way”, and the moment you realize that, in that moment you are free from it. We don’t realize it. To not to realize it is to waste life altogether, because there is no great fun in living a slave’s life. Are you getting it?

This mind is two things. One, the conditioned part which you can give a general name as ‘the brain’. And second, ‘the conditioning’. This mind is the brain which carries all the conditioning, and the intelligence. The brain is thoroughly conditioned. But you are not merely the brain, there is something more to you.

And when you discover that, the quality of your life totally changes. Your day-to-day living, the kind of decisions that you are taking, all that totally changes. There is now a brilliance about it, there is now energy about it. You are not stupid anymore. You are not merely a machine anymore. Are you getting it?

Hence it is important to understand how the machine functions, and how we are little more than that machine. That being little more is what makes life valuable, otherwise you go on leading a conditioned life. The script has been written by the external forces such as parents, society, education, and you start believing that you are taking those decisions without having the sense to understand that none of it is yours really, that you are merely a

puppet who is just enacting a pre-decided role, whose life is entirely predictable.

There is no fun in that, there is no energy in that, there is no vitality, and there is no youthfulness in that.

We deserve better than that. We deserve more than that. Hence, it is important to understand the difference between a conditioned life and an intelligent life.

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~ Chapter 2 ~

Why is my mind caught in petty issues?

Question: Why are most of the people concerned about their own problems? Why are they not concerned about the problems of humanity?

Speaker: One cannot look at this and that, when there is so much happening in my own house. There is a civil war going on right where I am standing. How can I be bothered about this and that? How can I be bothered about how many animals are dying in the forests, how many species are being eliminated every day, how the global temperature is rising due to climate change? How can I be concerned about them when I am locked in my petty issues?

Listener 1: But there may be bigger issues.

Speaker: There might be bigger issues, but for me the biggest issue is, “My wife is seeing somebody else these days”. That is because my ego is so petty.

Listener 1: Why does the [ego](#) exist?

Speaker: Yes! Good. That’s the question you should ask yourself, that why does the ego exist at all. Ask yourself that why does it exist at all. Till the time ego is there, you will have petty issues in your life. You will have only petty issues in your life.

Listener 1: But this may be the case with only fifty percent of the population. What about the rest fifty percent?

Speaker: Fifty percent is an impossibly large proportion. I am talking of point five percent. We don’t have even that many. Fifty percent would be

God's dream, God's impossible dream. Even God cannot make fifty percent people realize the Truth. I am talking of one in five thousand.

Listener 2: We say that we should be the light bulb. We should be the 'light unto himself'...

Speaker: 'Shoulds' don't work in life. You might say that I should be a light bulb. Where is the light?

You are right. Wonderful! It is a very, very nice image to think of. But just thinking, will that suffice? I will be a light bulb. I will be a search light. It's a beautiful thing to think of. But mere thinking would not do.

It is a good idea. But that's what it is, just an idea. You know what, when the British attacked Lucknow, the city of Lucknow, the ruler there, Wajid Ali Shah, was busy playing chess. His generals stood in front of him and said, "Give us the orders to march. Give us the orders to face the British." The fellow said, "Wait. I cannot afford to lose this game."

How can you fight the bigger battles of life when you are engrossed in the imaginary battles? How can you fight the bigger battles? The real problem, how can you look at it when imaginary ones are so heavy upon you?

So what did the British do? When they captured the Nawab, they carried a procession of him through the streets of Lucknow, like a caged animal. So there was a vehicle on which his cage was kept, and that cage was provided with all the amenities, a very nice and soft mattress, pillows of the best kind and a huge chess square was kept for the Nawab. That's our situation.

We are captured, we are in a jail but our chess piece is entertaining us. That's the purpose of entertainment in life, so that we do not look at the jail we are in. You are in a jail but that chess board is so attractive, that you are

busy with your pawns and horses. “My horse is threatening your King.” That’s the real thing. The world is collapsing around you, you can’t even see that. For you the greatest issue is, “Mr. Verma’s son got two marks more than my son.” If this is the situation, then how can you be bothered that the glaciers are melting? How can you be bothered that the humanity is probably going to be eliminated in next few decades? How can you be bothered? “How is my hair looking?” That’s the biggest issue for you. “What comment did he post on my Facebook status?” That’s the greatest issue of your life. How does it matter to you that there is so much of stockpile with man today that he can destroy the earth a thousand times? For you the greatest issue is, “Is this shade nice?”

What kind of [life](#) do you want to live? I am asking you this. I am repeating. Do you want to live a life of that kind where the issues in your life are like this? You know, you visit one of these popular news sites. What are the greatest issues that they are telling you? ‘Ten wardrobe malfunctions that you did not see!’ Then you go and click there. That’s the heading, that’s the link. ‘Ten wardrobe malfunctions that you did not see.’ ‘Ten actresses without makeup.’ These are the biggest issues you must know.

They are your real teachers. They are telling you ten things that you must know. Who are they to educate you? But you allow yourselves to be educated by them. And then they become the real issues in your life. “Oh! Ten things that I must know. Ten new fashion trends this summer.” And girls quickly click. “So what is happening? Last time the in colour was purple green, this time it is jasmine green. So, if you are wearing purple green, then you are so outdated, so old. Go and buy jasmine green.” Now she is comparing purple green and jasmine green. I don’t know how their eyes differentiate between these wavelengths. And these are the teachers

who are trying to educate you about what are the real issues in life. ‘Ten fancy bikes worth having.’ So M.S. Dhoni is riding one, John Abraham is riding another, Robert Vadra is riding the third one, and you are looking at them. Your eyes are now glued to the screen.

These are the real issues in life. ‘Ten great things to do just after your marriage.’ He has already decided that marriage is great and that you must marry. You can’t even see that somebody is imposing. It is so subtle, it is so damn subtle that you can’t even see. ‘Ten kinds of new bridal makeup.’ The assumption is that you will definitely become a bride. You don’t even see that you are being educated. ‘Ten things never to reveal to your boss.’ You are being educated constantly. These are the real issues. “Should I tell my wife about my ex?” What to hide, what to disclose? Such a great issue!

Now how does it matter that the Blue Whale is disappearing? The Blue Whale has no place in your consciousness. How does it matter that a few islands have already been lost, the rising ocean level has already submerged them. How does it matter? You are busy thinking about your wife and your ex. That’s the real issue. “How to have good sex at the workplace without being caught?” That’s the real issue.

Look at the way you people gossip. Ask yourselves honestly, “What are the issues that we keep gossiping about?” Are you thinking about the disappearing female child? Many states in India have a sex-ratio of close to 800 at birth. Mass female genocide is happening. Do you ever talk to each other about this? What do you talk about? What do you talk about when you meet somebody? “Hey, you look nice! How do I look?”, “I’m bunking the class, aren’t you?”

Tell me. Does it matter to you that the ground water has been so badly polluted, especially in Indian states like Punjab, that there is one train which goes from Bhatinda to Bikaner which is called ‘Cancer Express’. Does it matter to you? Do you ever talk about that?

What do you talk about? “I’ll humiliate you”, that’s what your mind is full of. The hills are being denuded. The rivers are just filthy streams now. Does that matter to you?

Do you know about the plight of the girl child? Have you paid any attention to it? But you will pay all your [attention](#) to all the rubbish that is there on the T.V. You will know everything about new movie releases. You will know every bit of all the gossip that is going around. Do you know what is going on in the Middle East? Do you know that Africa is burning?

After this session, when you go out, look at all your batch mates, and remember that they are all adults, matured adults. Observe the subjects of their discussions. See what they are talking about, and then have pity on them. Go to the canteen and see the kind of rubbish that’s going around. Do you want to live that kind of a life, where the real important issue is whether the maid will turn up today or not?

Jealousy, trivia, pettiness, that is what the life of the normal man is, absolutely wasted life. Do you want to live like that? Do you really want to live like this? Try to be a little silent and see what is going around, and suddenly something will open up in the mind. Suddenly something will open up. You will not be the same person anymore. That canteen of yours is such a wonderful place. It’s a great observatory. Whenever I visit your campus, I sit there. I make it a point to sit there every time I come so that I know the kind of audience I am dealing with.

Listener 2: Sir, they will get settled. They will change.

Speaker: What do you mean by settled? This is the settlement. They will not go beyond this. Today they are gossiping, tomorrow they are gossiping, right on their deathbed they will be gossiping.

Listener 3: We shouldn't lose hope.

Speaker: Had I lost hope, why would I be sitting in front of you? It is not hope. It is your real nature that I am invoking. I don't have any hopes. I am just asking you, *"Is it necessary to live this way?"*

There is something within you that has just come into life. It will die very soon. You will go back to the same crowd. In fact many of you will laugh at each other. You will tell each other that, "You know, for that one hour, somebody made a fool of us."

If you want to be a part of the crowd, be a part just as these lights are a part of this room. They illuminate this room.

If you are with them, be with them as an illuminating influence, not as a participant in their darkness.

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~ Chapter 3 ~

Attention and Concentration

Listener 1: Sir, can I be in attention even when the mind is distracted? Does attention also depend on whether I am loving the thing that I am doing or not?

Speaker: Prashant, attention is a quality of the mind. Attention is the deep desire of the mind to understand. Understanding means settling down, becoming quiet.

Attention arises when the mind says that the ripples created by objects in mind must settle down. These objects could be:

1. A TV program
2. Two people and their chatter
3. The disquiet of the mind itself

However, remember that there is a difference between attention and concentration.

In attention, there is no specific object. Attention is the quality of the mind in which it is alert to everything, including itself. Hence, whatever is in its purview it is its object. Alternately, there is no specific object. Alternately, the mind itself is its own object.

In concentration, there is a process of ego-based choices involved. Concentration is fragmentary. Concentration is upon a specific object that the ego has chosen for its benefit. Concentration does not give understanding; it only gives pleasure and satisfaction.

Listener 2: Concentration does not give understanding; it only gives pleasure and satisfaction.

Question a - Can I say that understanding does not result in any feeling (of say pleasure or satisfaction)? It is just understanding?

Question b - In other words, can I say that if I am left with satisfaction then I was concentrating rather than being attentive/meditative?

Speaker: Amit,

1. Understanding results in a cessation of tension. That is the only 'feeling' it gives.
2. Yes, satisfaction is always motive-driven. If there is satisfaction, there is bound to be the (apparent) fulfillment of some desire.

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~ Chapter 4 ~

To know the past, stand separate from the past

Question: Sir, is the past helpful in differentiating between 'good' and 'bad'? Why should we look into our past?

Speaker: You need to understand it quite subtly. No, there is obviously no need to delete the past. There is no need to absolutely get rid of the past. No, I would never advise that. No sane man would ever advise that.

But sitting over here, who would look at the past? You. For me to look at you, I must be separate from you. Is that not a pre-condition? For me to look at you, I must be a little away from you.

Let us do a little experiment. Try to look at your palm. Now, keep bringing the palm closer to your eyes (*taking the palm closer to eyes*).

Are you able to still look at it? Look at it. Now keep bringing it closer, closer, and closer still. Aaah! Even to look at the palm, you must be at a distance from the palm.

So when you say that I want to look at the past, even to look at the past, you must first be...? You must first be...?

Listeners (everyone): At a distance from the past.

Speaker: A little separated from the past. Or is it so that the past itself will look at the past? If you are totally identified with the past, you will never be able to look at the past.

Listener 1: Because you are living.

Speaker: Right. You are the past. Your entire mind is filled with the past. Even to look at the past, you must stand detached from the past. You understand detachment? Otherwise there is no question of looking at the past, drawing any knowledge out of it. That would not happen.

The situation of most of mankind is that it wants to look at the past while being greatly attached to the past. No, this is impossible. You cannot be attached, yet observant. No observation is possible in attachment. When you are attached, you are de-facto the past itself, you are nothing but a bundle of memories. Now this past has no capacity for honest and free observation. It has no capacity at all.

So, we are not saying that erase all your memories. What we are saying is see that as you are today, right now, you are not a product of the past. And then look at it, as if it is available like a database. But even a good computer, and all of us are better than computers, even a good computer knows exactly when to access its memory and when not to. You may have three or four drives, full of TB's of data attached to the computer but it will not keep accessing the data all the time, it will leave the data free. Even the machine is smart enough to know when to use the data. It is not attached to it, there is no compulsive clinging.

But look at our lives, how we cling to the past. We do not know ourselves. All we know of ourselves is in relation to the past. And we know the world in the same way. We do not even look at the people closest to us honestly. We look at them only through the eyes of the past. Our friends, family members, parents, we have already given them labels according to the past and those labels are all that we see.

Now how can you ever see? How can you ever see? We do not know the individual that the father is or that the mother is. We do not know, we only know the label, and that label is coming from the past now there is a problem, there is a great problem. Now you are living in imaginations, and life will hurt now.

Because the fact of life is not available to you, life will hurt you. You would be struggling. You will be meeting resistance at every step and you will keep wondering that why is life so harsh upon me, because you are not opening your eyes.

The stone is here, right now, in front of you (*indicating an imaginary stone through his hands*), but your eyes are full of the dreams of yesterday. So, the simple stone becomes a huge stumbling block and you fall down and hurt yourself. And that is what our situation is. We are hurt, tremendously hurt. If you look at your mind, it is nothing but an aching mass of hurt. So easily we are hurt! All of us are carrying so many grudges and complaints and hurt within us. This is the reason.

Life is not some determined villain, out to hurt you, to give you pain. It is our own stupidities that put us in suffering. No, there is no need to not to ever look at the past or even the future. Fearlessly look at the past, and fearlessly look at the future, but mind you 'fearlessly'. You cannot be fearless when you are attached. Do read your history books, do look at your family albums, do project the future, but be centred in the present.

“Even when I am forecasting the future, I realize clearly and deeply that I am seated in the present. No memory of the past, no hope of the future can sweep me off my feet. I am not a day-dreamer. Yes, I can project. There

is a trend that I can project well. This is the probability of this event happening in the future.”

Alright, do that. Wonderful! But do not let your mind be carried away by that. Do not start identifying yourself with that.

Yes, something did happen in the past, but past is past- gone, dead, buried. Past is past. And even when the memory of the past is coming to me, then that realization must always be there, that even this thinker must be seated in the present. This present is always all important, always all important. It is unchanging. Time keeps rushing about this present but this present never changes.

You be seated there and seated there, fearlessly. Fearlessly and randomly wander wherever you want to go, there is no limitation, there is absolute freedom. You want to go to the past, go. You want take a little walk into the future, welcome. But make sure that your center is at the present. Don't forget your center.

The mistake that we make is that we forget the center, we forget who we are. We just forget who we are!

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~ Chapter 5 ~

What is emotion?

Question: How can we control our emotions?

Speaker: How can you control something that you do not quite understand? Our friend here is controlling the operations of this camera. How is he able to control the operations? Because he understands the functioning, he knows what leads to what, he knows when to pull the lever, he knows when to press a button; he knows all these things. To control anything, you need to understand. In fact, once you have understood then you don't even have the need to control.

Do you understand what emotions are? We get emotional quite often, but have we reflected, have we bothered to ask what is this thing called emotion?

What is emotion?

Listener 1: Emotions are those small activities which affect us in a great sense.

Speaker: Alright! Understand this. You may be sitting here and there may be some kind of irritation in the mind, but you are sitting silently. That irritation is not showing up in your body or upon your face. The irritation increases, the mind becomes more disturbed. What will start happening? What will start happening?

You will start fidgeting a little; you will start looking here and there. Your body will become restless. After sometime, the irritation increases even further and it becomes anger. Now what will happen? Your face will change

a little. Your eyes will change a little. What you call as the pupil of the eyes will become a little dilated. And if the anger increases a little more in the mind, as the irritation is a thought, then your body will start shivering, your cheek will get red, and you may even get violent. Then people will say that he has become emotional.

What is emotion?

Emotion is just thought - 'thought' that has become severe, intense; 'thought' that has gathered a lot of energy. Lot of energy is stored in the subconscious, thoughts usually remain at the surface level. But when the thought becomes intense, then it gets connected to the energy of the subconscious.

You can leave all that aside. You can just understand that intense thought is called emotion.

There is nothing special about emotion. There is nothing sacred about emotion. Emotion is thought. When the thought becomes powerful, it starts having an impact upon the body and then you say that I have become emotional. Till the time it is just a thought, its effect on the body cannot be seen, but when the same thought becomes intense then the whole body expresses that thought and that expression is called 'Emotion.'

For a little bit of sadness you do not weep, but more sad thoughts come and then what happens, tears start flowing. Then you say that, "I have become emotional". But what happens is we give undue regards to emotions. We feel as if emotions are very special. No, emotions are just an expression of your conditioning. Just as thoughts arise from conditioning, so do emotions. Emotions too are an expression of your conditioning.

But that's not the way we look at it. When somebody is saying something to us, let us say someone says, "Kindly give me 500 rupees", we may not accept the request. But if the same person says with tears, then we are likely to give the 500 rupees. Why? Because we think that emotions are true, we think emotions are special, we think that emotions must be respected, but there is nothing special in emotions.

Emotion is thought. And all thought is conditioning. Thought comes from outside. You have acquired it. Similarly, emotions are acquired. That is why one person weeps at X and the other weeps at Y.

So, do not ask, "What to do with emotions?" Rather ask, "How do I look at my conditioning?", because your emotions are just an expression of your conditioning.

And how do I look at my conditioning? From morning till evening whatever you do, whatever you say, whatever you think, if you pay attention to it that is the only way to discover your conditioning. And as you discover your conditioning, your conditioning subsides. It will no more have the same power. And you will find that you are gaining sensitivity.

When conditioning comes down, when the mind becomes light, free and clean, then you become progressively less emotional; less emotional but more sensitive. Small things will touch you. You would start knowing, experiencing what you would have never experienced earlier. It will be a very fresh thing that would now be happening to you.

Emotions are stale. You already know what will make you angry. Don't we all have our pain points? You already know that if I say this kind of a statement to you, you will become angry. So emotions are conditioned,

emotions are stale. If someone comes and says that you are looking beautiful, you will become happy.

So, all emotions are pre-programmed. You already know what makes you happy. You already know that if you receive that kind of SMS, you will start crying. It is certain that if a message in such and such words comes to you, you will start crying. So there is nothing in emotions. All emotions are conditioned, pre-programmed and acquired.

Sensitivity is an altogether different thing. Sensitivity means to be open to new and fresh. Like looking at a sunrise for the first time, like splashing fresh, cool water on your face in the morning, that is sensitivity, that fresh experience. And that is not being emotional, that is not a sentiment.

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~ Chapter 6 ~

To manage time, see what your mind values

Question: Sir, how to utilize time?

Speaker: Who will utilize time? Who wastes time?

Listener: Myself.

Speaker: So, to whom should the question be directed? Or should we talk about time? What do you waste? Do you waste time, or do you also waste resources? You also waste life and you waste everything that comes to you. Somebody who is wasteful, would he waste only time or would he waste a lot of other things as well? So, is time the real issue or is it 'me' that I should to talk about? What should I talk about?

When you ask that how to utilize time, you have made a very arrogant assumption. Your assumption is – “Everything is alright with me, it is just this small aspect of time utilization that I falter in. Everything else is good”.

It is like this that there is something wrong with my entire physical system, my blood, my very blood has a lot of impurities and because of this there are a lot of symptoms that are showing up in my body: my heart is under-pressure, my kidneys are not functioning well, my liver is enlarged, I keep feeling sleepy, I keep forgetting, my brain doesn't function properly, the blood is impure, there are few pimples on my face. I go to the doctor and say, “Sir, my problem is that I have a few pimples on my face.”

Now, am I wise when I say that the pimple is my problem? Is my problem only that I have pimples? What is my problem? My entire being is my problem. My very blood is my problem, right? But what am I focusing on?

Pimples! Now the doctor can give you a cream that will remove the pimples. Will that solve your problem? This pimple gone, another pimple will come up. Right or Wrong? Have you not seen that happen? It clears from here and comes somewhere else or sometimes at the same spot.

We don't even know what the real issue is. It is not about time at all. Don't ask that "How to manage time?" Don't ask that, "How to utilize time?" Ask yourself, 'How do I manage myself'? Because it is the self that is wasting the time. It is the self that is wasting everything that is around it.

There are thousand opportunities that come to you. Life itself is a grand opportunity, but the self is squandering all the opportunities. Not only time, everything else as well. So, we will go to the more basic question, to the more useful question, and that is how to manage the mind, because it is the mind that wastes time. We will forget time. Nobody can manage time. Time just flows, time cannot be managed. What can be managed? The Self, my own mind that needs to be managed. We will look at that.

You need to then ask yourself, "What does my mind find attractive?" What does your mind do most of the time? There are twenty-four hours in the day for everybody. Ask yourself that where do these twenty-four hours go. Where does my mind spend these twenty-four hours in? When you will look at this, you will come across your values. You will come to know what it is that is preferred in life.

Because whatever you prefer in life is where you spend your time.

If you have told yourself that the biggest pleasure in life is sleeping, then don't be surprised if you find that you sleep eleven hours a day. "Why do I sleep eleven hours a day? Because I have thoroughly convinced myself that sleeping is the highest happiness."

Similarly, if you have convinced yourself that roaming around here and there is the biggest pleasure that is possible, then don't be surprised if you spend four hours gossiping, because you have told that to your own mind.

We are looking at the mind now, right? We have kept time behind; we are looking at the mind. We said that we will find out how we spend our time. And when we find that out, we immediately come upon our values. "What have I told myself to be valuable?" Whatever you have told yourself to be valuable you will find that your time is going there.

Let me ask this to you- to how many of you this happens that you want to find time for doing something but unable to find time for it? With how many of you do this happen?

(Some listeners raise their hands).

Please be assured that somewhere you are convinced that the thing for which you cannot find time, that thing is not important. It is embedded deep in your psyche that it is not important. So, howsoever much you try, you will still find no time. Had it really been important, had you been careful enough to really examine and see its importance, time would have made itself available, because there are twenty-four hours in a day for everybody.

How is it possible that somebody finds time and somebody does not find time? You are the one who is allotting time and you allot the time according to your values. It is a question of values.

What do you find valuable? "I find it deeply valuable that one must sit with the family and watch television." So, don't be surprised if three hours a day you are doing that. "My definition of valuable friendship is when I talk 3 hours a day to somebody on mobile phone." So, don't be surprised if you

talk three hours a day on mobile phone. You are spending time exactly according to your values, not even a second is spent otherwise.

Be convinced, time does not slip away. Time strictly follows your values. So, if you say that, “I don’t know, time just flies away”, then you are deceiving yourself. No, time never flies away. Every second of it is controlled by your mind. If you do not find time for studying, the conclusion is obvious that you do not find studying valuable. In your value system, you do not accord priority to studying. That is why you cannot give time to studying. In your value system, had studying been important, time would have presented itself. Is this becoming clear? It is not about time at all, it is about ‘my mind’, the values enshrined in it. Is this becoming clear?

When you will find what is really valuable in your life, then you will find time for it. Do you know what is really valuable? Have you ever given a thought to it? What is really valuable in life? What is really important?

Listener 1: Money.

Listener 2: Happiness.

Listener 3: Time.

Listener 4: How do I find out what is really valuable?

Speaker: Nice, four or five responses have come. I asked that, do we know what is really valuable. There are four or five responses. Somebody said money, somebody said happiness, somebody said time. One of you said something else and then there was this girl who says that how do I know what is really valuable. There are others who are already convinced about what is really valuable.

If money is really valuable, what would you spend most of your time doing? Dreaming about money, and that is what you do. Dream, have money, without asking that who is it that is having money and how is that money benefiting him. It must be from some source that you have gathered this notion that money is the most important thing.

Somebody said happiness. Yes, good! What is happiness? Is happiness that which you experience on listening to a joke? Is happiness that which you experience upon achieving a target? What is happiness? Why must happiness be different for different people? Why does happiness vary for the same man at different times? Today, something is happiness for you, ten years back your doll was the greatest happiness for you. What is the value of such happiness that keeps on changing? What is happiness? One has to find out. I am inviting you to this.

When I was your age, this was one question that was so important for me – what is valuable in life? I was very clear that I will not commit myself to any path till this question is answered. How can I just start doing something without knowing that it is really valuable? I have these few years of my life with me and I have one life. How can I spend this life doing something of which I am not convinced? And at the end of it, what will happen? If I see that I have wasted my time in pursuit that has no value at all, is that not horrible?

You are 70 years of age, you are dying, and you realize that you have spent your life doing something that had no value. Tell me, won't that be horrible? And I am telling you 99.99% of this world faces that horror daily. The so-called grown-ups, the so-called successful people, the so-called super achievers, they all are realizing this every second that they have wasted their life doing something which is not valuable at all.

Why are people quick to jump to conclusions? Why do you quickly commit yourself? Why can't you investigate? And she has put it very nicely, "How do I find out what is really valuable?"

Listener 3: Sir, we have already been told what is valuable.

Speaker: Good! Very good! So you have something to start with. You have already something to start with and it coming from outside. You have already been told what is valuable. What is valuable? A huge car is valuable. A huge mansion is valuable. A bank statement that has ten zeros behind it is very valuable. And all these things have been told to you by your so-called well-wishers. They have already filled you up with what is valuable and you are chasing that without examining whether it is really valuable. So, how can I inquire what is valuable, when I have already been told what is valuable? The inquiry has been closed.

We have been told that there is no need to inquire. Getting married is valuable! Having two kids is valuable! Having a house is valuable! Being respected is valuable! And you will say, "Yes Sir, everybody says that. Are these not valuable?" Why should I say no? I am saying that go and find out.

Why can't you find out that whether these things are really valuable? When you will discover what is not valuable, then that which is really valuable will start showing up. It will silently start shining. But first you will have to reject all that which is rubbish but you are mistakenly thinking to be of value.

Are you getting it?

So many of you believe that fakeness is valuable. So many of you believe that living a structured life is so valuable. Are we not intelligent? Don't we

have our own eyes? Don't we have our own mind to examine? Can't we go close and see whether these things are really of any importance? Will we have just beliefs for some fake values?

If you just want to believe, then why are you studying science? Does science tell you to believe or does it tell you to go close and ask questions, examine and experiment? Tell me. Does science tell you to be a superstitious? Just believe anything.

They have told me that going to the temple every Tuesday is very valuable, very important. So, go. Do you know why you are going there? And if you don't know, why must you go there? Do you even know what the temple is? Then what are you doing in the temple?

You have been told that you must always look good, you must be praiseworthy, people should say nice things about you, you should be respected. Do you understand that what is praise? Do you understand that what is respect? Then why you should feel bad when somebody does not respect you?

Without understanding something, why have you given it so much importance? Get married. Settle down, have a family. Do you understand that what is marriage? And if you don't understand, why you are getting restless to get married? Why do you feel devastated if you see somebody not getting married?

Do you know what is really important in life? And if you don't know, then open your eyes and see. It is not a huge secret. It is an obvious fact if only you bother to inquire.

You are intelligent, you have the capability. Just open your eyes and see. I assure you that all of you are capable of looking at the facts, are capable of being in the Truth, if only you are not afraid, if only you have not closed your eyes believing that you already know everything.

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~ Chapter 7 ~

Mind, the toughest prison; Mind, the fullest freedom

Question: We have been told that mind is a prison. How to get rid of this prison?

Speaker: ‘The mind is a prison’, is a correct but an incomplete statement. Remember, the mind is limited by the brain, but the mind is not merely the brain. What is it beyond the brain?

Listeners (in unison): Intelligence.

Speaker: Yes, and that is not a prison. The mind is surely a prison when intelligence is not in operation. When one is not attentive, then the mind surely becomes a prison; a prison of the past, a prison in which others have enslaved you. But the mind is not a prison when we are acting intelligently.

Somebody has said that, “The mind is both - your best friend and your worst enemy.”

When is it your best friend? - *When the same mind is operating intelligently.*

And when is it your worst enemy? - *When intelligence is switched off.*

And when is the intelligence switched off? - *Intelligence operates only in an environment of Attention.*

Alternately, you could say intelligence only operates in Love. When there is no attention, when there is no care or love, then intelligence does not function. And then the mind is your worst enemy. It is a prison, more difficult to break out of than the central jail.

(Everyone smiles)

Once in, you are always in. No windows, no escape doors, no fresh air either. Everything is stale. Everything is coming from past, and to make the matters worse, the prisoners may not even know that it is a prison. When the prisoner knows that he is imprisoned, then he makes some attempt to break out, to get free. But the mind is such a prison, which is full of suffering, but which does not let you know that you are imprisoned.

You feel, “This is my palace; this is not a room in the jail; this is not a cell in the jail, this is my great palace. And these handcuffs, they are not handcuffs but they are my ornaments. I am the king over here.”

The mind is such a deceptive prison. You do not even know that you are imprisoned. “See, I am the king. Look at my ornaments. All these walls are the walls of my mansion, my palace. All these policemen that you see are my personal bodyguards. All the policemen who are patrolling, you know what they are doing? They are securing me. They are my personal bodyguards. I am not the prisoner; I am the king out here.”

And many of us live in this prison and believe that those policemen, who are keeping us in the prison, are actually our bodyguards, are actually our well-wishers. In fact, for many of us that is the definition of a well-wisher. Somebody who keeps you in a prison is your well-wisher. The more somebody wants to imprison you, the more you think that he is your well-wisher.

And what is your logic? You say, “He wants to keep me in prison so that I can be safe.” The prisoner, remember, is extremely safe. Is he not? The prisoner in the jail is very-very safe. Is he not? Nothing can happen to him! The bird in the open sky is vulnerable, but the bird in the cage is very-very

safe. And that is the logic of the prisoner, “I will keep you safe and I will keep you imprisoned.” And you start believing that, what imprisons you is something that benefits you. Getting it?

The worse slavery is when the very remembrance of freedom is lost. The worst slavery, worst imprisonment is, when you yourself start asking for slavery, you yourself become an advocate of imprisonment.

There is a small story. We talked of the bird and the cage, so it reminded me. There was a bird in a cage, a parrot. The bird had been taught to constantly keep uttering the word, ‘Freedom’. So what was the parrot doing all the time? Chirping. What? “Freedom... Freedom... Freedom.” It is completely caged, imprisoned.

Now a young man like you was passing by. He heard the bird and said, “Oh my God! The bird is enslaved, she wants to fly free and she is asking for freedom. I must help her.” So what does he do? He goes to the bird and he opens the door of the cage, it is easy. Opening the doors of the cages is not very difficult, when you want to, when you really want to. He opens the door of the cage and he waits for the bird to fly away. But now when the door is open, the bird is not flying away. And what is the bird, the parrot doing? Shouting – “Freedom... Freedom... Freedom”.

Now, because you are young, and energetic, and freedom loving, you say, “This bird must gain freedom.” So what do you do? You put your hand inside the cage, and you try to bring the bird out. What does the bird do? She bites your hand like anything. “How dare you liberate me? I am so safe inside the cage. My master feeds me twice a day. Once in the morning he feeds me, once in the evening he feeds me. So, he gives me food, he gives me provisions and he also gives me security. How dare you liberate me?”

The bird starts biting and the finger starts bleeding, but you are adamant. You too are young and freedom is very dear to you.

(Everyone smiles)

You say, “No! Freedom is life. One must be free. So forcibly, you pull the bird out and you make it fly. It goes away. What is it that it is still chirping? “Freedom...Freedom...Freedom.” You also walk away. After a while when you return, what do you find?

Listeners (in unison): The bird is back in the cage.

Speaker: And what is the bird saying?

Listeners (in unison): Freedom, Freedom, Freedom.

Speaker: Do you see the prison of the mind? A mind that becomes habituated to slavery, does not want to become free. It does not want to become free because freedom is a little bit of a risk. In the open sky, the bird might be attacked. It will have to search for its own food. In the confinement of the prison, food is provided. The bird can just be comfortably languishing. There is the master who gives me food and also takes me to the doctor sometimes. And animals in prison, animals in cages often look better than the wild animals. Because their hair is combed, they are vaccinated; they are provided a good diet. So if you just look at them, caged animals might look more attractive than the wild or free animals. But who is really enjoying?

Listeners (in unison): The wild animal.

Speaker: In some animals, the lifespan is more when they are kept in their small cages; when they are domesticated. Then they actually live longer

than the wild animals. In the wild, there are many dangers. But who really enjoys life - the animal in the wild or the animal that has been domesticated?

Listeners (in unison): The animal in the wild.

Speaker: But often it happens that even if you let the caged animal away, like that bird, it will come back. It will come back to its slavery. We all must find out whether unfortunately it might be true for us. Whether there is something in the mind which imprisons us.

There are only two factors that dominate the mind. The jail that we are talking of actually has two entries. Only two policemen who are guarding the gates- one is 'Past' and the second is 'Others'. One is a slave either to the past or to the others.

What is slavery to the past?

Slavery of the past is, "I cannot go beyond my past", "I cannot go beyond my background", "In my family everyone does this, so I will also do this", "Since childhood, I have been conditioned to do this, so I will keep doing this". This is called slavery of the past.

And what is slavery to the others?

Slavery of the others is, "I am not using intelligence", "I am not using my free mind", "I am allowing others to set terms of my life", "Even though I am young and adult and capable, yet others are taking my life decisions", "Others influence me very-very easily", "I feel confused", "In all matters of life, I always have to seek consultation", "I am better-off when somebody else decides it for me", "I follow the crowd". This is slavery of others.

So, what are two kinds of slavery?

Listeners (in unison): Slavery of past and slavery of others.

Speaker: And these two, as we said, are the two policemen guarding the jail, guarding the prison of the mind. But the prison is blown away, dynamited by something that you already have. By what?

Listeners (in unison): Intelligence.

Speaker: Yes. Intelligence is such dynamite. It blows away the prison in no time. The moment there is application of intelligence all these prisons are reduced to dust. We do not even need effort. They are gone.

And remember that you all are intelligent. It is just that in some of us, at some moments, the intelligence is awakened. In others, it remains a potentiality. In some of us, the intelligence is very much active. In others, it is sleeping. It is there, it is there with us but it is sleeping. It is sleeping because as we said that intelligence operates in an environment of attention or Love.

So, if Love is absent, if attention is absent, then intelligence will remain inactive and we will remain prisoners. Those who want to break out of the prison must learn to be attentive, must be very careful to their own life, must see what is happening and see very clearly. And in the moment of seeing, you are no more a prisoner. In the moment of really seeing, you are no more a prisoner. The same mind that is a hell of a prison, will become the heaven of joy, the heaven of freedom. Freedom that we all deserve!

As young people, we all deserve it. It is our birth right. Joy that we all deserve! Love that we all deserve! But that cannot come to a prisoner. A prisoner knows no Joy, no Freedom, and no Love. All of these are possible

only in attention, only when you are watchful, only when you are really awake. Awake, seeing and listening. Then nobody can make a prisoner of you. Even now, nobody can make a prisoner of you, except...

Listeners (in unison): You, yourself.

Speaker: Your own sleep keeps you in prison. The moment you wake up, you are free. Is that clear?

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~ Chapter 8 ~

Solve your mind, all your problems will be solved

Question: I have resigned from my current job. At present I have different options from different fields, to pursue as a career. I do not know what to do next. How do I know what is my calling? How do I know that this is really my calling and not just boredom from the present job? How do I know that it is not just the tendency to escape from one thing to the other? How do I know that?

Speaker: How does one know anything? Right now because there is a demanding situation, right now because life has thrown up a challenge, and it is demanding an answer from you, you are eager to ask that what is your calling. “I want to know what is right for me. I want to know which decision to make.” Fundamentally you want to know what the right action is.

Is right action required only in this situation or is right action required at every point in time? In other situations you conveniently forget and remain in your dream world of ignorance, like a patient who after developing cancer goes to the doctor and asks that what he should eat now. Now what is the point in asking this question? You ate what you wanted to eat all your life. Why are you now asking what to eat and what not to eat? This question has only limited utility now.

You are asking, “How do I *know* what is calling?” Can you know what is calling, without knowing what is life, without knowing what is God, without knowing what is Freedom, without knowing yourself? I am making it difficult for you, I know that. We want quick, convenient, limited and

isolated answers, that right now there is a requirement of an answer to this particular life-question, kindly supply me the answer.

But it doesn't happen that way. You cannot get answers to one thing without knowing the answers to everything. You cannot know anything in isolation. When somebody comes and says, "Well I do not know why my daughter is behaving in such a way," I tell him, "Do you know anything? When you do not know anything, how can you know your daughter?" People come and say, "Sir, what is God?" I ask them, "Do you even know what this door is? Do you even know what this door is? Do you know why you feel like sleeping all the time? Do you know why you are attracted to this and that? When you do not know anything, how can you just know God?"

But we want to know piecemeal, in isolation. We say, "This much I know." You can never know 'this much'. *Either you know everything or you do not know anything.*

Knowledge is fragmented; understanding is not.

Please understand this.

Knowledge is fragmented and it will always remain fragmented. After all how much knowledge can you have? Knowledge will always be limited and knowledge is an ever-expanding domain. So you will always have some knowledge in some particular area, and the vast expanse of knowledge will be outside your mind. You will never have it. With respect to knowledge it is alright. When you say, "I know *of* this thing but I do not know *of* this thing", then you have made a valid statement.

You can say, "I know mechanical engineering but, I do not know electrical engineering." Good! Correct! But you cannot say, "I know Freedom but I

do not know God.” What rubbish are you talking? You cannot say, “I know the right thought but I do not know the right action.” Come on!

Now ‘calling’, that is the subject you are addressing. *Calling* cannot be known without knowing Love. It’s the Heart that calls. How can you know *calling* without knowing God? But people come up and say, “We want to choose the right career. Kindly help us.” And If I give them Ashtavakra Gita to read and say that this is your career guide, they will be dumbstruck. “Sir, what are you doing? We wanted some career guidance, and you are giving us Uddhava Gita.”

This is your career coach. You cannot get a better coach than Krishna, but you don’t realize that. You want to know the right career without knowing the right place of the mind, right? This is what you want to know. You want to know what the right career is for you.

Now, who decides the career? Mind. Is the mind in the right place? When the mind is not in the right place, how will you ever know the right means of livelihood? But such is the depth of our ignorance.

Only a spiritual mind can take even the smallest right decision. You are deciding all the time, right? You are deciding, for example, which feet to put first - left or right. Even that decision cannot be made correctly by you.

You cannot make even the smallest decision correctly without a Spiritual foundation. You will not know what to eat, you will not know whom to meet, you will not know what to say, you will not know what not to say, you will not know what to wear, you will not know what to hear. That is your tragedy. Such is the depth of your waywardness. Even one step will not be taken rightly.

Only a spiritual mind can take any right decision, any right decision. But you don't want that, because that involves surrender. All you want is right prescription, "Right now I am facing this problem, so please solve this problem for me." I am repeating - there is only one fundamental problem, your mind.

Solve your mind, all other problems will be solved. Without solving the fundamental problem, no problem can be solved.

You will just be fooled that you have solved a problem. Problems will keep coming again and again, like a recurring disease. What else is our life? A series of diseases. Sometimes the disease comes in one form, you attack the disease, and then the disease comes in another form.

You know, there is a very popular game that kids play. In this game many kids run around and one of them is supposed to touch the rest and turn them into a statue. So one kid goes and touches another kid, and this kid becomes a statue. He cannot move. But this first kid has to touch other kids also to defeat them and turn them into statues. The rule of the game is that you touch one kid, he turns into a statue. As soon as you move away from the statue to touch another kid, the remaining kids come and touch the statue, and the statue starts moving again.

So, you solve one problem, and by the time you relax and turn towards other problems, the first problem becomes alive and kicking again. And you are only running and running.

You think that you have solved one problem, the problem comes back. The problem never dies, you die of exhaustion. Or you just start complaining, "I don't want to play anymore." That happens. And then you can conveniently

commit suicide or whatever, and if you cannot do that, because it requires a bit of courage, then death comes to your rescue. Game is over, time is over.

There is one kid that you have captured, and there are two others that are calling you. Do you see this? You are asking me that which one to chase, calling or money, or calling or respectability. I can give you the answer, but by the time you will go towards either of them, this one that you have nailed will come back to haunt you again. Getting this? That is the reason why I avoid very specific questions like ‘what to do?’ and if you pester me too much then I will say, “Do what you *can* do.”

The grasshopper is coming and asking, “A huge rock is disturbing me. It is very precariously placed. Someday it will fall on my house. I want to move that rock.” Fine. Do what you can do. You have come to ask a question, and you want an answer suitable to you. Am I supposed to oblige you? Even if I oblige you, how will that help you?

People write long stories to me every day. I receive not less than twenty, thirty messages of that type from all kind of media.

(Sarcastically) In fact, most of the times people don’t even ask the question. They have already decided what to do. All that they want is an approval. So, there is only one answer that I give, “Go ahead”, and interpret whatever it means.

What else will you do? You will only do what you are programmed to do. You will only do what you are conditioned to do. Why are you wasting my time?

But if you are prepared to let go off yourself, if you have the guts to die, then let’s talk, then we can do some business. Otherwise I am not interested

in responding to your messages. I can respond, but what will you do with my response?

I have already responded thousands of time. What else am I doing right now? I am responding. If you cannot understand *this*, how will you understand my limited answer to your message? Don't you know what you must do?

Solve the mind. Dissolve the mind, and all the answers will be there. Because then, no answers will be needed.

~

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~ Chapter 9 ~

Stop thinking, just relax, and understand

Speaker: As I am responding now, did I plan to respond? This is attention – to be completely alert and wakeful. And out of that alertness comes a spontaneous response. This is attention. This spontaneity is attention, and spontaneity is of great benefit. What is that great benefit? You need not think.

So as I am speaking to you, I do not need to think. And when you do not need to think, (*pointing at the head*) ‘this’ remains very light. No problems, no headaches, no conflicts, there is only a beautiful flow; beautiful, energetic flow, like that of a mountain river. It does not pause to think which way to go. There is only flow. That is what attention is. Spontaneity! ***Spontaneity in awareness.***

Not just spontaneity, because spontaneity can be a reaction also. Somebody slaps you hard, you also slap him back. This is not alertness, this is mere spontaneity born out of evolutionary, biological conditioning.

I am talking of ‘aware’ spontaneity. For this, there is no specific time. You are sitting here, in that there has to be awareness. You are listening, eating, walking, in that there has to be awareness. Every place is a place of attention, and that is called ‘***an intelligent life***’.

It is not something like that, “When I come across a big moment in life, when I have to take a big decision in life, then only I will think in attention.” No, it is not like that. All the moments are in attention.

Listener 1: Sir, you told us to be attentive towards ourselves. Sir, don’t you think that this will make me selfish?

Speaker: The word ‘selfish’ has ‘self’ as its root. Can you be selfish without understanding the self? When you say ‘selfish’, do you understand what the ‘self’ is? Then how do you know what is meant by ‘selfish’? You say ‘selfish’, or you say ‘selfless’, in order to use any of these words you must first understand the word ‘self’. Are you getting it?

When I say ‘overweight’, or when I say ‘underweight’, what do I first need to know? What is weight? If I do not understand weight, can I make anybody understand overweight or underweight? If I do not understand the ‘self’, can I talk about ‘selfishness’ or ‘selflessness’?

What is the self? Your mind. Do you understand that?

Without understanding ‘self’, why are you using the terms ‘selfish’ and ‘selfless’? Only because you are habituated to it. Since childhood someone taught you that a particular kind of behaviour is called ‘selfishness’. You have never really understood selfishness. You have only established a link that when someone behaves in a particular way, it is to be labelled as ‘selfish’. You do not understand ‘selfishness’ because you do not understand the ‘self’. And that is what is being intelligent – understanding, not just following, not just picking up.

You want to do a small experiment? Pick up the words that you use in everyday life. Simple words: Education, Love, Living, Hate, Simplicity, Complexity, Conflict, Stress, Responsibility, Freedom. Do you really understand these words? Do you understand what ‘freedom’ is, what ‘responsibility’ is? You use these words day-in and day-out, without even knowing what they mean. What is this life that you are living?

You mentioned the word, ‘hope’. Do you understand what ‘hope’ is? Without even understanding the word you would say, “I hope to become a

management trainee one day.” Wait! Do not go so far. You have taken the story too far. ‘Dreams’ is such a sacred term for you - ‘my dreams’. Do you understand what dreams are? Do you really understand what dreams are? Obedience, do you understand that? Religion, patriotism, do you understand that? Money. What is Money? Sex. What is that? Have you understood it? But then it is so important in your life, so important in your life. Life. Have you ever tried to pay attention to it? What is [life](#)? Breathing, eating, walking, sleeping. That is life. What is ‘Life’?

Listener 2: Sir, being an ideal for someone.

Speaker: Alright. What is stupidity? You were born with all the capacities and potentialities and with all the intelligence. But what have we made of ourselves? Anybody comes and throws some garbage in your mind like a public dustbin, and you call it ‘my’ mind. That is what I claim to be myself and I am very possessive about it. “You see, don’t you dare point fingers at my beliefs, my conceptions! I listen to songs. I read inspirational stuff from here and there. At times my seniors tell me something, at times my parents tell me something, society has taught me some stuff, media, T.V., books, and I have come to believe that this is it.”

Are you here right now? “I am not present here right now but I am very excited to meet you next time.” Believe me that over the last thirty-fourty minutes I have not thought even once of meeting you again. Not because I am indifferent to you but because I am fully immersed in this moment.

But are you alert of your own mind, and watching what it is doing? Just to escape from this moment, it is trying to create an opportunity for some unknowable, unforeseen future. What else is there to observe? My own

words, my own thoughts, my being. Know this, you will know everything. And if you do not know this, it is as good as sleepwalking.

How old are you? Twenty-two? You have already spent one-third of your life with life-expectancy of seventy years. Keep sleepwalking. That is why in East, time is circular, too much time to waste. Keep wasting. Do you think that you are doing this course for the first time? Must have done at least ten times earlier, in so many births, in the same manner - by being absent. That is why you have to do it a number of times. It is like repeating a course again, after failing in it. You are only repeating it. What else?

Whatever you do not understand, you are bound to repeat. Do you know that history repeats itself? Do you understand why it repeats itself? Because you do not understand it. Once understood, the repetition stops. Had you understood the life-story of your own life over the last so many years, the repetition would have stopped. But you are not trying to look at it. You are not trying to look at it, so you are bound to repeat it again and again.

And then you will ask that, “Why is my life so boring?”, “Why I do not want to get up every morning?”, “Why do I need to be pushed for everything?”, “Why do I laugh so little and even when I laugh, I look like crying?” Ask yourself, “Why it is so?” You entered in this room because somebody else pushed you in, you will exit from this room because somebody else will push you out.

Look at yourself here and now. Can a rotten tree give fresh fruits? Your future will come from what you are right now. Am I right? But you are so intent at looking at other things in future that you are not at all aware of what all is happening right now.

Yes?

No?

Neither 'Yes' nor 'No'?

“We will believe what you say. Who are we to express 'yes' or 'no'? You have come here to deliver a guest lecture. Your introduction was given. We are just puppets dancing on the tunes of others. Will we design the syllabus? We will study whatever we are asked to. Will we decide what we want to study? See, we have left ourselves in the hands of God. All that we know is following others.”

“Whosoever takes me along, I only follow. I have done only this all through my life. I follow parents, I follow circumstances. You are a Guru, we will follow you now.”

“Why are you asking me what I want? Ask anything except 'Who am I?' and 'What do I want?' I am the most unimportant thing. Everything else is important.”

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~ **Fear and Ego** ~

*“To live fearlessly,
remove your dependencies.”*

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~ Chapter 1 ~

The root cause of all problems

Question: Sir, we have so many problems in life. Only the small problems keep us occupied. We concentrate on them and forget about the major issues of our life. So Sir, how to concentrate on those?

Speaker: Not really. Major or minor, that does not matter. What is major for one will be minor for the other. Even for the same person, a problem that appears minor today will start appearing major tomorrow and vice-versa. That will happen.

We are not talking about major and minor problems. We are not saying that we are concentrating only on the minor problems and forgetting the major problems. I repeat - we are not saying that we are concentrating only on the minor problems and forgetting the major problems. *We are saying that the root of all problems, whether major or minor, is one.* We are saying that the root of all problems whether major or minor or of whatever nature is one. And we do not look at that root. Instead we occupy ourselves with finding solutions to the secondary and tertiary problems. The primary is one and we do not look at that. In some sense, we do not want to look at that because as you said, “Problems keep us occupied.”

Mind wants something to be busy with. For the mind it is a nightmare if all the problems are resolved. The mind will say, “What will I do then? How will I remain alive? I remain alive only when I am struggling. I remain alive only when I am in conflicts.”

So, problems are like toys for the mind. Problems are the mind’s fodder. If problems are not there mind starts feeling suffocated. It, in fact, creates

problems for its own survival. Mind would create problems for its own survival.

Have you not seen people who start feeling uneasy if there is nothing to be tensed about? There are many such people. In some sense we all are like that. That is the major problem. What is the major problem? That we need problems. That is the mother problem; that is the primary problem, and we do not look at that.

See, everybody has some pain points or other, right? In fact, multiple pain points. Everybody has some confusion or the other. We all have strife and conflicts in life. Don't we have that? Where does all that come from? Why do we need that? Let me put it this way - Are they necessary? All the stuffs that we have filled our life with, are they really necessary? Can't we do without that?

It is not necessary, actually. We can still do without it, yet we ask for it. There is nobody to whom problems come. We *ask* for the problems. And when I say, "We", I mean the mind, the ego specifically. We ask for problems. Otherwise, how is it possible that every single living being is besotted with some or the other set of problems? How is it possible? It is only possible because we want problems. We beg for problems. We beg for suffering and pain.

I meet people from eighty years old to eighteen years old. And people have their own dilemmas, doubts, conflicts, sufferings and problems. Till date I have not met even one person who himself is not responsible for his problems. If you claim that you are suffering deeply, it only means that you deeply want to suffer. Otherwise, suffering is not possible.

We invite suffering. We ask for it. We beg for it. We beg for it and that is the central problem. And we don't look at that. In fact, trying to solve a problem is like justifying its existence. There is no need to solve the problem. One only needs to ask, "Does it need to be here?" You un-invite the problem, and then there is no need to solve it. How has the problem come to you? Because you have invited it. You don't need to solve it, you need to un-invite it.

You don't need to solve the problem, you need to solve the mind that attracts the problem.

The mind is the central problem and we don't look at that. We find great pleasure, great satisfaction and great doer-ship in *solving* problems. We praise somebody, "We say that he is a great problem solver." If somebody is a good problem solver, it only means that he is opening himself up to receive more and more problems.

No problem comes to you without your consent. Problems come to you because you need problems to maintain your identity.

What does the ego say, "I am somebody." That's the statement of ego. "I am somebody." How can I be somebody if I don't do anything? Who am I? An achiever. What does an achiever do? He achieves against all odds. Now what will the achiever have to do? He will have to have odds, in order to be an achiever. You understand odds? Problems.

Life is not a problem. Will you remember this? Will you remember this? Life is not a problem. In fact, there is nothing in life which is a problem. Situations are there, circumstances are there, problems are never there. You make something into a problem for the sake of your own petty ego.

Tell me, what is the primary problem? We want problems; that is the primary problem. Solve that.

Listener 2: Sir, sometimes there are some situations in which we do not know what to do.

Speaker: Yes, we don't know what to do because there is something that we want to get. How to get it is what we don't know!

But when I am complete, then nothing is a problem. Everything is happening all around me, but it cannot take away anything from me. My basic existence is not at stake. I will not be shivering. I know that there is something valuable that I already have with me and it can't be taken away. So the situations are there of this and that nature, but that's alright. "I don't have a job. It's alright. That does not reduce anything from my worthiness." "Somebody has rejected me. It's not a problem because no rejection can make me feel bad about myself." "I don't have money. It is alright. I emerged from the soil, and existence will provide enough to feed me at least."

Nothing is a problem.

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~ Chapter 2 ~

How to get rid of fear and panic?

Question: How to control fear and panic?

Speaker: Fear is a situation...

(The questioner interrupts to add to his question)

Question (again): How to control fear and panic, and move towards our objectives?

Speaker (Laughingly): Ah! Now you have made it very difficult for me. You are saying that you do not want to panic, and yet you want to keep moving towards your objective.

Now, where do your objectives come from? From the structure of your mind, your beliefs, all that has been fed into you. That is what gives rise to your goals, and objectives, and targets, right? And where does fear and panic come from? From the same stuff that has been fed into you.

You want to retain the goodie-goodie part, and you want to get rid of all that troubles you. You say, “No I want to chase those objectives, but I do not want to feel the associated pain and panic.” How is it possible? In fact those objectives, those goals and targets, are inseparable from fear. Wherever there is an objective, there would be fear associated with it. You hope to get something, and you *fear* that you may not get it. Don’t you see that a man, who is chasing goals, has condemned himself to live in fear?

Whenever you are having an objective, you want to meet the objective, don’t you? And when you want to meet it, there is always a parallel thought

that you might miss it. This thought itself is fear. Now you know why you panic? Because of these objectives.

To have an objective, and yet to remain centered, is a *different thing* altogether. That happens when the objective is not an external stuff.

It is possible to have an objective, and to be on the road to it, very calmly. It is possible to work very energetically, without the fear of loss, or without the fear of failure. But that happen only when your objective is not arising from an internal sense of incompleteness.

Understand it like this. When we set an objective, we say, “When I get that X, I would be better-off.” Isn’t that the feeling while chasing every [goal](#)? That, “When I accomplish my mission, then something would be added to me, I would be a better man, I would be better-off.” Is that not so?

So, all our objectives, in a way, start from, and feed on our sense of inferiority. “I am not quite alright right now. When I will reach that milestone, then I will have the right to feel better about myself.” Our inferiority becomes the engine that powers our journey. The more inferior you feel, the more speedily you run towards your [goal](#). That is what happens with most people, in most cases.

So much so that most of us, unfortunately, come to a point where we feel that unless there is fear, no work is possible, no movement is possible. So, if the boss wants the work done, he threatens the employee. No other engine is possible. Only when he is afraid, will he work. When the teacher wants the student to read, he says, “Unless you study, you will fail this semester.” Do you see what is happening? “Reach that objective, otherwise you are reduced.” And, “Reach that objective, and you are increased. Something is added to you.”

We forget that another mode of working is possible. It is possible to work energetically, beautifully, without having objectives. “I am alright, and because I am alright, I am working. And obviously the objective and the quality here cannot be the same as when I am working because I feel inferior. If I feel inferior, and I am working, then I am prone to panic attacks.”

“O my god! I am feeling inferior, and this work was my chance to redeem myself. And if I lose this chance, then I continue to feel inferior. So what do I do? I panic. Another opportunity, may be the last one, is being stolen.” I am panicking.”

But if I am alright, first of all, my goals do not remain the same. My goals are now worthy goals. Secondly, I cannot panic, because whether or not those goals are achieved, I am alright.

Do you see that two things change?

One, I do not chase the same [goals](#). The goals change, the very quality of the work changes.

Secondly, those goals are not the goals, in the same sense as they used to be. And I am not chasing them in the same sense that I used to chase. This chase has a different quality; these goals have a different dimension. I work hard, and yet I do not bother if I fail.

While working hard I was smiling, while achieving the goal I was smiling, and while failing, I was smiling. I was successful, people looked at me, and I was smiling. I lost the race, the people looked at me, and I was smiling. And it is not that I was not running hard enough. I ran as hard as I could. I

too have an engine. And that engine is not fear. My energy too rises from some place. I work, and I work hard.

Please do not think that one can work only when he is motivated by greed, or threatened by fear. Do not ask for motivations and threats. You demean yourself.

To be motivated is to become a mercenary. “Show me money, and I will work”. Or, “Show me money, and I will sell myself”. Or, “Show me a stick, put a gun on my head, threaten me, and I will work.” Is that nice? You know what that is? You want to live like that - carrot and stick, carrot and stick?

Then discover your real engine. It is a very powerful engine, discover it. You will have all the energy. You will be working, you will be moving, and the world will be your playground. You will be dancing, but without the associated grief, suffering, and panic. Won't that be nice?

I note this repeatedly. It took me three and half hours to reach from Noida to this place. I expected to reach here at around half past ten. While coming here, I went to sleep in my car. I woke up at half past ten, and found myself in the middle of thick traffic, and found an entire ocean of cars around mine, and it was still an hour to reach here.

I started looking at the faces of the people in the cars around, and they were all going to ‘work’, right? We are talking about ‘work’. I do not know whether I am biased, and I do not think I am, but I did not see one joyful face there. When the engine is greed and fear, how can you be joyful while going to work? I will be returning in the evening, and I will again be surprised, if I see one joyful face.

I see tensed faces, I see angry faces, I see indifferent faces, I see bored faces, I see tired faces, I see complaining faces, but I do not see joyful faces. It should be a matter of celebration, “I am going to work. Wow, so exciting!” But it seems that the fellow would rather sit in the loo all day than work. He would be more excited there.

You want that kind of life? Yes you are driving your own car, probably. And inhaling all the wonderful fumes that Delhi has to offer, and your boss is calling you, “It is eleven”.

Or you are calling up your subordinates, “Yes I am stuck in traffic, but how dare you got stuck. You should have been there at nine.”

Isn't that humiliating that you cannot even resign from these jobs, because you know that a salary cheque is waiting for you? Every single cell in your body wants to run away, and yet you cannot run away because there is a carrot dangling in front of you. Isn't that demeaning? Yes?

Let work be celebration, let work be life.

You wake up, and you want to work.

You wake up, and you do not want to run away from work.

You wake up, and you want to straight away reach out to something.

Now work is holy, it is sacred, it is your breath, and it is your heartbeat.

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~ Chapter 3 ~

What is anger?

Question: What is anger?

Speaker: Something happens and you get angry. We are looking at that event very, very closely. Something happens and you get angry. Let us give the whole thing a shape, a name, a face.

Let us say that a stranger comes to you and says that you are stupid. And he says this in front of many people. On the other hand, a friend on whom you rely, a friend whom you trust, he comes to you in front of twenty people and says that you are stupid. And you have great trust on that friend, great belief in that friend.

When would you be angry? When are you likely to be angry? When are you likely to feel hurt? When the friend says this or when the stranger? The stranger is a nobody. You do not know him; just somebody. He has just come, said a few comments and gone.

When are you likely to feel hurt?

Listeners (everyone): When a friend says this.

Speaker: When a friend says this, right? Remember, both have uttered the same words. Both of them have said that you are stupid, and both of them have said this in the same situation, in front of twenty people. But when do you feel hurt? When your friend says that, right?

Now let's go into it. Why do you feel hurt and therefore angry when your friend says this? Why do you feel hurt when your friend says this and why not when the stranger says this?

Listener 1: Because you have expectations from them.

Speaker: Yes, because you have expectations. See, had the reason of your anger been those words that you are stupid, had those words been the reason why you are angry, then you would have been equally angry at the friend and at the stranger as well, right? So, words are not the reason. The reason is something else. What is the reason?

Listeners (everyone): Expectation.

Speaker: Expectations are the reason. You do not get angry at the event. You get angry at the expectations you have from him. Getting it? You do not get angry at anything other than your own expectations. When they are defeated, when they are frustrated, when your expectations are not fulfilled, that is the situation you call as ‘anger’.

So, anger is the frustration of expectations. So if a fellow has a lot of expectations, what will happen to him? There will be chances of more and more...

Listeners (everyone): Anger.

Speaker: Anger. Whenever you feel angry you must see this very, very clearly that, “I am expecting something, and it is not happening and that is why I am feeling angry.”

Now, who gave you the right to expect? Why must you expect? And what is this business of expectation? Why do you think you have a right to expect something? Your expectation is nothing but a desire that the other person should behave according to your image of him. You have an image of your friend. And because of that image you believe that he will behave in a

particular way. When his behaviour is not according to that image, then you feel...

Listeners (*everyone*): Angry.

Speaker: Now, what is real? Is the behaviour real or the image real?

Listeners (*everyone*): The behaviour.

Speaker: The behaviour is real. If the behaviour did not match with the image then which one was false?

Listeners (*everyone*): The image.

Speaker: The image was false. So who is stupid?

Listeners (*everyone*): We.

Speaker: You are stupid because you made a false image. Now you make a false image, and that image is broken on coming in contact with reality. And then you get angry. Don't you think it is stupid?

What am I doing? First of all I am making a false image. When that image gets dented, broken, on coming in contact with reality, what do I do?

Listeners (**everyone**): I get angry.

Speaker: Angry. Do you think it is intelligent of me? Look at the whole process of what my mind is doing.

First of all it creates images. Why must you create images? Why is it necessary to create images? You create images because you are afraid. You want security.

(Pointing at one of the listeners)

You want to believe that this fellow is like this. So you have created an image of him. And you want to keep this image. Are you getting it? I have created an image of him and I think this image, or I rather wish that this image must continue to be like this.

For example, my image is that he is reliable. Now when I say that he is reliable, my mind becomes secure. He is reliable. Now my mind can be peaceful. I can go to sleep. Are you getting it? This is just an image. Tomorrow he may prove to be unreliable. And then there will be anger.

So, fear leads to anger. Fear leads to creation of image. And when that image comes in contact with reality, then there is friction, the image gets broken. The breaking of this image is called...

Listeners (everyone): Anger.

Speaker: If you are not afraid, you cannot be angry. First of all you have to be afraid to be angry. The intelligent man lives in the moment. He does not live in images. Hence, there is no reason for him to get angry. He does not live in expectations. At the root of all anger lie expectations. The intelligent man does not live in expectations. He lives in the moment.

So it is obvious that the man who gets angry and the rest of the things, obviously cannot be receptive, because he is afraid. When you are afraid you cannot hear. How would you be receptive? Can he be joyful? No, he obviously can't be joyful. Can he be ego-free? Anger is fear. And fear is ego. How can he be ego free? All of these things are highly inter-related. Do you see this? Do you see how ego is fear?

How is ego fear? Ego comes from outside. What comes from outside can also go back to the outside?

Somebody gave you respectability. He can also take it away.

Somebody gave you a jacket. He can also take it away.

Somebody gives you financial security. He can take it away.

Somebody says that you are brilliant. He can stop saying that. He can start saying that you are stupid.

Whatever comes from outside, can go back. Ego comes from the outside. So it is always afraid that something can be taken away from it.

Do you see the relation between all these things? Do you see that all these diseases come from a basic source? The source is ignorance. The basic source, the seed from where all these things sprout is ignorance. What is ignorance?

Listener 2: Neglecting things around us.

Speaker: No, not neglecting, not at all. Ignorance means lack of attention. Lack of awareness, not understanding, living in beliefs, living in acceptance, that is ignorance. Once you get rid of that, you get rid of so many diseases. Fear, anger, expectations, insecurity, ambition, all these diseases they go away once ignorance goes away, once inattention goes away.

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~ Chapter 4 ~

Confidence is fear

Question: What is the difference between confidence and over-confidence?

Speaker: It seems that this question is important to many of us here, right?

Listeners (*everyone*): Yes, Sir.

Speaker: What is confidence?

On a normal day at home, do you require confidence to speak to your parents, to other family members? Before you speak to them, do you gather courage, do you gather confidence and then go there? No, you don't. So, you don't require confidence at home.

You must be having some friends? When you are speaking to your friends, do you require confidence? No.

But you surely require confidence when you are speaking to an interviewer. Then you say, "I require confidence." Correct?

Try to understand this. Why do you require confidence in an interview room, and why do you not require confidence at home? You require confidence when you are afraid. The one who is not afraid, does not require confidence.

Right now, as I am sitting in front of you, this thought of 'confidence' has not crossed my mind even once. In fact, you may say that I am not at all confident right now, because one needs confidence only when one is afraid. So, the more you appear confident, the more afraid you are.

Do not ask for confidence, ask for simplicity. **Simplicity, not confidence.**

Simplicity is - 'I am what I am'. Confidence is - an indication of fear. And over-confidence is an indication of even more fear. Look at the definition of confidence that you have in your mind. For you, confidence and aggression are not very different. What you call as confidence is almost similar to aggression.

You remain as you are, then you would not need any confidence. As you are sitting here, you do not need any confidence. But if I ask you to come onstage and speak in front of an audience, then you would require confidence. Why would this happen? Because...

Listeners (everyone): There is fear.

Speaker: Fear will arise, but understand this fear. Do not ask for confidence. Understand this fear. This fear arises because we are constantly looking at others.

Let me ask you a question. Do you require confidence when you have to speak in a room all alone? No. But you require confidence when you have to speak in a hall filled with audience, right?

Listeners (everyone): Yes, Sir.

Speaker: What is the essential difference between both the situations? The process of speaking is happening in a vacant room and also in the room filled with audience. But in the second situation, 'others' are present. You are afraid of these 'others'. And you require confidence only to deal with the 'others'.

So, what is better, to ask for confidence, or to get rid of the fear?

Listeners (everyone): To get rid of the fear.

Speaker: Then you have to understand deeply that why are we afraid.

What is Ego? Ego is the image that I create about myself through others. I have no understanding of myself, whatever others have told me about myself, I have accepted it. This is Ego, right?

It is this Ego that gives rise to fear because I have always known myself through others. That is why I am always afraid of speaking in front of others. That is why I am always afraid of others' opinions. That is why I am always afraid of others' impression about me. If I fall in the eyes of others, I fall in my own eyes.

We have always known ourselves through others and that is the reason for our fear. If others applaud for me, then I consider myself to be brilliant. If others criticize me, then I consider myself to be bad. This is the reason of our fear, and the reason you ask for confidence. At the root of confidence lies the fear of others, fear of external factors. And all this is because you do not know yourself. You know yourself only as an image in the eyes of others.

Is it important to look at ourselves through the eyes of others? We have eyes of our own, don't we? Then why should we know ourselves through others? Not at all necessary. After all, all of us are mature adults now. We can stand on our feet, look through our own eyes and understand, right?

Listeners (everyone): Yes, Sir.

Speaker: Then why do we need to know ourselves through the eyes of others? Do not try to 'look' confident. The more you ask for confidence, the more it indicates that you are afraid.

Do not ask for confidence. Remain simple!

Do not try to become something. Just remain as you are. Simple, ordinary!

Do not try to become something, then everything will be alright. Everything will be fun. You will feel light. You will get rid of a lot of burden.

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~ Chapter 5 ~

What to do with fear and anxiety?

Question: How can one be in the sense of ‘presence’? How can one get rid of anxiety?

Speaker: First of all, I do not think that there is any magical formula to it. There is a part of anxiety that is related to ‘facts’, and there is a component of anxiety that rests upon ‘imagination’. We have to deal with them differently.

What is purely imaginary, will lose its sting, the moment you see that it is merely ‘imaginary’.

The part of anxiety that is merely arising from projection, just projection, and the mind is very fertile, the mind can really imagine anything, that part will lose its venom, its hold on you, the moment you see that – “I can go on imagining anything, and there is no end to the self-inflicted anxiety that I can cause to myself.”

There is another component of anxiety that is related to ‘facts’, where there is a cause-effect thing. You know that the cause has taken place, so the effect is bound to surface. And the effect might be impinging on your self-interest, so you are anxious, right?

Now this is the part that probably all of us have to bear. If the arrow has left the bow, it will travel the distance. Since it will travel the distance, one may as well say, “There is no point worrying now.” It is a fact; one can’t do anything about it. It is done. And when one can’t do anything about something, minimize your losses. Why put more investment in something, which is already a lost case?

But this part of anxiety, we simply have to bear. And we need to have the courage, to go through it, to pass through it; nothing can be done much about it. The good news is – the bigger component is the imaginary component. And the imaginary component can be gotten rid of, almost totally.

With some of us, and your own experience would probably vindicate it, the imaginary component might be eighty-ninety percent, or the totality of your anxiety. That is really good news. It means that with some of us, our anxiety might be totally unfounded. And if it is unfounded, fine. We can just dispose it away.

Let's say, I am scheduled to have an operation tomorrow; the surgeon would perform upon me. And the surgeon has told me as a fact that I have just X probability of survival. It is a fact. Now I am already not in a very good position, because I do not know whether I will see the day after tomorrow, right? And I will have to go under his knife in any case. This is the factual part of anxiety.

I may as well say, "This is bound to happen. And if it is bound to happen, and I know that it is not a very pleasant thing that is going to happen to me, then why make it all the more unpleasant? It is already not very pleasant." So, relax.

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~ Chapter 6 ~

Plans of future come from fears of past

Speaker: Pranab, you are asking that if you think of the future, then it appears like slavery of the past, because future consists of the images of the past, but at the same time there is a fear that, if you do not think of the future, from where will my actions come out?

It is very simple, not at all complicated. We will look at it carefully.

Future is automatically, naturally flowing from the present. At this moment, several of us as apparent from your faces, are listening carefully, right? You are still and listening carefully. You are not thinking, not planning; just listening. You are present and the future is being created. Have we not moved in time in the last two minutes? Even as you are listening, is future not happening?

Moment by moment, are we not moving into the future? We are and it is happening on its own without needing any interference from our side. But what do we think? Our concern is that unless I create a future, future will not come. Our conception is that unless I create the future, the future will not come. Unless I create a beautiful future in me, there cannot be beauty in the future. Is that not the way you think?

The next minute is the future; the next hour is the future. Consider this second itself which is very much available to us. Are we not moving into the future? Peacefully, without problems, without any effort; just pleasant, just attention.

Take another example. Let us have a seed with us. The seed's nature is to grow into a tree. The very nature of the seed is to grow into a tree. You do

not need to imagine a future for the seed to become the tree. What do you require? You just require that in the present moment you are with the seed. You give it water, give it sunlight, nourishment, and that will happen only if you love the seed. The equation goes: the seed, plus water, plus air, plus sunlight, plus soil is equal to the tree. But in your mind the equation has another variable. The equation in your mind is: seed, plus water, plus air, plus sunlight plus desire is equal to tree. You feel that unless there is a desire in the seed to become a tree, how can it become a tree. It will become a tree on its own.

The present will become future on its own. You just take care of the seed; you just take care of the present. A beautiful future will be born; you just take care of the present. The future will be beautiful. The seed will become a tree. You just take care of the seed, a beautiful tree will grow.

Is two plus two equal to four? But you will say, “Two plus two plus desire is equal to four. I want two plus two to be four. ” If you have clarity, if you are looking at it carefully, then two plus two will be naturally four. Do you require a desire for it to be four? There is no need. All you need is the appropriateness to look into it. Two plus two will come out itself to be four.

A beautiful present is a beautiful future; you do not need to desire it to be beautiful. Think about only present. The present of this moment is the future of the next moment. Is it not?

So, don't feel guilty about it. In fact, even in thinking that you are neglecting the future, still you are thinking about the future, still obsessed about it. In this also there is a misconception. We all have the ability to forecast. Forecasting is one thing and desiring from the future is another thing. Based on how economy is going, the economist can forecast how the

economy will grow in the next year, that is also looking into the future but that is not the same as being future-oriented. You have the weather department. What does it do? It keeps forecasting the weather. If I have the capacity to project the future, that is one thing, but to be obsessed with the future is the entirely different thing.

To make the future the centre of your action is totally different. There can be two ways of acting: one is that I am acting right now and the other is that I already have the image in the mind and based on that image I am working for the future. Unfortunately, ninety nine percent of us work according to the second order.

See, the first model says that, “I am in love with my books and studies in the present and because I study well in the present, so I will do well in the examination, which is in future.”

The second model says that, “When the examination will be announced, when the exam date-sheet will be put up, then to do well, I will start studying. To do well in the future, I will start studying. Future comes first for all.” That is our model. That is the way of life for ninety-nine percent of the people. Future comes first for you and then the present comes. You are reversing the flow of time. What comes first, future or present?

Listeners (*everyone*): Present

Speaker: But in our minds, future comes first. “I want to succeed in that examination, so today I must study”. The appropriate sequence is, “Because I am studying, hence I will naturally do well in the exam. I am not studying for the sake of exam; I am studying because I love to study.”

Would it not be beautiful if you live this way? Then marks would be a by-product. Marks will not matter, what will matter is the time that you spend with your books; the joy, the fun with the books, that is more important.

Feel free, let it come. Fearlessly, let it come. Let there be faith that, "I am capable of handling whatever will come. I can take it. I will not be scared. I will not shiver. I will not be afraid. Just bring it on. I have a way to respond to it. My intelligence is adequate. There is a challenge, I will respond. The world is not a threatening place. Please!"

We think that unless we secure ourselves well, the future may harm us. If we do not secure ourselves well, there is some danger in the future, and to take care of ourselves we must wear some kind of armour, we must enclose ourselves.

The world is not a dangerous place. Had the world been a dangerous place, how could I have ever been born?

The very fact that you are here means that existence has no enmity with you. The air that you breathe in, did you plan to get it? You can hear, you can see, you have become young. Your arms have become powerful, you have energy.

Does this come to you because you have asked for it? Did you desire it? You have eyes, you have eye-sight, did you ask for it?

Existence has given all this to you, how can existence be hostile towards you? The past was not hostile, the present is not hostile. How can future be hostile?

Essentially, all planning for the future is planning of the present.

~ Chapter 7 ~

Fear can be answered only with Faith

Speaker: Mind has so much stored, that it does not even know how much is stored. There are two portions to the storage. There are two parts of this godown.

One part is – where you know that you have something stored.

And the other part is – where you have it stored, but have forgotten that it is stored.

Now what is happening? For example, this is a place where you keep all your stuff. You brought lots of vegetables and have kept them here. You are like the mind - accumulative, always in a hurry to accumulate, afraid that there might be a famine, that there might be a curfew, that – “I may not get vegetables.” That is what the mind is always thinking - “Hoard, store.”

So, you keep bringing vegetables even when no vegetables are needed. Your house is full of vegetables. And because the refrigerator and other places can hold only small amount of vegetables, so you keep your vegetables at very unseemly places - under the bed, in the car. Wherever you find space, you put the vegetables. You are always storing vegetables.

Now, so much is stored that some of it is remembered, and some of it is forgotten. Now what will happen to that which is forgotten? It starts rotting. Now the house is stinking, but you don't even know why it is stinking.

That is subconscious. It is stinking because you kept something in it, and you forgot.

And this may not have happened in only the last thirty years of *your* existence (*referring to the average age of the audience*). Your parents may have kept something and it has been given to you through their genes. Maybe it happened one thousand years back, and just the flow of DNA has brought it to you, but surely somebody forgot.

And because the mind of the mankind is one, because the mind of the universe is one, because there can be only one mind, it has come to you, as it comes to everybody else. Now your life is stinking, and you don't even know why. That is the subconscious.

Now, how do you find out why the house is smelling so bad? What is the house? The mind. How do you find out that why is it smelling so bad? "I haven't done anything, yet it smells."

When it stinks, you don't run away from the house. You don't take a deodorant and spray it all around that, "Now the smell is gone for some time." You don't start making an argument that, "This is not stink. This is a rose flower smell." You don't start doing all these things.

Basic honesty is needed to accept that, "Yes, it is stinking. Let me go close to it. I will not run away from it."

When you go close to the stink, where do you reach? The source of the stink, the place from where the stink is arising. When you reach the source, what can you do? Then you can clean it. That is the unconscious.

The unconscious cannot be seen directly, but its effects can be experienced in life. You can't see, so it is quite puzzling. You can't see, but the effects are there. You are unnecessarily afraid. You ask yourself, "Why am I afraid?" And you don't find any reason.

People are afraid of lizards. Now, lizards have done nothing to them. For example, you are thirty-five years old and you can't remember whether any lizard ever harmed you. Yet you are afraid of the lizards. There is a reason.

Lizards represent reptiles. And when you were a monkey sitting on a tree, there was this large python that was also on that tree. You were a bird once; the snake came and ate your eggs. You are afraid of lizards since that time. It is not that today the reptiles are scaring you. You would always be scared of reptiles. It is there in the genetic material itself.

You have to go close to it and see that, "I am no more laying eggs and you are no more a python. Look at my size and look at your size." Put the lizard on the table and talk to it. "Look at yourself, and look at me. Now is it befitting that I am afraid of you? You should be afraid of me." Talk to the lizard. And slowly you will find that the fear will be gone. You are no more the pigeon; she is no more a python. So why should you be afraid?

Listener 1: Sir confronting the situation is one way to let the fear go away. But we are so fearful that we don't want to confront our fears.

Speaker: There you need Faith. That – "Let me confront it. Nothing can go wrong."

Listener 2: Sir, faith on what?

Speaker: On nothing. You have trust *on* something. You have Faith *on* nothing. Trust always has an object to trust, Faith has no object. That is why trust can be broken, Faith cannot be broken.

Object can deceive you, Faith is object-less. When you have Faith, you cannot be deceived. So difficult, right? It is like hanging without a rope. No object to hang on to and still hanging. That is what Faith is.

You see, if you hang by a rope, the rope can be broken. But if you hang without a rope, there is no fear. Nothing can be broken. That is Faith.

“I don’t have Faith *on* anybody. I am just faithful.”

Listener 2: Sir, earlier when we were talking of student-teacher relationship you were talking of Faith, and I thought you were talking of faith on the guru.

Speaker: Faith finds expression, it is like individuality. It finds expression. It seizes the moment, and it expresses itself. Faith is like individuality, you can do nothing to arouse it. Faith, like individuality, and like core, **is just there.**

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~ Chapter 8 ~

To live fearlessly, remove your dependencies

Listener: Sir, how can we overcome our fears?

Speaker: You have raised an apt question about fear, because this precisely is the moment when a lot of people in this audience might be in the grip of fear. I am exhorting you all to ask questions and many of you are quite reluctant. The reason is fear. Not that you don't have questions to ask. You surely have questions to ask, but you are afraid. You are asking me how to remove fear. Let us start from here.

What makes any member of the audience sitting here afraid? Why can't he ask questions when he surely has questions to ask? Would he still be afraid if there were not so many people in this hall? Would he still be afraid if it were only me and him? He would not be afraid. Right now he or she is hiding somewhere. From whom is he hiding? From the members of the audience.

So, yes one is afraid. But one is afraid of what?

Are you ever afraid of speaking when you are alone in a room, in front of a mirror? Have you found yourself stumbling even then? You don't hesitate then, right? So, yes you are afraid. Afraid of what?

You are afraid of the audience, you are afraid of the others. So whenever it comes to fear, always remember one thing. All fear is related to somebody else. Something external, something outside of you is always related to your fear.

Now why is one afraid of the audience? One is afraid of the audience because one is dependent upon the audience. How are we dependent upon the audience? Our image depends upon the audience.

Who am I? My self- image about myself. Who am I? The image that I hold of myself that comes from others. I look at myself through the eyes of others. So, in case I get up and ask a question and the audience boos me down, the audience says that what a stupid question I have asked, how unpolished language do I speak, then I will fall in my own eyes. My self-image will take a beating. That is why I don't want to take that risk. I will not ask the question. Do you see the link?

First thing is that, fear is related to others, something external. Second thing is that, it is related to others, because you are dependent on others.

I am brilliant only when somebody tells me that I am brilliant. I am acceptable only when others accept me. I am smart only when my friends say that I am smart. My question is good enough only if everybody in the hall claps. But there is a risk. I may get up and everybody in the hall may not clap, instead they may jeer at me. And then I will be devastated because I do not have my own eyes to look at myself. I look at myself as others look at me.

This is reflected awareness. I am not looking at myself directly. I never examine my own actions and thoughts to see who I am. Instead I depend on others.

My friend comes and says, "Boss, you are a dude", and I say, "Alright ! You have said that I am a dude, so I must be a dude."

My parents come and say, “You are very irresponsible”, and immediately I internalize their opinion. “They have said that I am irresponsible, so it is quite likely that I am irresponsible.”

I was taking an interview and came across this candidate. During the interview he said that he had great leadership qualities. I asked him that, “How do you know that you have good leadership qualities.” His reply was, “Because everybody says so. All my friends say that I will be a good leader. All my friends say that I have good leadership qualities.” So, I asked that, “Is it because your friends say that you have good leadership qualities, that you believe that you are a good leader?” He replied, “Yes, Sir”. “So, who is leading whom? You do not know any independent existence.”

Let the image fall. “Let everybody think bad of me, yet I am what I am.”

You do not know this state. That is the reason you become easily tensed when somebody says a few bad things about you. Does that happen or not? And that is also the reason why you swell up, why you immediately start feeling good when somebody praises you.

“You are looking quiet handsome”, “From where did you buy this shirt?”, “From where did you get your haircut?” And you puff up. Why did you puff up? Because he said something nice about you. Now, it doesn’t matter how your haircut actually looks, it is just that it is acceptable to others, so it must be good. And this is a situation of great desperation, deep slavery.

Do you see this? “I am so dependent upon the opinions of others. A complete slave I am. You say that I am A, so I become A. You say that I am B, so I think that I am B. Who am I? That I do not know”. That is fear.

One - it arises due to others. Second - it arises when you depend upon others.

So, how to get rid of fear? By reducing your dependency.

Anybody here who wants to live fearlessly must reduce his or her dependency. As your dependency reduces, you will find that you are becoming more and more fearless. And if your dependency keeps on increasing, your fear also keeps on increasing.

Reducing dependencies, finding your authentic self, is the key to living fearlessly.

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~ **Education and Career** ~

*“Move in knowledge,
but be centered in wisdom.”*

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~ Chapter 1 ~

Why is education not helping the world?

Speaker: The question asked by Nitish is that in spite of having a world that is more and more educated, with every passing day the literacy levels are increasing, more and more people are enrolling for higher education as well, in spite of having all these, why do we have a world like this?

Why do we have a world like this?

Education has two layers to it.

The first layer is the superficial one which deals with objects. Let us see what all is included in this layer? Since your childhood you have studied Hindi, English, History, Geography, Mathematics and now Technology. But you are not the languages. You are not the glaciers and the mountains that you read about in geography. You are not the kings and their kingdoms you read of in History. You are not a quadratic equation, you are not a differential equation either that you studied in Mathematics. And none of you is an electromagnetic motor about which you are reading currently. All of these are external objects. Education about them is superficial education which takes the mind to objects, objects outside.

Objects include people, places, things, moments everything. So, when education tells you about other people and their thinking, when education tells you about science and the products of science, it is all about objects; external objects. And your education has filled your mind with knowledge about external objects; which is alright, which is important to an extent. But that is just superficial. That is just the first layer of education.

Real education is something else. Real education takes the mind not outwards but inwards. Real education is about a mind that is able to understand its own processes.

From where does anger arise?

Why am I so insecure?

Why am I always restless?

Why can't I be attentive?

Why am I jealous?

Why am I possessive?

What is the quality of my relationships?

What is Love?

What is Joy?

What is Truth?

What is Freedom?

What are thoughts? How do they arise?

A mind that cannot enquire into this, a mind that cannot go into itself, is not an educated mind.

When education is about the external, the laboratory is outside. When education is about the mind then you have to observe the mind itself. Then the observatory is here (*pointing at the head*). If you just have the first kind of education, you will get what someone has called as - ***Guided missiles***

and unguided men. What someone has called as - ***Smart phones and stupid people.*** Are you getting it?

That is the product of the first kind of education that just takes you outside. So learn about what others have done, what kind of technologies are being developed in labs, but then you will have, *smart phones and stupid people*. You are intelligent only when you can look at yourself and understand your mind; otherwise you are completely stupid even if you hold a master's degree. You are not educated in the real sense. You are not educated in the real sense if only the first kind of education is coming to you.

I never tire of telling my audience that if you keep all your education till date on one side, and self-education on the other, self-education will outweigh the rest of your education. Because self-education is not about objects, it is about you. This same mind that has always been forced to wander outside is taken inward. And that is far more important. That is the second kind of education, the real education, in absence of which you are not really educated.

You asked, 'Why do we have so many crimes and such things?' Part of that you would have understood, right? *Guided missiles and unguided men.* There is another layer to understanding which will help you understand that why we do have so much of all this.

You talked about that particular rape case. Don't you see that every kid since childhood is being told to speak the truth, to be a loving being, to be non-violent? And still the child creates a world like this which is full of misery, suffering, corruption, violence, hatred and rape.

Do you ever wonder that in spite of being told all these so-called virtuous things in childhood, from where do these criminals come? After all every

criminal was a child once and every child is told of these moral and immoral things. Then why do people grow up to be murderers and rapists? Why?

The reason is, because the truth cannot come to you from outside, the truth of life cannot come to you from outside. It is a great misconception to think that ethics and morality can be taught. But that is what is happening in every house. The mother tells the child to speak the truth, and if the kid is not a totally dull kid he will turn around and ask, “But mummy, why should I speak the truth?” the mother will be irritated because she does not know. Somebody told her. That’s the way she knows. It does not come from her understanding. So it just remains a foreign thing to the kid, it cannot become his life, it cannot become his way of living because he has never really understood what is wrong with lying, what is wrong with violence. The kid says, ‘Mummy keeps telling me that violence is not right but I get so much of pleasure in killing these small insects.’ And mummy is not really able to tell him why killing insects is wrong. At best she can give some borrowed answer which does not convince the kid.

Till the time you do not get the second kind of education life will remain violent, life will remain full of suffering. People will remain ambitious and greedy and discontented.

You must go within. Truth, Love and Joy are not words to be borrowed from somebody, they are to be discovered within. The real freedom, the only freedom is the freedom of the mind and unless your education brings that to you, education is worthless. It can give you a few conveniences, which is alright but that is all superficial.

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~ Chapter 2 ~

Competition, career and planning

Speaker: Manoj has asked that, “Given that there is so much of competition, how do I plan my career?”

Manoj, can I solve a problem if I do not understand it? You said that, “There is so much of competition, so how to plan my career?” Now look at the three words that are involved in this. ‘Competition’, ‘plan’ and ‘career’. Do we really understand any of these three words?

Do we understand what competition is, and what a competitive mind is? What is a mind that is always competitive and that is always thinking in relation to the other? Such a mind is a fearful mind. Such a mind does not look at itself because it is so busy looking at the other, that its life, all its activities, all its thoughts are determined by what is happening on the outside.

So, if someone else is running at a particular speed, this mind might say that it has to run harder. If that fellow starts swimming, then this might say that it has to swim harder. This mind has nothing of its own. Somebody else dictates what it does. And it is always afraid. It is always afraid because its sense of accomplishment comes only in relation to others.

Now at your age, when you are so young, when you have just entered college, if you are thinking that far ahead then there is a problem. There are a thousand things that you can ask me, but see what you have chosen to ask. You could have asked me so many questions about yourself, but you are asking something that will happen three-four years later. Doesn’t that show that your mind is already apprehensive of something? And if your mind is

so occupied then what will happen then, a few years later? Can your mind be really alive to what is happening right now?

See, how do we enter college? When we enter college, we start thinking of what is going to happen in the fourth year or after fourth year. Now if that is important, what will happen to the quality of these four years? If my mind is telling me that the really important thing will happen at the end of these four years, then what will be the quality of my first year, second year and third year? The real important thing is there so, this becomes unimportant. If this becomes unimportant, then life becomes boring, right?

My whole attention is on events that will happen in the future, and life is right now. Life is right now and mind is thinking about what will happen years later, because mind is saying that only that which will happen years later is important, only that is precious, only that is real. Only when I get a good result, or only when I get a good job, or only when something great happens in my life only that is important.

If you are not available to what is happening right now, if you are not available to what is happening in this moment, and if your mind is thinking of the future, then your life will be boring, dull. The real moment is right now. But if your mind keeps thinking of the future, it will miss life now. Then life will be boring for you.

When life becomes boring, you start finding it valueless. Then studying becomes unimportant, results become important. Then studying a particular course becomes unimportant, getting a job becomes important. The result is that we live very superficial lives. Our actions lack depth. Neither do we study deeply, nor do we do anything deeply. We are not totally, completely available, attentive to anything. Are you getting it?

Why can't you ask, "Sir, what is it that can be done now? How can I use this opportunity that is available at this moment?"

A fearful man has no awareness of moving deep in the 'now'. You are forgetting that future comes from the present. You have completely forgotten that today leads to tomorrow.

Can a decayed seed give birth to a healthy tree? Future is that tree, present is that seed. But all of you keep thinking that, "Let the present go to ruin, but we will keep imagining about a beautiful future". "Whatever I am doing right now is unimportant. If I keep thinking of past and future, if I keep thinking of this and that, if I am not attentive, it is alright. But, I will keep imagining a beautiful future."

Future will come from this moment. If this moment is lived well, the future is bound to be beautiful.

Your argument is exactly opposite to this. You say, "Let this moment go to waste. I do not care for this moment, I care only for the future." From where does the future arise? Future emanates from this moment. The one who is sleeping today, who is unaware today, who is lost today, who has decayed the seed of today, how can he think of a beautiful tree in the future?

Imaginations, resolutions do not give a beautiful future. Those who live in today, they get a beautiful future as a 'present', a surprise gift. Those who live in dreams of tomorrow, they not only spoil their today, they do not get anything in the future. Those who live in now, in the present, they not only live today fully, they also get a beautiful future as a surprise gift.

Forget worrying about what will happen tomorrow. Forget worrying about what will happen four years later. Pay attention to yourself. Do you know

yourself? Do you understand the meaning of 'career'? Do you understand the meaning of these word - 'work' and 'livelihood'? Do you understand the relation between 'work' and 'money'?

You have heard somewhere that there is a lot of competition and to survive in it one needs to do a lot of planning, without understanding what is 'career', without understanding that the mind which is always competing becomes diseased. Without understanding all this, you have jumped into it because you are afraid. Even this fear is not yours. This fear has been implanted in your mind, by your family, by the society, by the media, by your education. You have imbibed this fear. This fear cannot help you.

Go deep into what is available to you. Go deep into your mind. Understand the mind, understand the world.

And then you will yourself come to know what is worth doing. You will yourself know what kind of career will give you happiness. You will not be lost. Then, you will not study engineering because somebody else suggested. Then whatever you will do, that will come from your own understanding. So, do not be in a hurry to take any decisions. Wait, understand!

Observe the mind, understand the mind.

Observe the world, understand the world.

~

~ Chapter 3 ~

How to make career choices?

Question: Sir, after completing my B.Tech. degree course, should I go for higher studies or a high paying job? How can I decide that?

Speaker: “After completing B.Tech., I do not know whether I should go for a job, or for higher studies, or something else.”

Sonu, usually in life, when you are stuck between two or three choices, you will find most of the times that none of the choices are really good for you. So, my question will be, “Why am I unable to choose between A, B and C?”

Life says that whenever you are unable to choose between A, B and C, had any of these three been really what your life is looking for, then you would not have been confused. Confusion itself is an indication that these, all three, all five, all eight, are sub-optimal choices. Do you understand what is meant by sub-optimal choices? A sub-optimal choice is that which is not really reaching the maxima. It's a compromise.

First of all, let's understand what this word called 'work' is because all three questions that you have asked relate to work, right? What is work?

What is your age today? 21 or 22? You would be working for minimum thirty to forty years? Your total work-life duration will be at least thirty to forty years? Do you see that? That means, particularly till the end of your life except for the last ten years, you would be working.

How many hours a day do you sleep? Six hours to eight hours, right? One or two hours for your other regular physical activities - eating, washing and

such other activities. You are left with around fourteen hours. Out of which, how much time do you think one spends working? How much time do you think you spend on working? From one end to another end? End to end means, starting from your home, going to the workplace and coming back to your home. So, how much time do you think you spend working? If you are in NCR, it would be a minimum of twelve hours or it could go to sixteen hours. Because one hour of commuting time either way is the standard. So, two hours you are anyway spending just in commuting. A typical office day stretches to a minimum of ten or twelve hours, it could extend to fifteen hours, and it could be sixteen hours. So, taking away the sleeping time, you are left with around fifteen hours or so in the day, of which twelve to fifteen hours you are spending in work.

Remove the sleeping part, how much of your total waking life do you spend on working? What percentage of your total waking life are you spending on working? Eighty percent! You remove the holidays and the other leaves you take, and yet you will be left with seventy or seventy-five percent. You will be spending three-fourths of your waking life working.

Understand the significance of 'work'! You will be spending three-fourth of your waking life working, which is practically your entire life. So, what is work? Work is life itself!

Now somebody who does not make a wise decision with respect to work, is he losing out merely on work or losing out on life itself?

Listeners (*everyone*): Life itself!

Speaker: He has not only spoiled his career but he has actually spoiled his
.....

Listeners (*everyone*): Life!

Speaker: Remember, I am not yet talking of ambition and money. I am just talking of the time you give to work. I have not yet talked of money. I have not yet talked of how high you rise in the corporate hierarchy and such things. No, that's not my concern.

My concern is that an adult being works, he acts and this action is life. If he does not know the direction of his work, if he does not know where to place his work, then he is condemning himself to hell. He is saying, "Let my life be hell." Because all the day you are working, and if work is something that you do not like, if that work is something that your heart does not agree to, then you will suffer and suffer badly.

And, that's what is happening with millions and millions of people around us. Under the influence of various forces, people choose careers, work streams that are intrinsically unsuitable to them. And then, because of inertia, because of fear they find that they can't even get out of the rut they have put themselves in. The result is that they make a wrong choice and then they have to stay with the wrong choice. First of all you make a wrong choice and then you stay with the wrong choice because you dare not do anything else.

Have you heard the story of the crying woman inside the train? So there was this woman who was sitting in a long distance train and her co-passenger, who did not know her, was sitting in front of her; two strangers sitting in front of each other. So, the train left the station and after a while the co-passenger sees that the woman is tensed. He has noticed that people do get tensed, nothing big about it. A few hours and he sees that she is actually worried, her forehead is freckled and she is showing physical signs

of distress. She is fidgeting; she is looking here and there. He becomes a little concerned, but he thinks that she may be tensed because she is leaving a few people back. There is something in her personal life which is keeping her nervous. The day passes and the night comes. And when the night comes he finds that she is actually shedding the tears. Her eyes are moist. So he gathers courage and asks her what is wrong. She doesn't reply. He doesn't press for the answer because one can't press strangers for answers. He goes off to sleep. It's a long distance train. When he wakes up in the morning he finds that she is actually sobbing. Streams of tears are flowing down her eyes. He again asked her, "Is there something wrong. Is there some way I can help?" She says nothing. So, he keeps to himself. By the time evening comes, and it's a long distance train as has been said, the woman has gone mad with grief. She is hitting against the wall. She is actually crying out. Somehow this is too much for the man. He catches hold of her and says, "Please tell me what's wrong? You are getting hysterical for what reason?" And she replies, "Since yesterday I am sitting in the wrong train. And every passing station reminds me that I am sitting in the wrong train. That is why as the train is moving along, I am getting more and more depressed."

That is the story of most of the working professionals. First you get into the wrong train, then at every station you have an opportunity to get down. Getting it! Life gives you so much opportunity. It's a long distance train, it stops at many places. You could have de-boarded it anytime. But then you don't have the guts to get down either. First of all you are getting into the wrong train, and now you are in the wrong train and you keep on going along.

As you go along, your suffering keeps increasing and increasing. First of all out of ignorance or out of fear, pressure or other kinds of influences, you choose the wrong direction of life and then you find that you do not have the courage to change the direction. Don't let that happen.

You asked me about three choices that is A, B, and C. Now isn't it obvious that anybody's career choices include these A, B, and C? How is it possible that if there are two hundred unique individuals sitting over here, all choices are limited to these three?

If you are really unique and you are actually individuals then your career choices will show that. It's more or less a herd mentality. Everybody wants to go in the same direction. How can the same kind of choice be the right choice for everybody, if you are really unique? It is obvious, very obvious that our choices are not our choices. They are coming from our environment. But who has to live your life - you or the environment? Who will live your life? Would you live your life or those people would live your life who are giving you these choices? Yes!

Yes, YOU would live your life. If you are going to live your life, then you must find out that which really calls you.

Do you understand the difference between work and calling?

Working is one thing and realizing your calling is another thing. 'Calling' is a word that is used to describe the work that really beckons you. It is that which if not done will never leave you satisfied.

Most of us never respond to our calling. Most of us even do not know what this 'calling' is. It keeps beckoning you. It keeps giving you signals. If you are insensitive, you will not catch those signals.

If you are afraid, then you don't have space to listen to that little voice. Ask yourself, "What is it that I can do even without being paid?" Can you ask this question to yourself? "What is it that I can do even without being paid?" And if you find something that you can do, and nobody pays money to you, then that is your calling. Find out something that you want to do even if you have to pay money for it. Instead of getting a salary or compensation even if you have to pay the money to do that, you will still do that. That is your calling.

There is the character of Howard Roark, the architect in Ayn Rand's 'The Fountainhead'. Architecture is his calling. He has not taken admission in architecture college because his papa had told him to. Architecture is his life force. He designs a particular building and he says that, "I design it because I am in love with it." The client says, "No, you change the design. If your design is constructed, it will cost me these many dollars extra." Roark says, "You deduct those many dollars from my fees but I will not change the design." When that starts happening, then you know that, "This my calling." "If you want to, you can hold my entire fee, pay me anything but I will not change my design. I love this design."

Is there anything of this nature in your life? And if there is, then it is beautiful. And if there is not, then you better find out.

Have you heard of Richard Branson - the founder of the Virgin Brand? Virgin Atlantic, Virgin Records etc.

Listeners (*everyone*): Yes, Sir.

Speaker: Once he was asked what one should do in life. He said, "If you want to fly kites, fly kites but then give your everything to flying kites."

The question was about entrepreneurship. He said that, “If your heart is in flying kites, then do keep flying kites.” You will be able to make money out of it. One does not need too much for livelihood and that much will be available to you. But then don’t remain confused. Once you find out that you love to fly kites then just fly kites. Become a master in flying kites. And whenever you have mastery in something, life is with you. Unknown forces come to help you. And you benefit in both ways. One, you are doing what you love to do and second, you are getting help from unpredictable quarters.

Won’t it be wonderful that you are being paid for doing something that you anyways enjoying doing? Is that not what you call heaven? “What am I doing? I just do what I enjoy doing and I am also getting some money for it.” Isn’t that beautiful? I am opening the possibility to you. Would that not be beautiful? But that will not open up to you if you keep thinking that life is all about moving in particular well-laid, well-determined directions. If you say that there is only one, or two, or ten ways of earning livelihood that the society has approved of and I will follow only those ways then there is no hope for you.

If you are really unique, then you must have your unique inclinations. Have you tried to nurture them? These unique inclinations could be anything. Somebody just might like watering plants, somebody may just enjoy reading comic books and it could be just anything. You are privileged that you are living in an age where the economy is more open than it was at any other point, where you have the tremendous power of the internet, where the world is economically more prosperous than it ever was, when your country is growing at a heavy rate of growth. Why must you compromise?

Remember, we said right in the beginning that if we are compromising with work, we are compromising with life.

Many of us think this way: “Let me do anything, at the end of the month I will get the paycheck. I will do anything and ultimately, I will get the paycheck at the end of the month. Let me just do anything, I will ultimately get the paycheck at the end of the month. That is what matters.”

But tell me that you may get paid on one particular day in the month, but how many days there are in the month?

Listeners(everyone): Thirty days.

Speaker: How many days there are in the month? Thirty! On how many days will you receive the cheque?

Listeners(everyone): One.

Speaker: One. How many days are left?

Listeners(everyone): Twenty- nine.

Speaker: What will you do in those twenty-nine days? Will you just keep waiting for the cheque? Or will you sleep on those twenty-nine days and wake up on the thirtieth day? You have to live through the entire month. How will you live? How will you get out of your house every day to go to work? How will you do that? How will you spend every hour, every second? How can you be causal about livelihood, work and calling? How can you allow others to dictate you in terms of this regard? Don't forget the woman who boarded the wrong train. And it's not difficult. It's not difficult. You just need to have little Faith.

Anyway the route that you are choosing will not give you what you desire from it. If you think that going on these conventional ways will give you security and a lot of money, anyway it will not give it to you. If everybody decides to go on one single road, what happens to that road?

Listeners (*everyone*): There is a traffic jam.

Speaker: Jam. On a jammed road, does anybody move? You understand what I am trying to say? All of you decide to pursue one particular profession, what will happen to the jobs in that profession? Jam. Will anybody get jobs?

Listeners (*everyone*): No, Sir.

Speaker: India is producing fifteen lakh engineers per year. If they all decide to go in a particular direction, obviously most of them will not reach there.

An advantage with pursuing an un-traded, uncharted path is that the road is clear. If you take the road which may be bumpy, which may not have four lanes, which has just a single lane, which nobody uses, which may be little scary because it passes through the jungles, you will be at an advantage. Why will you be at the advantage? Because nobody will be there on that road. You can do whatever you want. If you want, you can sit on the middle of the road and have a picnic.

But you can't do that on the highway because everybody wants to go on the highway. When everybody will go on the highway of this nature, there will be traffic jams. We all are stuck in the traffic jam, yet we are not searching for our individual route. Remember life is not a highway.

Life is not a place where you can find one common road. Find out your individual road. You all must create your individual path. There are no pre-determined paths. But the mind wants to move on all the paths that have already been used to make use of other's experiences, to do what everybody else is doing. But if you will do that, then do not forget that you have only one life. Anybody here who has come with the inventory of life? "You know I have forty lives. It doesn't matter, let me waste one life. Let me gain experience in three or four lives and then after that I will do something enjoyable."

You have just one life. As far as you are concerned there is only one life, one single precious life. Ask yourself, "What am I doing with it." The entire world is open to you. I repeat, you are lucky to be born in the time of opportunities. Don't waste what time has given you. Don't waste what coincidence has given you. If you love cooking, then you must cook. If you love to run, then run. Let nobody tell you, "How can an engineer go and become a chef?" Let nobody tell you that. Today you have people from IITs and IIMs running real estate firms, who are running laundry services.

If you have gained an education, it should liberate you. It should not enslave you. We find our education enslaving us. We start saying that after getting a big degree, how do I do any small task? I am asking you - Why can't you run a very well-organised, juice shop? I ensure you that you will earn more there than you will earn in your run-of-the-mill job. Then that one juice shop can become a chain. What are these brands, Starbucks, Cafe Coffee Day? They are nothing but tea stalls and coffee shops, right? The tea stalls and coffee shops are now a multinational company.

Why can't you start with your own juice shop? What prevents you?

Rotten belief, a false sense of respectability; that's what holds us back.

“Will I run a juice shop after studying so much?” Your study has become your handicap. “Will I run a small dhaba?”, “Have I studied mechanical engineering just to make these small spare parts?”, “Yes, I love soccer but now I am an electronics engineer. How can I become a soccer coach in a school?”, “I am a computer engineer, how can I go and start teaching the kids of three, four years in a school. How can I open a small school in a village? I am a computer engineer.”

Even though you know that you love to teach, you love to be with the kids, even though you realize that your village is in need of school, still you will not do that. You will not do that. Many of us come from villages and small town. Don't we? Many of us know what is needed at our place. There is a tremendous opportunity there. But we won't do that. Why won't we do that? I am asking you. Why not? Why must you aspire to be in Bangalore, Gurgaon and California? Why not about your native place?

So, Sonu, it's not a question of option A, B and C. There is D, there is E, there is F, right up to Z. And it doesn't stop there.

As all of you are individuals, you must find your individual calling. That is the only way of living. Everything else is hell.

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~ Chapter 4 ~

Is hard work the key to success?

Question: Sir, everyone says that hard work is the key to success. Is this true?

Speaker: Rohit is asking that is hard work the key to success. Rohit, you have picked two entities and asked whether they can be equated.

You have said 'hard work' and you have said 'success'. You are asking whether the two are synonymous. Does one lead to the other? Is one a guarantee to the other? Is the presence of one necessary for the presence of the other?

How do I know whether 'A' equals 'B', when I neither understand 'A' nor do I understand 'B'? You are asking me that, "Is 'A' equal to 'B'?" I am asking you, "What is 'A' and what is 'B'?"

Let us understand that. Then it will be very easy to understand whether 'A' equals 'B'.

What is hard work?

Work is of two kinds. One is the work that you have read of in your Physics book which is the expenditure of energy, the kind of work that you can measure in calories, joules and electron volts. It is the physical work. We are not too bothered about it because it is anyway happening all the time in nature. That physical work is mere energy and energy keeps getting converted from one form to another.

The other kind of work which is more significant is mental effort, is mental churning, is mental happening. Getting it?

These are two kinds of work. One is the activity that takes place physically. The activity that takes place physically is not really work, even though your physics text-books would have made you believe so. You know there is something called as 'basal metabolic rate'? You know even when you are sitting here, you are 'working'? You are working physically without any mental work happening. Even as your body is burning energy, metabolism is happening. But you are not thinking about it. It is just happening on its own. You may be very peaceful, very silent, yet work is happening.

We have chanced upon a very significant statement. You can sit very silently and yet work is happening. The heart is beating. The system is digesting food, blood is following, lungs are operating. Yet nothing is happening in the mind. Nothing is wrong. Without your intervention, even without mental work, physical work is happening. Even without any mental work, physical work is happening. When even without mental work physical work happens, then there is no need of anything called 'success'. Then what is happening is just happening, nicely, smoothly, beautifully.

Now, contrast this with another situation. I am all the time thinking of success. I am constantly thinking of success even without moving my hands and feet. That is what mostly happens. There is a lot of thought which may not be necessarily accompanied by physical activity. In the first situation you had physical activity without thought. No mental activity but physical work was happening. I am saying contrast this with another situation where there is no physical activity yet there is a lot of mental activity that is planning, projection, ambitions, "I want success, I want success." And that is very-very tiring, extremely tiring. Are you getting this?

Surely physical work is needed. But let that physical work not come from a lot of mental activity. What you call as 'success' is nothing but a concept of

the mind and it requires a lot of mental movement. You are constantly 'thinking' of success. So, mental work is happening. Mental work is happening and happening. All this happens when you are chasing success.

Real success is when you understand something, and out of that understanding you immediately start acting. I have understood something, and when I have understood something the mental movement has stopped.

Till what point does the mental movement continue? The mental movement will continue only till the point I have not understood. When I have understood, the mental work stops, it is settled, closed. The mind is peaceful and the body is acting. There is no need for the churning to keep happening in my head. There is no need of mental work. Pure physical work is happening even without my intervention. I have understood and that understanding is translating into action. A lot of hard work is happening without me trying to do it. It is happening without 'me'.

Let us take a day-to-day example. Let us say that there was a particular day in the college when you did not like attending your sessions and from eight in the morning to four or five in the evening all you did was attend the sessions, all you did was just sit and walk, but no great physical activity. At 5 p.m. you felt tired mentally, even though you had expended just two hundred kilo-calories. After 5 p.m. you go to play soccer. In playing soccer you spend a thousand kilo-calories, five times the amount you spent in the entire day. In playing soccer, a lot of physical work had happened but it did not tire you down. That is because the real hard work 'just' happened. You were not thinking every moment, "I have to chase the ball, I have to pass it, I have to do this way."

The crux of the matter is, live in understanding. When you understand something, hard work happens on its own.

In fact, more physical hard work happens than you can otherwise do. Then you don't have to 'do' hard work. Then you are not mentally tired. Great work happens even without your thinking and planning. It is just happening out of your understanding, and that understanding itself is success.

So, yes hard work is the key to success but not mental hard work. Thought will not lead to success. The settlement of thoughts, the understanding, that is success.

Thought always says, "I will lead to success." In thought, success is always in the future, "I will lead to success." In understanding success is right now, in that very moment, instantaneous, immediate. "I have understood and I have started acting", and that is success. "I have understood and because I have understood, action is simply happening. Action does not wait for my permission. It even does not ask for my intervention. I have attained such clarity that I have to act." Action will happen. This is success irrespective of the result. It does not wait for the result in future, that in future result will come and then we will decide whether it is a success or a failure.

"I have understood and from that understanding the action is happening and that action itself is success, right now."

The notion that you talked of that you will work hard and in that working hard a particular result will come and that particular result will be called as 'success', this notion is obviously not valid. Are you getting it?

Listener 2: Why do we distinguish between success and failure?

Speaker: We distinguish between successful and failure because all our activity, all our work is only for something in the future, the attainment of which we call as ‘success’, and non-attainment of which we call as ‘failure’.

See, we never do anything for its own sake. Whenever we are acting, we are acting to attain something ahead of us. So what is important, the action or the attainment? Action is right now, attainment is in the future. Whenever we act, whenever a common man acts, it is for the sake of the attainment in the future. The action has very little value.

In our mind, in the conditioned mind, the value is given to that result, that attainment in the future. So, it is obvious that when ‘that’ result is important, the attainment of it will be called as ‘success’, and the non-attainment of it will be called as ‘failure’. But if there could be a mind, if there could be man who finds Joy in the action itself, then ‘success’ and ‘failure’ will have no value.

If you give importance to the result, if the result is what you are chasing, then success and failure will be of great value and all that is happening right now will only bore you down. You will never be present into it fully, because your mind will be there, ahead, then something is to be attained. So, that is one kind of success, to be obtained in the future.

When success is to be attained in the future then the present does not have any value, then the action in the present does not have any value. The other kind of success is in the present, that is happening which ought to happen. “I am successful right now because the action right now is arising out of my understanding.”

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~ Chapter 5 ~

Play hard, not work hard

Question: Sir, what will happen if I stop working hard?

Speaker: It is a deep, deep conditioning to say that hard work is necessary. Look at the entire existence around you. Do you think anything, anybody, any creature in existence is working hard? Everybody is simply partying, enjoying, celebrating, and dancing. Man is the only one who has condemned himself to labour. Nothing else labours. Though they dance around with vigorous energy, but there is no labour involved in that.

Have you seen a river flowing, the way it flows? There is great energy in that, but it is not working. It is not 'working'. There is so much energy in a flowing river that it runs all your power plants. But is the river working? Look at the eagle that is soaring in the sky. It is not working. There is just playfulness.

Man is the only one who has told himself that 'hard' work is the key to success. That is why you are asking this question that what will happen if you stop working hard. It would be wonderful if you stop working hard. Play hard, that is important. Anything that is substantial comes from playing hard, not from working hard.

Play hard, celebrate like a mad-man. And that is life, not hard work, not hard work. When you are playing hard, then hard work just happens, without your doing. "I am enjoying it so much that I am giving it every ounce of energy that I have."

Listener 2: That is hard work.

Speaker: Yes, that is hard work.

Listener 2: Then what is the difference between playing hard and working hard?

Speaker: Playing hard is purposeless. You do not want anything from it, except enjoyment. Working hard always has a target.

Playing hard means that I am always happy, that I am dancing around. Working hard means that I am so sad that I must get something. They are opposites.

Playing hard means that I am so contented that I can dance and play. Working hard means that I am feeling like a beggar. It means that I must work hard to attain something. They are opposites.

Do you get the difference? Play hard, do whatever you want to do but with a deep contentment in your heart. The heart must always be contented, and then your work becomes play and, that is beautiful.

There are two ways of working.

One is with a heart that is empty. That's a beggar's heart. "Let me get something", "I am studying for the sake of mark.", "I am working for the sake of salary", "I am meeting somebody for the sake of some pleasure." This is the beggar's way of living.

The king's way of living is, "I am so happy that I am meeting you. I am so full of joy that I am simply distributing it to everybody."

Listener 1: But Sir, we have always been told that if you want something, you have to work hard for it. If I don't have anything to achieve in life, why will I work?

Speaker: So, to make you do something, what is implanted in your mind? Your logic is, “Unless I feel dissatisfied, why will I work?” So, if I want you to work, what will I put in your mind? Listen to me again (*emphatically*). You are saying that unless you are dissatisfied, you will not work. So, if there is somebody who wants to make you work, what should he do? He should make you feel very dissatisfied about yourself, because only dissatisfaction is your engine.

Listener 3: Because that is demoralization.

Speaker: That’s wonderful. So this means all your work emerges from demoralization. You have been made to feel dissatisfied about yourself since a very long time. Family, society, education, religion all these have continuously told you that there is something missing in you, that there is something wrong about you and you must work hard to make up for it. You are not good enough as you are. You have been made to feel small, petty, and inadequate.

And you have been told that if you want to become something, if you want to gain any bit of worthiness, then you should ‘do’ something. “You do not deserve my love if you do not get ninety percent.” Even love is conditional. “There is something seriously wrong with you if you do not get ninety percent.”

Listener 3: So, if it is based on conditions, then it is not love.

Speaker: Then it is not love. But that is what we have been brought up upon, something that is not love at all.

Listener 2: Sir, is there anything that is unconditional?

Speaker: Don’t you know that? Don’t you know that?

Listener 2: You are telling that if I get ninety percent, then only parents will love me. But in every case there is a condition. Is there anything unconditional?

Speaker: Ever been to a strange place where you are unlikely to go again? A new place, let us say a hill station. Have you ever met a dog there? A beautiful dog. Let us say, you go to a hill station, you meet a dog there and you pat the dog. You were unlikely to see the dog ever again. Why did you touch it with love? The dog cannot give you anything. It is not your dog either. You would never see it again. Why did you touch it with love?

Does it answer your question? Is there something unconditional? You are not demanding anything, you just want to give. It is possible, it is possible.

What is the central problem? The central problem is that we have been made to feel small about ourselves. That is the central problem. I am saying this repeatedly to you. Fundamentally there is nothing small about you, there is nothing missing in you. All the diseases of life, all your unease, all your gossip, all your restlessness arise from this deep-rooted conditioning that there is something wrong and missing in you. Kindly get rid of that notion.

You are wonderful, perfect, beautiful. With all your inadequacies, you are still very beautiful. With all the layers of conditioning that you have, you are still wonderful.

A diamond may fall in the mud, but does that reduce its price? You are very, very valuable. But those who do not know their own diamond nature, they make everybody feel small. In fact, there are only two kinds of people in the world - One who feel small, the other who feel complete and dance.

The ones who keep feeling small about themselves, their only purpose in life is to make others feel small. The one who is afraid will necessarily spread fear around him. Have you not seen such people? Exams are approaching and she is shivering. So what does she do? She calls up five others. And what does she do to those five? Does she give them courage?

Listener 4: No.

Speaker: What does she do? The one who feels small, ends up making everybody feel small. Beware of such people. They might be very close to you, yet be extremely cautious of them.

Listener 3: And the one who is complete?

Speaker: The one who is complete will obviously radiate completeness.

Listener 3: How would we know if someone is complete? Completeness is impossible.

Speaker: How do you feel when you are with a person? Do you start feeling more and more inadequate, or do you gain a certain relaxation? That 'presence' will tell you. Do not be so certain. Do not be so certain that completeness is impossible.

Completeness is not impossible. It is your very nature. How can it be impossible? It is there, covered, yet there.

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~ Chapter 6 ~

The Power of the Leader arises from his Core

Speaker: So, the question is about leadership and power. What is the relationship between them? Does a leader exercise power?

What is power? Why does the mind want to exercise power?

Listeners (*everyone*): To control others.

Speaker: To control others. Let's see.

There are two kinds of minds. What are the two kinds?

One, that is free to be aware, but yet it is all full of influences. And the other, that is clear of garbage, clear of conditioning.

One chief characteristic of conditioning, of influences, is that an influenced mind wants to influence. Just as a virus wants to spread, similarly an influenced mind wants to influence. Power is the need to influence.

Why does the conditioned mind want to influence others? It wants to influence others because it sees that something is missing, something is wrong. It senses some kind of a deficiency within. And it thinks that it can make up for that deficiency by getting something from outside, by making others do what he desires from them.

I have a conditioned mind and because I am conditioned I will not be at ease. Dis-ease is what I will experience, right? I have a conditioned mind. Because I experience dis-ease, what do I do? I want to search for some kind of a remedy, a treatment.

But a characteristic of this dis-ease, or conditioning is that you do not look for a treatment within yourself. You are not actually even aware of the real nature of the dis-ease. You think you can get rid of your discomfort, your restlessness by doing something outside. Power is the name of doing something outside. “Can I do this? Can I make this change happen? Can I make that person follow my wish?” All this is what we call power.

Hunger for power comes from an inner restlessness, an inner void, an inner deficiency. And a deep hunger for power indicates a deep disease. This is the first kind of mind; running after power. And what is their definition of power? The world will follow my desire. As if the world following your desire will give you what you want!

What you want is peace, but you don’t even know that. You think that if everybody offers you obedience, if everybody acts in a particular way in front of you, if systems and people are subservient to your wish, then you will feel good. No, you will not feel good. You may tell yourself that it’s all very nice but deep within that void will still remain. The pain will be there and now the suffering will magnify because you are seeing that even by getting so much of control over the world, imagined or otherwise, there is no real control. Even after getting so much of control over the world, my real problem is still the same. So you now have an added pain of failure. “I did whatever I could do, I fought, I obtained power, I won, I struggled, I made so much of effort, and yet my situation is as pathetic as it ever was.”

This is the destiny of the man who runs after power. He does not even realize his real problem. He is searching for solutions to a very superficial – even imaginary problem. And running after an imaginary problem is a sure shot way to forget the real problem.

Then we said that there is another kind of mind which looks at itself, another eye which is not always looking at the world.

Now we are talking of the mind which looks first at itself. It says, “Before I try to influence anybody else, can I please change my own ways? If I say that the world needs a change, then it’s me who is looking at the world. Am I sure that I am looking rightly at the world? Am I sure? I might be tipsy.” I am drunk out of my senses and I think that there is something wrong with the world. I do not consider that I am unable to grasp the real nature of the world. But I say that, “You know that there is this thing wrong with the system, this thing wrong with my friends, this thing wrong with organizations.” I do not realize that organizations are not what I am thinking of them; that the world is not what I imagine it to be.

You see, there was a man. He returned home drunk, totally drunk. Now he had locked his house from outside and he was carrying the key. So, what is he attempting now? The lock is hanging and he is trying to open the lock with the key. But because he is drunk, he is unable to put the key in the hole. He is attempting and attempting. But every time he brings the key to the lock, what happens to the lock? The lock moves this way and that way, it sways.

Now, someone else is watching him for a long time. It’s half an hour and this man is unable to enter his house because he can’t open the lock. So he says, “Can I come and help you? Can I come and help you open the lock?” The drunkard says, “No, no, I don’t need help. Just hold the wall. The wall is shivering. The wall is shivering so much that I am unable to put the key in it.” I do not realize that my mind is drunk. What do I say? “The wall is shaky. Please hold the wall, the wall needs help. I don’t need help, the wall needs help.”

The second man whose mind is clear, whose faculty to look at himself is not asleep, says, “Why am I feeling diseased?” He does not come to quick answers. He looks within. He tries to probe. He says, “The lock could not be shaking. Surely something in my mind is wrong. Can I look at it?”

Now this is the second and real kind of power; power not over the world, but over my own mind because the world is anyway what I make it out to be. What is the wall doing? Shivering. Why is it shivering? Because I am saying it is shivering. What is the world? Bad. Why is the world bad? Because I think it is bad and I look only at what I call as bad. And what is the definition of bad? Something of my construction. Is that clear?

I look within and what do I find there? I find that various forces have been trying to capture my mind. What are the names of those forces? Media, friends, colleagues, family, society, religion, all kinds of inputs that goes into the mind. When you look sharply at the mind what do you find? You find that these diseases are trying to take control of your mind and because it's your mind, you must fight them. This is real power.

“I will not allow anything, anybody, any thought to take control of my mind. My mind is my seat. My mind is my throne. Only pure intelligence can be seated there. No social influence. No influence of any kind. **The real battle is within.**” This is Real Power.

But what do I do instead? You see, I am trying to fight a thousand battles outside. I am saying that I will get power when I defeat that person. And who is defeating that person? You, who is already a slave of a thousand forces. Now when you are already a slave of a thousand forces even if you win a battle outside, will it be your victory?

Suppose there is a slave. And the slave goes out and fights a battle and wins it. Can the slave say that I have won? Such is our condition. We are fighting a thousand battles. But when they are not our battles, when everything that we do is being dictated by influences, even our victory is not our victory. What we are calling as having power is not power at all. I wrote an exam and I got selected and I am thinking that I have succeeded. But why did I write the exam? I wrote the exam only because my mind was terribly influenced to write the exam. I was made to write that exam. Now even if I succeed in that exam, is it my success? Is it my success? What right do I have to say that I have power and I used that power and I succeeded?

Now I have been conditioned to influence everybody. We said that this is a characteristic of conditioning. Conditioning wants to condition. A conditioned mind would end up conditioning others as well. I have been conditioned to influence others. And how do I influence others? Sometimes by having power over them, explicit, violent; sometimes by acting sweet; sometimes by acting pretty. Now when I act sweet and pretty and someone gets influenced by me, what do I feel? I have won. Now have you won? You were trained to act pretty and sweet. Someone else is laughing. The real mischief-maker is having a good time. You don't even realize.

Ayn Rand has said that the most depraved man is the one who goes after power. She says that the man who is running after power is the poorest man of all, because real poverty lies within. His mind is extremely impoverished. He is starving.

So, first of all realize that what we normally call as power is not power at all. It is just an expression of our slavery. Secondly, if you must have power, you must have power over your own mind. You must have power over all the influences that are trying to capture your mind.

Real power is to remain free. Real power is to fight all the forces that want to make you a slave. That is Real Power.

Now tell me then, who would be a Real Leader? The one who tries to capture power here and there? Or the one who says that my being, my thought, my mind must be untouched. It must be pure.

Who is the Real leader?

Listeners (*everyone*): The second One.

Speaker: And remember, just as conditioning wants to influence and spread, freedom from conditioning also spreads. The fake leader spreads fakeness through influence. The Real leader spreads freedom through his presence. His very presence is enough. He does not need to influence.

Conditioning spreads through influence. Freedom from conditioning spreads through presence.

The Real leader's presence is enough. His presence is his power.

The power of the fake leader comes from his designation, from all the things that have been given to him, from all the things that he has acquired from outside. His power, his so-called authority comes from outside. Now all these things can be taken away, right? You are travelling in a big car; the big car can be taken away. You have a fancy designation; the designation can go. You have lots of money; the money can disappear.

But the Real leader, his actions are not through what society has given him. His being is enough.

That is the test of the real leader and the fake leader. The fake leader will collapse if you take away his designation, his identity, his name, his perks. He will have nothing left. And nobody will listen to him.

But for the Real leader, take away everything from him, yet he loses nothing. His authority doesn't come from what the society has given him. **His authority rests within him. His own being is the authority.**

He does not say, "Listen to me because I am the chairman of such and such organization." He will not say that. Because if someone has to listen to you when you are the chairman of an organization, he will not listen to you when you are no more the chairman. The seat goes, the chair goes, and you too go. If someone bothers for you only because your vehicle is carrying that red or blue beacon, then the moment that vehicle is taken away you are nobody. You have nothing to support yourself, nothing to stand with. That is not at all real leadership. That power is not real.

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~ Chapter 7 ~

What is professionalism?

Question: What is the meaning of being a professional?

Speaker: What is professionalism all about? Is it just about serving your profession with excellence or is it something more than that? Whenever we hear this word ‘professional’, an image comes to the mind. Is professionalism that image?

Clearly there are two layers to this question.

One - Can professionalism be defined by a certain code of conduct, a certain personality, a certain way of carrying yourself? That is the first part and that is how most of us know professionals to be. So this first layer is very important. Is professionalism about that?

Two - It is about the profession itself. If professionalism is all about being excellent, then the question is, “Being excellent in which profession?”

Let’s look at the first layer.

What do you do when you walk into an interview room? You start wearing clothes that look like the clothes of a professional, right? You aren’t the professional yet; but because most of us have confused professionalism with the image of a professional, so we think professionalism is nothing but this image. You talk in a particular manner, that is called as professional. You wear a particular kind of clothes, that is called as professional. You carry yourself in a particular way, and that is called as professional.

Surely this layer, the first layer is a very superficial layer. Very, very superficial layer! A code of conduct, or the way of carrying yourself, or a

certain persona does not mean that you are excellent in the profession.

What about this profession? We are not yet taking this question. That is layer two.

Whatever be the profession, wherever it is coming from, it may be an altogether external influence, but no one can know the depth of your excellence by the way you carry yourself. All this can be manipulated and it is used mostly for manipulation only. Nothing else! People work totally substance-less. They would prefer to walk and talk in certain borrowed, copied ways and the world is deceived.

The world is cute. What does the world think? “These must be professionals.” Because the world has no eyes. It is a stupid world we live in. It has no eyes to look at the essence of the person, the individual. It is too eager to judge everybody. And how does it judge? By the appearance, by the words, by the looks. And so words and looks have come to hold an unreasonably important space in our minds. They do not deserve that space.

The very questions - “How am I looking?”, “What am I wearing?”, “How am I speaking?” are not at all very important questions. At least it can’t be the central question in your life. “How do I look to others?” And that looking is not just your physical looking. That looking is also about your image in the eyes of others. Unfortunately, it has become very, very central question in our lives and that is also how we know a professional.

It’s none of your fault. Since you were very small, all you saw was- ‘P is for Pilot’. And who is a pilot? He is wearing a particular cap and a particular uniform. Now, does that cap or the uniform make a pilot? But then you were so small and the message that goes to your mind is that anybody who can wear that cap and can look nice and smart is a pilot. This is a totally

erroneous relation that is established in our minds. But it is alright! A child's brain is not yet fully developed, so it is alright if this kind of an erroneous relation gets established there. But none of us are kids now. How come our minds are still deceived?

Haven't you noticed how you become respectful the moment you come across someone wearing a particular kind of dress? Someone walks-in, in a proper professional coat and tie, and the rest of it, and you get impressed. You are impressed and it is no wonder now that you will be taken for a ride.

Coats impress you? Is that all you have learnt in your lives - to be impressed by coats, trousers and neckties?

(Silence)

You don't look into the eyes, you don't look into the man; the coat is all that you can see. So, professionalism has come to mean a certain way of behaving, a certain way of talking, relating, expressing. And when you say you want to become a professional, the image that comes to your mind is of that – “I am an engineer”, and the image that comes to you is not of someone who is deeply engrossed in an analytic equation, but of someone who is wearing a particular dress or who is being found at a particular place.

So if there are C.S. students, then they are imagining themselves in some office in California. Now, what does that office have to do with software engineering? The office is bricks, mortar and glass. What have bricks, mortar and glass to do with software engineering? But that's the image that comes to your mind.

If you are a civil engineer, the image that comes to your mind is that you are wearing a yellow helmet with a torch, and a lamp on it. Now what does this lamp has to do with civil engineering? Nothing. But that's the image that comes to your mind. And that is what the little kids do. The little girls, they will wear long coats and play 'doctor-doctor'. Haven't you seen them? For them being a doctor is all about wearing that coat and writing prescription. And what do they write in their prescriptions? What do they write?

(Silence)

We still haven't grown up. You know what most of us if given a chance to work at a place, in an organisation which is housed in not so impressive a building, a shady building, it may be a start-up, it does not look like the great office of that great MNC listed in NASDAQ, we will not work there, even if the actual work is better there. You would rather work in an office that looks like a high-profile office, even if you are doing utterly clerical work there. You will feel more like a professional in that Bangalore or California office; even if you are nothing but a clerk there. It is all because in your mind, being a professional is so much about the external, the thing that is outwards.

It's a beautiful word that doctors or lawyers or architects use - 'Practice'. 'Practice' means doing! What counts is where the thing can really be practiced. What counts is where the thing can really be done, not appearance. 'Practice' means that a surgeon is actually able to conduct the surgery. That is practice. The lawyer is actually able to fight a case. That is practice. Or practice is just about wearing that black coat?

Listeners (everyone): No, Sir.

Speaker: But very soon, one year or sooner, you will be standing in queue for employment and you will forget all this. You will totally forget it.

Have you ever wondered how a company can come to you and in its presentation show a grand picture of its office and impress you? It is so because no one of you is intelligent enough to get up and ask, “But this is brick and mortar. What does it have to do with software or electronics?” None of you will ask that. Or say, “Why are you showing civil engineering work to us? If you just want to impress us, show us a picture of a five-star hotel, we will be all the more impressed. What does that have to do with the work that I will be doing?”

You don’t ask about the work and that is why the company shows you the picture of the office. You won’t ask much of that because you are trained to think of a professional only in terms of his personality.

Now the second part - **What is a profession?**

Profession is livelihood, right? This question is actually asking, “What work is? What is worth doing in life?”

I ask you, “Have you ever wondered how much of your waking time you are going to spent working?” Around 70%! In your waking hours you will be investing around 70% of your time working. This is the most critical question in your life. What is worth doing in these hours? This 70% of my waking time!

This is your life. Work is your life as it is going to consume so much of your time. It is life. Have you ever bothered to deeply enquire? Do you love yourself? Do you love your life? If you do, then don’t you want to see what

can be made out of this life? What is worth doing in this life? Don't you want to find out?

Listeners (*everyone*): Yes, Sir.

Speaker: You must find out. You must. Your work is your life and your life is your work. If those working hours are boring and full of conflict, what will become of your life? What will be the quality of your life? Life will be boring, dull and sapped of energy.

What is worth doing? What is not worth doing?

You surely cannot pick a profession just out of an influence cast on you by somebody or some force. Unfortunately, most of us pick up a profession or a trade, unfortunately most of us enter into a particular stream of studies, being dictated by somebody, not really knowing ourselves. And if a profession comes to you, not out of your knowing but out of a social factor, your family telling you something or following the current trend, then you are in for a life of confusion and conflict.

I used to ask that how is it possible that when a particular organisation visits a campus, 3/4th of the campus wants to apply to it. How can the same company be the dream company of, say 400 students? Where is individuality in all this? Where are You in all this? I only see a flock of sheep having same kind of jobs, same kind of pattern of higher studies, as if the script has been written beforehand for you, as if it has been pre-decided for you that this going to happen to you.

Oh, you will have a little bit of choices, alright, but all that has been settled well in advance. That is how a profession comes to us. Decided well in advance; but with a little bit of tinker here and there. Don't want to do M.S.,

fine, do M.B.A but that is it. Do not try to cross the boundary. Don't want to go to Electronics, alright, here is IT, but that is it. Don't jump the fence!

Is that how profession must come to us? Or is profession something lively? If profession is life, then you need to look at it with greater care, deeper enquiry.

Doesn't this topic deserve more investigation? Are some of us are able to see the need to look at the question of profession with great sincerity, with great clarity?

Listeners (*everyone*): Yes, Sir.

Speaker: You cannot just keep drifting, and at the end of a particular day you will find that you are into this profession. You will be inviting a life of great suffering and boredom. Our world is full of such people who entered into their professions for just the wrong reasons. Somebody told them that government job is wonderful; it gives security and respect, and they entered into it. And then they wonder that why they don't want to work, and whine about their work all the time. Lazy, clumsy, dull, bored! Because that is how they got their profession. Somebody got it from his father. "I have a shop, now I pass on the shop to you." You take it forward. That is how profession came to him. Now any wonder that the man is always irritated? He will be irritated. Do you want a life of boredom, frustration and irritation? Do you?

Listeners (*everyone*): No, Sir.

Speaker: Then find out.

Listener 1: Can we say that if there is tea maker who sells more tea than anybody in the area, then he is a good professional?

Speaker: See, profession is not about doing good in terms of selling this and that. Please listen to this very attentively. The quality of the profession is defined by the quality of your life in it, not by the amount of sales you generate, not by the kind of respect society gives you for being in a profession. And quality of life is just not about how much money it gives you. It's about love with which you can come to it. It's about the energy you can give to it.

Want to know whether you are in a right profession or not?

If you prefer to stay in it even if it does not give you any money then you can know that you are in the right profession. If there is something you can give your life to then know that you are in the right profession.

“It does not pay me well, I do not make much money out of doing this and yet I want to do this and there is nothing else that comes to me.” Then you know you are in a right profession. And only then the life is worth living.

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~ Chapter 8 ~

The decorated highway of success or The naked sky of freedom?

Speaker: Aman has asked, “What should I choose - a life of correctness or a life of exploration?”

First of all we have to understand that why this question is arising in his mind. What is correctness?

‘Correctness’ as the word, as the notion exists in our mind, is probably about following a beaten path. If I have to go from here to somewhere then I already know this is the path that I ought to take. So many others have taken this path. This path has been recommended to me by teachers, friends, family. Whenever I look around I see people taking this path. So, this must be the correct path. After all I just have to reach from here till there. Reaching is important. Why waste time in thinking too much about the path, especially when the path is so easily obvious? It is a proven path. Everybody has been taking this path. So, why bother to enquire about this or that. I already know. Take this road, walk, reach there.

This is what probably we mean by correctness. It is already correct. It is well known in advance through others.

Then there is exploration. What he means by exploration is, “As I stand here, not only do I not have a definite notion, a fixed notion about the path that I want to take, I also have not asserted my mind where I want to reach.”

In the first situation, you just want to do the ‘correct’ things. There are many people who just want to do the correct things. In the lives of those

people who are very fond of correctness, first of all the ends are fixed, where you want to reach, the target, the goal. The ends are fixed and also the paths, the means, they are also fixed. These are the people who worry a lot about correctness, who are afraid of being incorrect. Where does their correctness come from?

Listeners (*everyone*): Others.

Speaker: Others have told them that, “That is the place to go and this is the path to take.”

Then there is a second kind of people who are explorers. What happens with them? They stand with no fixed concept of where they ought to reach. Life is not work for them. Life is not a project for them. Life, for them, is not – “This is the project that we need to complete. This and this way and the way also need to be correct.” Life is just a game, a sport for them.

So, what would they do? They would go and find. They would look about. They would not say that anything is prohibited for them. “This is the highway that goes till that point, but who has prohibited me from looking right and left of that highway. Nobody has prohibited me. The highway is nice, very-very nice, everybody is travelling on the highway. There is nothing that prevents me from looking at the greenery around and maybe there are small tracks that move on the side of the highway that lead to beautiful places. I will explore, I will find out.”

Remember, the first kind of people have been told in advance, where to go and what kind of path to take, which road to take. I am calling it a highway because everybody takes this path. When so many people move on a path, they call it a highway.

The second kind of people explore, they are not obsessed with the highways. They do not care much about the highways. They say, “Highways are alright if we feel alright travelling on the highways. But then on the side of the highway there are such beautiful and nice things.”

Have you seen the people who travel on highways? Their eyes are always on the...

Listeners (*everyone*): Road.

Speaker: On the road. If you are travelling on the highway and you are also in a great hurry to reach where you want to go, the only thing important in your mind is your destination, where you want to reach.

Would you really care to look at what is going around, this side and that side, especially when you are driving? Will you do that? You won't do that. It is because your mind is full of thoughts of the destination. “We need to reach there and this is the path we are taking. Then what do we have to do with this and that?”

So, often they appear to reach their destination, but they do not enjoy anything. They do not enjoy anything. The highway does not really have the beauty of life. The explorer is less concerned with what is artificial, what is target orientated, with what leads to somewhere. He is more concerned with playing, with enjoying, so he will stop. He will go deep to enjoy the fields and if there are jungles this side, he will go deep into the jungles as well. He might meet some interesting people out there. Oh, it's quite likely he might encounter with danger. But dangers have their own thrill, right?

As young people do you really want to avoid all dangers? That would be very-very cowardly. Won't it be? Who wants to avoid all dangers? A bit of

threat here and there is alright, that adds to life, makes it spicy. Doesn't it? These are the explorers. They are not really obsessed with the ways of life. They dare to go this side and that side. They dare to stop to look at the sky as well. How many of you ever look at the sky when you are driving? You reach the sky if you look at the sky. You need to be an explorer for that, who first parks his bike and who says that I am not in a hurry. Would you park your bike and look at the sky? The explorer is never in a hurry. He doesn't really have to reach anywhere. He always has time. He is not in the competition.

If you are racing your bike with somebody would you stop at the roadside and look at the flower on the side? Would you? You are racing your bike, you are in competition with someone, you can't look at the sideways. Would you? You can't.

The explorer does not do all these things. He is brave. He does not compete. He already knows that he is a winner, there is no need to compete. He is the winner always. He does not have a need to compete. In the eyes of the achiever, in the eyes of this person who does all the correct things, the explorer is the big fool. Are you getting it?

In the eyes of the achiever, the explorer is the loser. He says, "See, he doesn't race, he doesn't compete. He is not thinking about reaching anywhere. He will be left behind in life." That's what they think about the explorer. That is not the truth. You ask the explorer. You meet him, you look at his face and you will find a lot of joy. You will find a certain radiance. You will know that this fellow is not a loser. In fact, he is the only one who is living life fully. He is enjoying it. He is really-really enjoying it.

Who is enjoying it - the go-getter or the explorer?

Listener 1: The explorer.

Speaker: The explorer. Now, having come so far, will you tell me that what do we mean by these highways? I have talked of the beaten path, I have talked of the highway. What do these represent?

In your life are there any highways? There are surely. Tell me about them. What do we mean by highway, the beaten path that everybody is taking? What is everybody doing?

Listener 2: There is no highway.

Speaker: There is no highway. I see everybody doing something. What is it that all of you seem to be doing?

Listener 3: Copying others.

Speaker: Copying others. In what ways we are copying others? Have you seen a highway? Vehicle after vehicle, all moving in the same direction and in the same way. Is our life something of that sort? Vehicles after vehicles all trying to go to the same place. All moving one after the another. Yes, is our life something of that sort? Where are we all going? Is there some place that we all want to reach? Is there something that we all demand? Alright, let me make it easier for you. What is that most of you want? You know that I want this and my neighbor wants this. What is it?

Listener 4: Success.

Speaker: It is success. So, the name for the highway is the 'highway of success'. Give a more concrete name to this thing. When do you call yourself as successful?

Listener 5: When we achieve something.

Speaker: When you achieve something. What is it that you want to achieve?

Listener 6: Name, fame.

Speaker: Name, fame and money - that is the highway. Everybody is going on that. Can I have a bit of reputation please? Give me some money. Will some company hire me? That is the highway. The go-getter is always on the highway, running, racing, huffing and puffing. Always sweating, afraid. What is it that he is afraid of? "It is a grand race, always going on. Will others beat me in the race? Will I reach that destination?" He is always looking back over his shoulders, looking at who is following him. He is always trying to look far at the horizon thinking that who are ahead of me.

"What is my percentage? What is the percentage of the fellow on the right? What is my salary package? How many friends do I have on Facebook? He has a girlfriend, he too has a girlfriend. Where is mine?" That is the highway.

"I have reached a certain age, certain time. By this time, I should have reached this place. I am thirty now, where is marriage?" That is the highway on which everybody is going. That is that correct thing to do in life.

I know that most of us are very interested in doing the correct things in life. But I am sure that we have a few explorers as well here. They are the real salt of the earth. They are the ones really worth talking to. I speak for them. I am not interested in those who have already made up their mind to do the correct things, who are very afraid to leave the highway.

Anybody here who want to live a life of the explorer? Who wants to be explorer? (*Looking at the audience*) Raise your hand hands. Let everybody

see.

(Some listeners raise their hands)

These handful of people, if they can sustain what they have just said, they will actually reach somewhere. The go-getters will run their entire life and will catch nothing. The explorer doesn't run to reach and he finds that he has already reached.

Yes! Scared? The exploration is dangerous. On the side of highways you may meet few robbers or dangerous snakes. You might also meet a beautiful girl. It is worth getting down from the highway. Would you?

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~ **Self** ~

*“To go beyond yourself,
come close to yourself”*

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~ Chapter 1 ~

You have forgotten the key to yourself

Question: Sir, good afternoon. While I speak before you, I will try to choose my words very gracefully. Sir, I have many things in my life that keep me happy but it is life and we are not supposed to have everything. I have lacked something in my life that I can say as self-motivation. Sir, how do I get self-motivated?

Speaker: What you are really asking for is not motivation. So, first of all let us make a little bit of semantic correction.

Do you know what motive is? A motive implies a desire. A motive implies a target. All motives are outside of you and hence all motives are a kind of greed. To be motivated means to have a desire to attain something outside of you. “That is my motive. That is my target. That is what I want. That is what I want to attain. That is my motive.”

You have talked of two kinds of motivations. Let us look at both of them. One is external motivation which you kind of don’t like and then there is self-motivation that you are asking for.

What is this external motivation? You see, external motivation is when somebody comes to you, speaks to you, fills your mind with his thoughts, gives a goal to you and you feel like going towards that goal.

But you forget that those thoughts and that goal have been given to you by somebody else. The thoughts appear powerful now, the goal appears tempting now but the power and temptation will stay only as long as that person is there. When the motivator goes away, the motivation also goes away.

You would have seen that happen. Somebody comes and fills you up with energy and you feel that this is it. “Yes! Now I can move mountains.” But the next day, back to your slovenly self. Because it was very external; it was just a borrowed thing that was coming from outside and hence went back. It was not yours at all. This is the first kind of motivation.

The second kind of motivation is when you say that it is “my own motivation” and that is what you are calling as ‘self-motivation.’ What is that?

So, you go to the highway, you look at a particular hoarding and what do you see? A new mobile phone has entered the market. You already have a decent phone but you look at that advertisement and at first when you look at it, the advertisement hardly has any effect upon you. You say, “I already have a mobile. It is just six months old. I don’t need a new one.” But the advertiser is clever, quite cunning. He repeats that advertisement; he bombards your mind with the advertisements in newspaper, T.V., internet. And you also see that new model in the hands of a few of your friends. And one month later you find yourself saying, “I want this mobile.” This is what you call as self-motivation. “I am motivated to buy this mobile.” And if somebody will stop you and say, “No, you don’t need this mobile, in fact, you don’t want this mobile,” you will say, “No, I am motivated to buy this mobile.”

That mobile can be replaced by anything else. That can be replaced by career path. That can be replaced by anything tangible. You completely forget that it is not at all ‘your’ motivation. You forget that you have been influenced to go towards it by forces that are not visible to you. You will never know who the advertiser is. You will never know the man who is earning profits from the sale of that mobile. You will never know that man.

But still you are being influenced. Not only are you being influenced, you are also being deceived to think that it is your own motivation, which it is not. It is not your motive. Your mind has been filled with somebody else's motives. It is just borrowed stuff that you are mistakenly calling as your 'own'. And it is all the more dangerous.

When the influence upon the mind is gross then you can at least easily recognize it. Then you can say, "I don't want to be influenced or motivated by somebody else." But when the influence is hidden, subtle, deceptive then you fall into this trap of 'self-motivation'.

There is nothing called self-motivation. All motivation is external. It is just that the external has two forms - explicit and implicit, hidden and open, covert and overt. So, first of all let's just junk that word 'motivation' because all motivation is just an influence upon the mind, tempting you towards something external.

But then you are faced with a problem. The problem is that motivation has been your engine so far. Motivation is from where all your energy rises. Is that not so? When you feel motivated then you feel energized to do something. Now, you will ask that, "If we are not motivated, from where will our energy come? Why will we move if there is no motive? Even the slightest of my movement happens only when I am motivated. Why do I eat? Because I am motivated to take care of my hunger. Why do I greet somebody? Because I am motivated to get some favours. Why do I smile at somebody? Because there is the temptation of reciprocity or the threat of social ostracization. If I don't follow social etiquette, then I will be ostracized. So there is always some motivation even in my slightest action."

“Now Sir, you are saying that motivation need not be an engine of movement. Your actions, your living can come from somewhere else. From where can it come?”

Far more powerful than motivation is another engine, truly internal engine and when I say ‘internal engine’, I am reminded of a car - the car that you are, a beautifully built car that has a really sound internal engine, a very powerful engine, a very smooth engine that the best technician has designed.

But what do I see? I see that the car is being pushed and pulled. And that’s how it’s moving. Ten people are pulling it from the front and twenty people are pushing it from the behind. And that’s how that car is moving. I wonder why this car is being made to move in this way. And my surprise is heightened by the fact that those who are pulling and pushing the car are sometimes applying their forces in mutually opposite directions. So those at the back, want to take it ahead and those at the front, want to take it back. The result, the car is not moving anywhere. It is just kind of vibrating in a very disorderly way. Oscillating, not really going anywhere.

So, I come close to that car and see what is really happening. And remember, that car is what you are. Then somebody tells me that the car is wonderful but nobody has the keys. “We do not know how to ignite the engine, so that’s why we have to apply all these external forces.” These external forces are called ‘motivation’.

You require motivation only when you forget the real key to yourself, to your own engine, your internal engine. What is that internal engine? That internal engine is of understanding; that is your own innate powerful engine. You do not need motivation, you just need to understand. You do

not need any external push or pull; you need the source of energy that supplies power and direction from within. And you have it already, but you have forgotten the key. You have been made to believe that the key does not exist, that unless you are shown the way, you cannot move. No, you don't need to be shown the way. No pied-piper needs to come and queue you towards a fancy designation. You are the finest car that can be made. No improvement is possible upon you. Discover your own key and then you would not need to be motivated.

Remember wherever there is motivation, there would always be the accompanying threat of de-motivation. Only a de-motivated man asks for motivation. Otherwise, there is no need to be motivated. Sitting in front of you, I am not motivated at all. I am just speaking. There is no motivation. Why do I need motivation?

You are motivated to achieve something. Till the time you don't achieve it, there is a kind of suffering. Why? "I still don't have it." And if you happen to achieve it, it is never final. Then the next target would come up and the restlessness would continue.

It's an entirely different way of operating. "I am meeting you not to get something from you, be that an interview room or a board room or the room of your house, or the room that is called this world. I know who I am and I know what I must do. From there are coming my actions and those actions can never be short of energy, short of appropriate energy. When a lot of energy will be needed, you will find me overflowing with energy. And when I will need to relax, I will be completely relaxing. Appropriate energy! I know how to switch the car on and I also then know how to switch it off." When you have the key then you know both; how to turn the engine on and also how to turn it off. You are the master of your life then.

Imagine the most beautiful and the most expensive car. And what are you doing to it? Ten people are pushing it from the back at the grand speed of 5 kilometres per hour. You have an engine that can supply 500 Horse Power and the maximum speed you are attaining is 5 kilometres per hour. You look at the meter, you look at the dashboard and what do you see? You see that the maximum speed possible is many hundreds of kilometres per hour. You see that and then you look at your current speed and you say, "Five KMPH. Is that all that I am built for?" And you wonder what's wrong.

This is what is wrong. Only the internal engine can give you five hundred horse power, only the internal engine. Those of you who are dependent upon external sources of motivation, all that you will ever get is five kilometre per hour, languishing like a man strolling randomly on the road, sometimes this side, sometimes that side, and real cars are whizzing past him.

How many for the internal engine, the real Rolls-Royce engine that powers even fighter aircraft? How many want that?

(Everyone raises their hands)

And how many of you want to be pushed by five people from the back? Yes?

(Silence)

But that is what is happening. I have heard that even to bring you to your classroom, you require five to ten people to push you. Is that so? Behind every face I see five other faces. *Such a fine creation you are.* Why do you require motivation? And you are adults; capable, intelligent and beautiful.

Why do you require that external push? It is demeaning; it is a kind of humiliation.

Listener 1: Sir, I still have a doubt. Although you have been quite patient to me, there is something missing. How do I find that key?

Speaker: The question of finding arises only when you have lost the key. This is such a fine car that the manufacturer has ensured that the key cannot be lost. The key is there. And you must realize that there is a great difference between ‘losing something’ and ‘forgetting’ it. You have not lost the key. You have just forgotten that the key is with you, within you.

What has happened is that since childhood because we have been brought up on a diet of external motivation, we have started believing that the external is all that there is. If you just look closely you may find the key in your left pocket. But what has happened?

You see, when you were young, as a kid what were you told? “If you come first in class then you will get a toy, this particular toy.” What is this? This is external motivation. How do you take a child to mathematics? By having him, by getting him into the love of mathematics, or by luring him with rewards and threatening him with punishment? But what do parents do? How many parents really invoke the love of mathematics in the mind of the child? They don’t do that. What do they say? “Either solve these many questions by evening or you are not coming with us to the market tonight. If you want to come with us to the market today evening then by evening complete your homework.” Is that not so? What kind of motivation is this?

Listener 1: External.

Speaker: You are not falling in love with Maths. When you were two years old, then you were offered some kind of a doll. When you were in class five, then you were offered some video games. When you were in class twelfth, you were told that if you get selected then you will get a particular bike. The toy is changing. It's just becoming a bigger and a more fanciful toy.

But one thing is common, greed and fear, and that is what is motivation. And you look at grownups, thirty years old, fifty years old, eighty years old. They are all running after toys. It's just that the toys have changed. When the man was five years old, the toy was a building, this big. Now the man is fifty years old. What is the toy? It's a huge corporate building. But the toy is a toy. Earlier it was a doll, now it's a beautiful wife. But a toy is a toy. And how do you get that toy? By reaching some target. "You clear the U.P.S.C. exam and you will get a nice wife."

(Listeners chuckle)

That's how it works. Does it not? Even the rates of dowry are predetermined. So much for engineers, so much for this and that. So there is a nice catalogue already in place like the menu card of a restaurant. What do you want to order? You must have that much of money in your pocket.

Because you have been brought up in this kind of a system where all actions are dictated from outside, so you have just forgotten that the key is in your left pocket. How do you look at your left pocket? This one, the left pocket, the breast pocket. How do you look at it? You look at it only when you bring your eyes down towards your heart. Till your eyes are looking towards the world outside, you will not be able to look at your own pocket, here *(pointing at the physical location of the heart)*. The key is here.

Turn your sight inwards. Stop looking at the world, stop hunting for the things on the outside. Bow your head down as one bows down in surrender and look at your heart. You will find the key there. The key is there. You need not worry. The difficult part for you would be to stop looking outside. Because you have been deeply trained to keep looking outside, deeply trained, it will require courage on your part to say, “No. I’m taking a U-turn. What do I want to do? I wouldn’t ask anybody. I will look inside. What do I want to say? I won’t go by social norms. I will look inside. Where do I want to be? I will not follow conventions. I will look inside. Who am I? What is my real identity? I will not borrow it from here and there. I will look inside.” This looking inside is very simple.

The difficult part for you, I am repeating, the difficult part for you would be to gather the courage to not to look outside, because you have now cultivated an artificial kind of helplessness, an artificial dependency. You need not be dependent, but you have *assumed* that you need to be dependent. *It’s a very cultivated helplessness.* So don’t ask about the key. The key is there; safe and secure. You can never lose the key. Ask about the direction of your sight. Till the time you follow the comfort of being dependent, you will never get the key. Till the time you take the easy route of tradition, you will never get the key. Till the time you feel that your definitions and identities can come from here and there, you will never get the key.

Have faith in yourself, and you will find the key there.

That is the key.

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~ Chapter 2 ~

Quantifying yourself leads to jealousy

Question: How should we get rid of jealousy and anger?

Speaker: By deleting the word ‘we’ from this. Why could not you ask, “How should ‘I’ get rid of jealousy and anger?”

Why this plurality? Why does ‘me’ become ‘we’? That is why the jealousy and anger are there. See ‘M’ and it has been inverted. The letter ‘M’ in ‘Me’ when inverted becomes letter ‘W’ in ‘We’.

And then, the entire life becomes inverted. The absence of ‘I’ is the root of jealousy and anger. This ‘we’ is the cumulative mind, the collective mind, the social mind, the comparative mind that lives in ‘we’, that lives in a tribe. Jealousy cannot be there without ‘the other’.

Jealousy is born out of comparison. Jealousy is born from a mind in which many, many are living. To say that there are many means, that they are different entities. And to say that there are different entities means, you have already compared them. Can you say that ‘X’ is different from ‘Y’ without comparing ‘X’ and ‘Y’? ‘We’ means that different entities are present. And whenever there are different things, there would definitely be comparison and hence, jealousy.

When the mind does not know the infinite, and there are not many infinities, there cannot be many infinities, there is only one infinity. *When the mind does not know the infinite, it lives in tiny-tiny, plural finites.* All of these are measurable. The mind continuously keeps taking measure of all these. And because it is not living in the infinite, because it is living in

its own limited sense of self, so it is afraid; it will compare. The only one who does not compare is the one who lives in the infinite.

Now there can be no comparison, as infinity cannot be compared. Till the time you have any kind of estimation of yourself, you will compare. Do you have any estimation? “Such is my height, such is my worth, so many marks did I get, this is the amount of money that I earn.” Till the time there is any bit of identification with this, till the time you have taken yourself as a quantity that can be measured, estimated, a number that can be attached to yourself, there is bound to be comparison, because numbers are meant to be compared.

And where there is comparison, there is jealousy. Jealousy is nothing but the feeling to have a higher number. “I need to have a higher number.” And you will always want a higher number till the time there is a number that is important to you. If your salary figure is important to you, you cannot avoid feeling jealous of someone who earns more than you. If your percentage of marks is important to you, you will not be able to avoid being jealous of someone who has a higher percentage.

Everything that is quantifiable, that can be put in numbers, is a source of jealousy.

What all can be put in numbers? The complexion of your skin can be put in numbers. You can measure it through a scale of brightness or something. It must already be there. Now you would be jealous, you would surely be jealous. “My wife is of a lesser fancied complexion than my brother’s wife.” And so on. ‘My height’ and everything else.

What have I just said? I have just said that what we are, our sense of it comes from some kind of measurement. We think of ourselves as a finite

entity that can be measured. In what ways do we measure ourselves? Tell me the ways in which we measure ourselves. How do you measure yourself?

Listener 1: My height and my weight.

Speaker: Height and weight. And?

Listener 2: Knowledge.

Speaker: I.Q. (Intelligence Quotient). That is a number. And?

Listener 3: Family background.

Speaker: Yes. Can we put that in number? Obviously we can put that in number. “My grandfather had twenty-five acres of land. Your grandfather had fifty-five.” So, measured. And how else do we measure ourselves?

Listener 4: Qualifications.

Speaker: Qualifications, obviously. “I have had twenty-four years of education. You have had only twenty years of education”

Listener 2: Achievements

Speakers: Achievements, the number of certificates.

Listener 5: Experiences.

Speaker: The diversity of experiences. “The number of countries I have visited.” All these are numerically expressed. Are they not?

Listeners (everyone): Yes.

Listener 5: Pocket money.

Speaker: Pocket money. Yes. How heavy is my pocket?

Listener 6: Number of followers.

Speaker: Number of followers, obviously. “My display picture has one-fifty likes. Your picture? Only forty. Nothing!”

(Everyone laughs)

Listener 5: Even number of girlfriends.

(Everyone bursts into laughter)

Speaker: Yes, number of girlfriends. And for the girlfriends, the numbers attached to their body. Thirty-six or twenty six? Gone!

(Everyone again bursts in laughter)

So you always keep measuring yourself. Don’t you? Don’t you?

Listeners (everyone): Yes Sir.

Speaker: Do we see this? We always keep measuring ourselves in a thousand ways. Wherever there is a measurement, there is an assumption that you are a limited and a finite entity. And wherever there will be measurement, there would be comparison. And wherever there is comparison, there is...?

Listeners (everyone): Jealousy.

Speaker: Finished, simple. So how to get rid of jealousy then?

Listener 1: We should not compare.

Speaker: You *will* compare till the time you are a number. How not to be jealous then?

Listener 1: We should not measure ourselves.

Speaker: But you will keep on measuring till the time you think you are finite and limited. So, how not to measure yourself?

Listener 1: By considering oneself as infinite.

Speaker: How big is the infinite? This big, that big? Which infinite? That one, or this one? Black one, or white one?

Whenever you will *think* of the infinite, you will make it finite because you will attach some kind of qualification to it. The infinite is not to be thought of. You cannot consider yourself as infinite.

“You know, I was feeling a little down since the morning. So what did I do? I said, “Oh! Okay I am infinite.”

(Everyone laughs)

“I am so jealous of my neighbour you know, he has got a new car. So what did I do? I said, ‘I am infinite.’”

You don’t *consider* yourself as infinite. You have to *know* yourself as infinite. How do you do that?

Listener 2: Die.

(Everyone laughs)

Speaker: How do you do that?

Listener 7: Observing ourselves.

Speaker: Yes, in more tangible ways. Don't take the numbers seriously.

Is that easy? Is that actionable? Can you start doing that? Don't take seriously anything that can be expressed in...?

Listeners (everyone): Numbers.

Speaker: Write that down. "Let's not take anything seriously." (*Addressing one of the listeners specifically*) For you, write down, "I will not take anything seriously that can be expressed in numbers." Next statement, "And I will give great importance to that which can never be expressed in numbers."

And what is it that cannot be expressed in numbers?

Is there something in your life that cannot be numerically expressed?
Nothing?

Listener 5: Emotions.

Speaker: No, they can be expressed in numbers. How many tears?
"Twenty-five millilitres of water, more emotions."

Listener 2: How many minutes of anger?

Speaker: Minutes of anger. It can be numerically expressed. How many cups did you smash? In anger. How many months of jail? (*Everyone laughs*) All these can be numerically expressed.

What is that which cannot be numerically expressed?

Listener 8: Love and Joy.

Speaker: Yes, will you say to your mother or to your friends, “Two point five grams of love”? Can you say that? Will you say that? It is impossible to quantify them.

When something cannot be put in a finite measure, then it is called infinite. That is what is infinite. *That which cannot be measured or expressed numerically is the taste of infinite.* So the infinite is not something far away, unattainable. It is so close, so very close. Love and Joy - are they things from another galaxy? So why think of these as, “Oh! They are two-hundredth level of consciousness beyond me.” Is love beyond you? Do you have any taste of it? *(Everyone nods in affirmative)* So, it is not beyond anybody, right?

In the finite if there is jealousy, in love there can be no jealousy, right? In the numerically expressed, if there is anger, then in the infinite, which is the simple things like love, like simplicity, like attention, like truth, there can be no anger.

Listener 1: Sir we often say, “He told me only a little bit of truth.” Sir, then what is that?

Speaker: He told a little bit of ‘fact’ that can be numerically measured. Yes, facts can be numerically measured. We just said that somebody is peeping from the key hole. *(Pointing at the key hole in the room)* He will see a little bit. So he goes and he says, “Prashant Sir was in.” So he told a little bit of the fact. There quantification is possible. Truth is indivisible, so there are no parts. You cannot say that a little bit of truth has been told. First of all, there is nothing called ‘little bit’. Second, it cannot be *told*.

Will you remember this? Not to take numbers seriously? What we live in is a world of numbers. We see everything in numbers. What we call as life

itself is measured in numbers – eighty years of age. So, in some sense, it is not easy to not to take numbers seriously. But the one who learns that art is the one who conquers jealousy. Numbers will keep coming to you always. The train is four hours late. Is there a number here?

Listeners (everyone): Yes.

Speaker: Now if you take this number seriously, then the anger is inevitable. “Oh! She spent only two minutes with me.” If you take the number seriously, then you’re gone, because two minutes is nothing. What is important is the *depth* of those two minutes, not the number. Because if you are attached to the number then you would have said, “One twenty minutes would have been far better. She should have spent at least two hours with me.” Instead of that, how much time did she spend? Two minutes. Now you will be disappointed, and hence there would be anger. But if you are more concerned with the depth of those two minutes, and if there is depth, then the two minutes are longer than two centuries.

If there is depth, then time changes.

Time is in the mind. If there is depth in attention, then time stops.

Two minutes are then two centuries. Then there can be no disappointment. You will say, “Oh! She spent two centuries with me. Those two minutes were so long.” Right?

Not the number, but That which cannot be measured in numbers.

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~ Chapter 3 ~

No action can correct another action. Only in understanding do all actions dissolve

Question: Destruction of our world, that we find comfort in, is inevitable. We can only help ourselves, understand this, and thus minimise our suffering. To a cosily sleeping mind though, this realisation is a nightmare. We can only pull it out slowly from of its deep sleep.

Travelling without luxuries and comforts, forces the mind to be in the moment, and breaks years of patterns.

Sir, can meaningful travelling be used as a technique to slowly awaken the mind?

Speaker: We often think that a particular *action* can bring the mind to awareness. We pit action against action. We think that there are good actions and bad actions, meaningful actions and meaningless actions.

Let me say something – No action can ever obliterate another action. Actions do nothing to the quality of the mind. It is quality of the mind in which any action is done, which is the Real thing.

You can take a shower, a bath. Now, the bath doesn't cleanse you. The real question is – what is the mind that is entering into this action? Where is this action coming from? You said, "Meaningful travelling". Where is the meaning coming from? What kind of mind? Because after all, *you* will supply the meaning, right? And *you* will determine whether it is meaningful or meaningless. You are the judge, you are the advocate and you are standing in the dock.

You have to realise that – “Once I have labelled something as meaningful, who is anybody else to say that it is meaningless?” And you are convinced that this particular action, be it travelling or anything, you are convinced that this particular action is meaningful. Now it’s meaningful. So meaningful, I am living in that.

So let’s forget actions for a while, and look at something else, because actions are numerous, actions are diverse. The same action gets done in a thousand situations. You may be riding your bike to reach a thousand different destinations, and for a thousand different purposes. So how can the *action* of riding the bike be of any consequence?

Now, we were saying that, no action cancels out another action. But that is our wish. We think that, just as in mathematics plus one and minus one is zero, similarly, in the world of actions, one action and its opposite get together and nullify each other. That doesn’t happen. In the world of actions, one action and another action, is just two actions.

In the world of actions, one action and its opposite action, is not zero. It is two actions. In mathematics, plus one and minus one is zero, but in the world of actions, one action and two actions, make you a double actor.

Not that your ‘actor-ship’ is taken away. It is not nullified, it is doubled. You are the one who first acted, the actor was there. And you are still there trying to cancel out the first action, so the actor is still there. The actor has actually been reinforced. So never try to correct your actions, please never.

Moral science has always taught this to us – to look at our actions. No. Looking at our actions is one thing, but trying to modify actions is absolutely different thing. You can observe the action. And observing the

action helps you realise something. But you cannot look at action with the intent of transforming it.

Are you getting it?

“I found that I was not paying adequate attention to my child, so what do I start doing? Earlier I was giving one hour a day to my child. Now what do I start doing? Three hours a day.” Now, has anything changed? Are these two actions cancelling each other out? They aren’t, because they are coming from the same centre. The actor is still the same. They aren’t cancelling each other out. In fact, they are building upon each other. The actor is living on and on, and now it’s a more *proud* actor, who thinks that he has improvised his actions, corrected his actions. It’s a more proud actor.

So, never deal in the realm of actions. Never! And never tell somebody that, “These actions are not right.” The mind may not be at the right place. And the right place of the mind is the *Heart*.

That is one thing to say, and that is a beautiful thing to say that the right place of mind is Heart, but it is a gross error to say that, “This action is not alright.”

What do you mean by that? Every action is alright and no action is alright because the term ‘right’ or ‘wrong’ cannot be applied to actions. Is this becoming clear? What this means is tremendous. This means that you cannot judge a person by his actions. This also means that it is not possible to draw inferences only from looks and words.

What is meant by action? Action is something that the senses can perceive. What is action? Action includes thought, action includes words. And these cannot be the yardstick. You have to go to sheer core of the person to see

what is actually happening. Your language may be different from mine, I might move my left hand and you might move your right hand to convey the same thing. Where is the whole thing coming from? Is it coming from the Source, or is it coming from another centre?

Is this clear?

I am not saying, “Do not watch actions.” Do watch actions, but actions by themselves mean nothing. So when you watch actions, watch to go and find out the *Source* of the action, not the action itself. Find out the Source.

From where is this action coming? Is it coming from the real centre, the empty Source? Or is it coming from the centre of ego? Is it spontaneous? Or is it arising from some identity? And the same action can come from both the sources. That’s clear to us, right? The same action can come from both the Sources. So, please don’t be judgemental about actions.

I can admonish you. But from where am I coming? Do I hate you? Is it coming from the centre of hate? Or is it coming from somewhere else? If you will listen only to my words, you will not be able to get anything. That’s why there has to be that quality of Silence in which you hear words, and then you transcend the words, and then there is that connection of love, in which you really see where the whole thing is coming from, in which there is that Core to Core connection. Now words are immaterial, and words are actions.

So, words are immaterial, actions are immaterial. Getting it?

Sometimes the most pleasant looking, the nicest looking action, might actually be coming from a very vicious place, very vicious place. And

sometimes, I dare say, most of the times, a very unpleasant action, might be coming from a very sacred spot. So be careful.

Let these eyes not only look only at the superficial. Have eyes that *really* look.

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~ Chapter 4 ~

Those who really want to change their life are prepared to pay with their death

Question: I often find my life revolving around petty issues, issues around ‘me’, mine’. And there is a deep frustration because of this. I feel that I want something more. Is that just an ideology, or there is something more to it?

Speaker: Life is not something cast in stone. Life is not something pre-determined or rigid. What you call as ‘life’ is a sequence in time. It is happening constantly. Not for a moment do you skip life. If life has a lot of ‘I’, ‘me’, ‘mine’ present, that can be taken care of, any moment. The very realization stops that. And nobody else is enforcing it on you. If you feel that you are sick of it, it stops there, then.

Even this sense of helplessness that – “What do I do if my life is like this?”- is just an inner ploy to continue things as they are. It is a very calculated helplessness; calculated and cultivated. There is nothing authentic about it.

One is healthy, educated, young, but one acts as if one is under so much pressure and compulsion. And what exactly is that ‘pressure and compulsion’? What exactly? Where are the facts? It is just that the training is so deep, and the desire to break out of the training is not so strong. Nothing else!

Listener 1: If one wants to change one’s life, one can only change it from one point to another. There is a limit to change. Is there any possibility that one can look at his limits, and go beyond them?

Speaker: It is not something as calm and composed, as you have just stated it. It is probably more intense, more throbbing, and livelier than that. 'Going beyond' requires the energy of your entire being. What you usually call as 'looking at something' is just an intellectual observation. That does not suffice.

Intellectually, just as an idea or thought, we all know a lot of things. That knowledge does not really help in critical matters of life. It can help in coffee-table discussions. It can help you argue and make a point. It can help you spend a good evening. But it does not help you change the fundamentals of life. The fundamentals of life are changed when you are prepared to pay with your blood.

So I am not really convinced with the passionlessness, when you say, "Can I look at my limitations and go beyond them?" Lot of people keep looking at their limitations, and nobody really goes beyond them. 'Going beyond your limitations' means going beyond yourself. It is almost like jumping out of your body. It is almost like being born again. So, it requires all your intensity, and it requires you to pay the highest price possible. It is not something so intellectual, so impersonal, so cold and calculated.

One's being shakes and shivers. You feel as if your very spine is being broken; your legs lose the power to keep standing. One trembles. Yet, the situation is not as pathetic as I might be making it sound, because there is a power beyond yourself that helps you and sustains you. So, even as all your personal energies fail, there is a support beyond you that becomes available. It requires faith to live by that support.

Listener 1: Sir, listening to all these things, I am not able to understand 'going by faith'.

Speaker: One never understands them, without living them. These are not concepts. This is not something that you can read about in a newspaper, or a book. Or watch a documentary, and come to learn. You will never come to learn these things, by just hearing about them from another man's mouth. One has to pay the price, and live that life.

And it is not a fairy tale, a pleasant story, when you are paying that price. Remember, that price is 'yourself'. One is battered, and bruised, and the being is full of wounds. And it is only then that you realize that there is a great healing power within you, which holds you together, in spite of all the wounds that you have.

Are you getting it?

These are not things that can happen in a comfortable room, on a Sunday morning, over a nice, hot cup of tea. It is more about 'Blood' than Tea.

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~ Chapter 5 ~

The race was won, by the one, who did not run

Speaker: The question is, “There are two persons coming from the same background, same kind of upbringing. One succeeds and the other fails. What is the difference between the two? Why does one succeed and why does the other fail?”

There is absolutely no difference between the two, absolutely no difference. The one who believes that he has succeeded, believes in the concept of failure. Can you be successful without believing in failure? If there is no failure, can there be success? Success and failure are two sides of the same coin. The one who does not believe in success, can never fail. The one who does not believe in failure, cannot succeed.

You first have to believe in the concept of ‘success’ and ‘failure’ in order to succeed or fail. So, these two fellows are just the same. Both of them live in an imaginary world where words like ‘success’ and ‘failure’ exist.

Do you know who these two are? These two are the ones who are running a race. When you are running a race, either you will succeed or you will fail. These two are running. One of them will succeed and the other one will fail. And there is no great difference between the two because both of them are essentially running the race. It is a matter of time, chance and circumstances that one succeeds in a race. And obviously in a race, somebody has to succeed and somebody has to fail.

But there is a third person as well. There is a third possibility as well. There is a man outside this racing track who is not running a race. When these two fellows are busy running and trying to succeed, that fellow is dancing. We

are concerned with that third fellow. We do not want to talk of these two. These two are worthless. I want to talk about the third fellow.

Look at the third fellow. He is the real man. He does not want to win the race. He can never fail because he does not want to succeed. He is just dancing. These two are worried and tensed that what will happen to us. These two keep thinking only about running, he is dancing joyfully.

He says, "I am already home. I do not want to run. I don't want to run any race. I don't want to succeed. I am already successful as I am. I am good, complete. Why should I chase an imaginary success when I am already successful? Why should I say that I want to get something when I already have everything! Whatever that race can give me is small, insignificant, inconsequential in comparison to what I already have.' He knows this and this knowing is really beautiful when the other two are really sweating out.

The one who is successful is also the one who is afraid of failure. When you are running a race, then the one who is winning is as afraid as the one who is losing. But when you are dancing, dancing for yourself, then you are not afraid, you are not comparing yourself with anybody. There is no question of losing. You do not bother about what the society will say. You are with yourself. Alright, innocent like a child, not competitive, not afraid, not nervous. Your query now will be, "How will the progress take place if we do not run?"

All that is valuable in life has never been brought about by those who were chasing success. Everything that is valuable, worthy and beautiful, is a creation of those who were not wanting to be successful, who were just busy dancing.

The scientist in the laboratory who says, “I am loving the experiment. I don’t even want to count what I am doing. I do not want to project how far success is. I am alright”.

The explorer who goes into the jungle not knowing what lies within, but he goes for the love of the jungle, because he wants to know, because he wants to roam about aimlessly, not wanting success.

These are the people who really win the race.

It is quite strange that the race is always won by the one who does not run the race. The race is always won by the individual who does not participate in the race. The ones who participate in the race, always lose.

Do you want to be a real winner? Then forget about ‘success’ and ‘failure’. Look at what is false. Find out who you really are. Listen to the call of your heart. Only that can give you real success. Running a cheap rat race will take you nowhere.

One day you will find that you are very close to death and all that you have been doing is racing, racing and competing with a millions of unknown faces, and unknown voices. And then you will say that I have wasted my life. Don’t race. Don’t compete.

Find out the call of your heart and give everything to it. That is the joy of living. *Not in racing, not in comparing!*

~

~ Chapter 6 ~

You have no strengths or weaknesses

You are just what you are

Speaker: You have assumed that there must be strengths and weaknesses. What if you just are and there are no strengths or no weaknesses?

What are the weaknesses of a Daisy flower? What are the weaknesses of a Rose flower?

Listener: Sir, it has thorns.

Speaker: The flower does not have thorns, the plant has thorns. But the daisy flower may appear to have weaknesses if compared to the rose flower, otherwise it has no weaknesses. A Sunflower is a Sunflower, a Lotus flower is a Lotus flower, a Daisy flower is a Daisy flower, none of them have any weaknesses or strengths, but if you compare their sizes, then a Sunflower and a Lotus flower will appear to be stronger than the Rose flower in terms of size.

They are all perfect as they are.

It is upon comparison that you start saying, “I am strong or weak”, and comparison is always foolish. You don’t have a strength and you don’t have a weakness, you are just what you are. Where is the question of strength and weakness? We talked of your authenticity, you all are unique, and everybody is unique.

To label something as your strength or as your weakness can only be done when you are being compared against some standard.

Who is the tallest one here?

Compared to him it's my weakness, that I am only 5'8". My height has now become my weakness if I stand next to him. But if I stand next to somebody else, say him (pointing to a student with shorter height), then the same height becomes my strength. Are you getting this?

So, there has to be a benchmark, an imaginary benchmark, and against that imaginary benchmark you fill your mind with notions of strengths and weakness which is not appropriate because they make you feel inadequate.

Strengths make you feel proud of yourself, which is not good, which is ego, and weaknesses make you feel bad about yourself, which is again not good, which again is ego. You are good, you are all right. What is considered strength at one place will be considered as weakness at another.

What is strength and weakness? I keep giving this example. In India we are still enslaved with the notion of color. Fair colored people ruled over us for a long time, so skin color is still very important to us. That mental slavery is still going on. When a child is born, and if the child happens to be a girl and is little dark colored, what will you repeatedly tell her? What would the parent be repeatedly saying directly or indirectly? That her dark color is her weakness. Is the color the child's weakness or the parent's mentality? It is the parent's mentality.

We borrow mentalities. We keep borrowing things, just like the picking up of the duster. We are picking up mentalities. We are borrowing that which is not ours. So you are very right. After some time the girl herself will start believing that there is something wrong with her. The proof is all those fairness creams that you see in the market. Now why should anybody try to use a fairness cream?

Being students of science, you very well know that a color is just a particular wavelength. Now, what is so sacred about five thousand angstroms, which is not there in seven thousand angstroms. That's what color is, that's what facial color is, but you will make the poor child believe that there is something wrong with her, and then she will spend her life trying to correct her weakness, as if there is any weakness. There is no weakness at all.

You are born in a family of people, who are extremely belligerent. You understand belligerent? Always picking up fights, always aggressive. In north India, we have a few places where it is considered an asset to be extremely aggressive. Do you know such places? And there are entire communities who pride themselves of being aggressive, that 'don't mess with us, we will beat you up' behaviour. Now, if you are born in such a family and your temperament is bad, you are hot headed, you are unduly irritated all the time, then it will be considered as your strength. Whereas, if you are born somewhere else, it would be considered as your weakness.

What is strength and weakness? You are just what you are. Simple! Stop, you are OK. If there really is a weakness, it is to be stupid, there is no other weakness.

What is stupidity?

Stupidity is not relative, stupidity is to not to know what is happening. Throughout today's session we repeatedly said that life is right now, and stupidity is to not to know what is happening right now. There is no other stupidity.

The only weakness is stupidity, and hence the only strength is wisdom, and there is no great wisdom in collecting knowledge.

Wisdom is a very simple thing. Wisdom is to know what is happening.

So you are listening carefully, right? Are you? If yes, you are wise. If you are listening carefully, this moment is complete, perfect, absolutely all right, no weakness at all.

~

~ Chapter 7 ~

Don't be so serious; nothing is too important

Speaker: How many of you feel this way that when the moment is there, the opportunity is there, you feel blank? The mind experiences a blackout. Do you understand a blackout? There is nothing. And when the moment is gone then the thoughts arise, "I could have said this. I could have done that". In the moment of action, you are unable to act and later there are so many thoughts.

How many of you find this happening with you?

(Many listeners raise their hands).

This is a very, very common situation, very common. This will always happen when you are serious about something. This will always happen when the results become very important to you. Whenever you are serious, whenever you think that it is a matter of life and death, whenever you give great, great importance to something, you will find that you have been numbed down, you will find that there is a freeze, there is an immobility. You are unable to act. Your seriousness has taken a grip upon you and you can't move. The mind is not free anymore.

If I start taking this conversation very seriously, I'll not be able to speak. Even if I speak, I'll not feel light, I'll not be able to have fun with you. You would have laughed so many times over the last one hour, right? You will not be able to laugh if I don't feel light. And I will not feel light if I start taking you too seriously. Same is true vice-versa. If you start taking me too seriously, you'll not be able to laugh. Let everything be like a game. Enter it playfully. Just enjoy it.

What is so important about anything? You are the most important thing. Nothing is more important than you. Why are you unnecessarily serious? Even now, so many of you appear quite serious.

Tell me really, do you dance freely? And why are you alive if you can't even dance? Why don't you just die? What is the point of living on if life must be boring, serious and heavy? What is the point of living on? Are you living to suffer torture? Are you living so that every day is a punishment?

Keep smiling. And you'll win a few girlfriends if you will keep smiling this way. Keep smiling. Nobody likes to see a heavy face, sulking, drooping shoulders. "Life is a torture"; if someone asks, "Why are you alive?" reply is, "Now that I have come to the world, I shall have to live." Are you here as some sort of jailed convicts? Are you?

When you are with your friends, when you are light, when you are laughing, do you experience these blackouts even then? You don't. You experience these blackouts only when there is some *important* occasion.

Tell yourself that nothing is important, everything is alright. "Nothing is important. I am important." Who is important? "I am important. Everything else is secondary, I am primary. I am central." And then nothing, no problem.

I feel really bad when young, well-educated students like you are unnecessarily suffering. There is no need to suffer. And you keep suffering for the most stupid reasons.

"What will she say?", "What will he think?", "He just glanced at me", "What did he mean?", "Why is he not liking me on Facebook?" Most stupid reasons! You give importance to such rubbish in life, such stupid things.

“He got 1.5 marks more than me. There is nothing left in my life now, I am finished. Done. Where is the jungle? I’ll leave the city now”; “My ex-boyfriend has another one now.” Flimsiest of pretexts, as if we are searching for reasons to tax ourselves, burden ourselves, as if we have been programmed to be unhappy.

We are alright. You are alright, I am alright, everybody is alright. You don’t need to be too serious about anything.

Take everything playfully. Don’t bother yourself with the results. The results will take care of themselves.

~

~ Love and Relationships ~

*“When Love calls, do not resist. Go.
That is where you will find peace.
Do not fight that unreasonable urge.
Surrender to your glorious defeat.”*

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~ Chapter 1 ~

The difference between love and attraction

Speaker: What is attraction?

At least this much should be very clear. We see instances of attraction, every moment, all the time around us. There is the game of attraction going on.

So, somebody bangs the door, and your mind gets attracted towards that. It is as if the banging of the door and the movement of mind towards the door are one and the same thing. If one happens the other has to happen, they are inseparable. This is attraction.

If you put some iron pieces near a magnet, the iron pieces will move towards the magnet. This is attraction. If two reacting chemicals are brought together, there is a reaction and the subsequent release of energy and everything else and that is attraction. So attraction is obvious, it is happening all the time around us.

It is just a mechanical movement. The iron does not know why it is getting attracted to the magnet. The magnet does not know why it is attracting the iron piece. And yet attraction is happening. It is a very dead thing. Sodium does not know why its atom wants to react with water. And water does not know why a particular configuration of the atom must be reacted to. Yet there is a reaction. This is attraction.

You take two metals, let's say, iron and nickel, and keep them in close contact for long periods of time. And after that you cannot separate them. Diffusion of molecules of one metal will happen to the other and some kind of bond will get established between the metals.

If some of you drive an old bike or old car, you will know that old nuts and bolt cannot be opened. They have to be cut, the nut fuses with the bolt. The nut fuses with the bolt. So, close together and close together for a long period of time, space and time; that is attraction.

Space and time is attraction. Space and time is also this world. What is this world? This world is all this that appears all spread around, so space. And this world is the past and future, so time.

Attraction and the world are inseparable. Attraction is the fundamental quality of this world.

And remember this world by itself has no life, it is a mechanical system. An apple gets attracted towards the earth, the earth gets attracted towards the apple, fundamental quality. And where there is attraction, there is repulsion as well. So attraction and repulsion, that is what this universe is all about, and this universe is time and space.

We just said that in closeness there is attraction. If you keep iron and magnet very far away from each other, attraction will become almost zero.

You very well know even the gravitational pull is inversely proportional to the square of the separation distance between the two interacting objects. So you increase the distance and the pull will become almost zero. You require time and you require closeness in space. So, if you are with a person since a long period of time, you will get attached.

Attachment is the fruit of attraction in time. Attraction happens right now and when attraction continues in time then what you get is attachment. Attraction is a dead thing and attachment is an equally dead thing.

So, iron and magnet, they will attract each other and if they stay in touch for a long period of time, they will also get attached. And that is the fact of our relationships. There is attraction and after that there is attachment. And sometimes we give the name love to either of these.

But this universe only knows attraction and attachment, it knows no love.

Love is a totally different quality. Love is understanding. And love does not relate to being attracted. To get attracted you require the mind to be dull, to be stupid. Only a stupid mind gets attracted and attached, an unhealthy mind, a diseased mind. A mind that feels incomplete and so it wants to go and cling to something and somebody, and feel complete.

You very well know why chemicals react. One chemical has some shortage of electron. So, it wants the other atom to provide those electrons, right? Either by transfer or by sharing. So, attraction happens when there is a feeling of incompleteness. And whenever you feel incomplete, that is disease, you are uncomfortable, restless.

Love on the other hand is the quality of a healthy mind that feels complete in itself. Because it feels complete in itself, because it is a healthy mind, all its relationships are also healthy. A healthy relationship is also called a loving relationship, it is so simple.

Love has no excitement or titillation about it. It is a simple being in health.

When you relate to other not because of greed or fear, it is love. But unfortunately if we look at our relationships, there is greed, fear and expectation always, always present. And where there is greed, fear, expectation, insecurity, there can be no love. There would be jealousy and

possessiveness and there could be discord and strife, but no love. So there is nothing sensational about love, it is so simple.

The relationships of a healthy mind are loving relationships.

When you do not relate to the other in order to get something from him, it is love. Where you are feeling so full towards yourself, that you feel no violence towards the world, it is love. Love is not about creating boundaries, my family, my people, my love, my house. Love is like the sun, full in itself, so its brightness falls on everybody, its warmth is available to all. Wherever it goes, it brings light. That is love. But love, in spite of being such a simple thing cannot really be an object of discussion. Because love comes from a healthy mind; and health simply means freedom from disease.

We do not need to work towards health. We only need freedom from the disease.

As long as the mind is diseased, it will be experiencing attraction and attachment. Attractions and attachments are the symptoms of an unhealthy and sick mind. They arise from conditioning. They arise from the latent tendencies of the mind.

So, these must be the object of consideration.

Why is the mind unhealthy? Can I look at it?

Can I understand how deeply conditioned I am?

Can I catch my ways?

Can I observe my daily life and look at the play of conditioning, attraction, attachment?

If you can do that, then just that realization gives you freedom from disease. Freedom from disease is health. And the relationships of a healthy mind are loving relationships, simple.

So when you talk of love, kindly do not get excited, there is nothing exciting about love, just as there is nothing exciting about pure water. But pure water is life, life giving. There is a lot that is exciting about fizzy drinks, about liquor. But about water, there is nothing exciting; it is simple, pure, and transparent. Love is like pure water, it is not sensational, it is not sentimental, it is not titillating. Love is the quality of a healthy mind, a mind that is not afraid, a mind that is not carrying the burden of the past or expectations. That is love.

Never think that a man who is carrying ideologies, a man who is ambitious, a man who belongs to a particular line of thought, can ever be capable of love. He will carry his sense of violence into everything that he does.

The man, who is dull and bored and careless and violent in the office, cannot be a loving father or a loving husband. After all it is the same mind; he will carry the same mind into the house as well. A healthy mind will be healthy in all walks of life, throughout the day.

A lady, who does not care for small kids in the slum opposite her house, cannot be a loving mother. It is impossible. How is it possible to love your kids, when you only have indifference to the other kids who are shivering in the cold?

A man, who kills animals, cannot have love for anybody. After all it is the same mind. When you do not have sensitivity and you can use the knife on one being, then how will your mind suddenly become sensitive towards the rest of the world? It is the same mind.

I know that as young people, love is a very hot topic for you all. But kindly do not think that you can ever know love without cleaning up your mind. Love is possible only to a very clean and very pure mind.

Others will know attraction and attachment but they will never know love. And that is their punishment.

The punishment of remaining conditioned is that you will never know love.

You will live sixty years or hundred years, without even knowing a moment of love. You can name other thing as love; you can fool yourself by saying that, "I have a very loving family".

But the fact will be that there will be no love.

So forget love, look at the purity of mind. That is what you can do.

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~ Chapter 2 ~

Don't let love turn into a relationship

Listener: Sir, love turning into a relationship has its repercussions in my life.

Speaker: Ayushi is saying that love has turned into a relationship and it is having repercussions in her life.

First of all, it is wonderful that you have understood a very fundamental truth, which is that, whenever anything turns into a relationship, it goes bad. Whenever *anything* turns into a *relationship*, it goes *bad*.

I understand what I am saying is a little puzzling but stay with me and remain attentive.

Love is a particular quality of relating. It is right now. It is not the concept of the mind, it is something absolutely new. It does not happen because you have thought about it. There is no background to Love. That is why when it happens it throws you off your feet. Those of us, who have had a taste of love, understand what I am saying. Because it is something which is not planned, because it is something which is not premeditated, because real Love is not a thought or a concept. That is why when it comes, it comes as a fresh breath of air. May be I am understating. It comes as a tornado that blows you off your feet.

Now, that is love; that is something new, something fresh. It just happens, it's just a surprise. You have not planned that I must fall in love with that fellow. That's why it rejuvenates. You discover that you are young. It's so beautiful.

What happens to this then? Now, this love which had a fresh quality of relating, we give it a particular name and we turn it into a relationship, and relationship is always dependent upon the past.

Understand the difference between love and relationship.

Love is fresh, relationship depends upon the past and is very limited. The moment you declare that I have a particular relationship with somebody, you already have a concept in mind.

Love is not a concept but husband and wife are a concept. The moment you say that somebody is my wife or somebody is my husband, you already know what that relationship means. Now it is dead, absolutely dead. Somebody has said that, "Lovers die and on their corpses husband and wife are born." Its only when lovers are dead then the husband and wife arise.

Because love cannot have a name, love is not a fixed relationship. But our mind, our poor little mind, it cannot tolerate the freshness of love. It has no power to live with the freshness and uncertainty of love. So, what does it do? It says that let us give a name to our relationship. Let's formalize our agreement, let's take the sanction of the society. So, the first name that they will give to each other is, "We are lovers." Then they say that, "Let's formalize it even more", and then they will say that, "Now we are husband and wife." And the more you are formalizing it, the more names you are giving it, the more trouble you are creating for yourself. You are thinking that all this is happening out of love. I am saying that all this is taking you out of love. You think that the relationship is born out of love, from love and I am saying that because of relationship you are moving out of love, away from love.

We are so keen to turn love into a relationship and the moment it becomes a relationship, love is gone. Now, there will be expectations, now there will be a definite code of conduct.

“You are my boyfriend. How can you look at somebody else?”

“You are my wife. You must take care of me.”

Now love is gone and duty has come in.

Love is not duty. Love is absolute Freedom. In your Freedom, you Love. You are not compelled to love.

A lover is not constrained to produce kids but a wife must produce kids. If you are somebody's girlfriend, you can walk away anytime but a wife has certain respectability, she cannot walk away anytime. What can you do? Now, the individuals are lost and images are living. The individual is gone and it's the wife that is talking.

Have you ever wondered that in all these movies that you see, why do all love stories end at marriage? There will be an entire love story and what happens in the end? Marriage, and after that, 'The End'. You should ask, “What happens after this? That is the real thing, show that.” But then, the movie has ended. They will not show you that now she is cleaning the clothes. That's the real thing that you should have asked. But they are very clever. If they will start showing you that then the society's objectives will be defeated.

The society does not want you to love. The society does not want lovers. It wants husbands and wives. The society hates lovers but it loves husbands and wives. It will say go, quickly get married. You don't love each other, doesn't matter. Go and get married. Marriage is good, love is bad. And

marriage is a name, so is any other relationship. I am not advocating a live-in kind of a thing even that is a name, even in that there are expectations. And I am not talking of just the love between a man and a woman.

In every relationship, there are no individuals. Father and son. Do the father and son really talk to each other? No, it's the father talking to the son, not an individual talking to an individual. That's why sons are restless with their fathers and fathers are never happy with their sons. Because a father can never be happy with a son. An individual can be happy with another individual, not a father with a son. But, we are so eager, "He is my son." He will not say that, "He is an individual." Have we ever seen our father as an individual? Very difficult and that is why there is so much suffering in our relationships. That is why our relationships are so dead. We constantly feel like moving away, certain suffocation there. So, it is good that you are realizing that relationship causes trouble. Great that you have realized this. Now, you are free for life.

All your life, if you have been learning this lesson, then you will avoid relationship. Yes, you will relate, but like a free bird.

Relating is another thing, relationship is totally different

It is a wonderful thing that it is happening to you at such an early age. There are people who grow thirty years old, forty years old, fifty years old, they still don't realize. And they die wondering, "What did I do wrong?" They probably think that life is suffering, they say, "Life is hell, what can I do?" They say, "You know what, man is born because he is a sinner", then they come up with all those fancy stories.

Life is not hell; you have made it into hell. Life is worth living only in love and you killed love. You killed love because you are so insecure; you

wanted to get into a relationship.

Haven't you seen, three months of dating and the girl will start asking, "When will we get married?" And she thinks it's cute. It's monstrous. You understand monstrous. Look at her face and see the devil and run away. Run away for your own dear life. The day she says, "When will we get married, run away." She knows no love. Had she known love, she would not have been insecure. You know what she is thinking? That, "Before you go away, let's get married. That way there will be a bond."

A really loving person would say, "Marriage or no marriage, how does it matter? I am not even thinking of marriage. This is sufficient. This fullness of love is sufficient. Who is thinking about marriage? Marriage is such a trivial thing, who wants to talk about it?"

But you want to talk about it as the first thing. I have seen people who even before loving, for them loving is an action, before loving, they will check, which religion, which caste. Now, it is alright. Now I can love. And, what is her age? "She should be at least six months younger because my parents do not like the girl to be older than the boy." So, everything is verified, all checks done, and now I will love. This fellow, can he ever love? Are you loving or getting a credit card, with so many checks?

My name is Alok Sharma, she looked quite pretty. I go close to her and find out her name is Razia Sultana and Alok Sharma runs heels over heads. And just two minutes back he was singing all the romantic songs and he was feeling completely in love. "I have discovered the nectar of life. She is the princess of my dreams. I was always dreaming about her." And the moment he comes to know her name. "My goodness, there are so many traps in the world. The world is so deceptive. There should be a nameplate somewhere

so that the moment we look there, we see the name plate and we are warned.”

Does love look at names? Does love want names?

We are occupied with names, labels, brands. Once, I was in Bangalore, looking at all these matrimonial ads, how did they read? ‘Bachelor in Technology, Computer Science, knows C++, also good in Java.’ These are the matrimonial ads. Now, will you talk C++ with her? He is telling her all the operating platforms. But that establishes his brand. “Java. Good. IIT-IIM, this is a love worthy fellow.”

Let it be like a wild flower, when it grows, it just grows. It can grow even on a rooftop or by the side of small stream. Let it just grow, don’t call it anything. Don’t try to freeze it. Don’t try to limit it. It will be dead.

If you try to capture a flower, what happens to the flower? If you try to capture a butterfly, what happens to the butterfly? It’s gone, it’s dead. All you will be left with is a skeleton.

You want to live with a skeleton? *Then why do you want to capture love? Why can’t you just love and let it be?*

Don’t raise expectations, let it flow.

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~ Chapter 3 ~

To relate in love is to relate free of experience

Question: Sir, how can we relate in love?

Speaker: Let us take a very basic kind of example, starting from what we usually interpret by 'love'.

Suppose there is a friend, and you love your friend. She is your childhood friend, and you love her. Because she is your childhood friend, there are a lot of experiences that you have had with her. Am I right?

You remember images of her when she was three years old, six years old, ten years old, then fifteen, and now twenty. And now she is in front of you, and you are talking to her. Have you ever wondered whom do you talk to?

Do you really talk to the living fact, or do you talk to the entire domain of your experience?

You have thousands of images and memories, and you talk to them. You don't even bother to look deeply, sharply, lovingly at the living thing, because you already have experiences. "I already know her."

Pay attention to this.

The doorbell rings, you open the door, and your father is standing at the door. So, when you open the door, whom do you find? Your father.

Now there is another case. The doorbell rings, and a stranger is standing at the door. In which of these two cases are you more likely to look sharply at the face of the person?

Listeners: In case of the stranger.

Speaker: That is our misfortune. Strangers, we can look clearly at. But we are so insensitive and so unloving towards our closed ones that we hardly ever look directly, carefully, sharply at their faces. Why? Because we have experiences with them. “Oh Daddy! I already know him. He comes home every evening. What is new about his face? I have seen his face a billion times. What is there in his face?”

But you never realize that Daddy’s face is not the same as it was when you saw him last. The face has changed. The moment is new, and he deserves that you have a new relationship with him, and not a continuation of the past. You cannot say, “Another day, another evening, same Daddy.”

But is that not how we live? When you go back home today, will you look at your mother as if you are looking at her for the first time? Will you do that?

(Silence)

Unfortunately we do not do that, because we already have experience. There can be no love now. That is why when young lovers meet, initially there is euphoria. And after one year, it’s all over. Because now there is...

Listeners: Experience.

Speaker: Experience. Now no one is so beautiful. It is the same. Do you say, “Such a new smile. I have never seen this?” No.

You would say, “She is smiling daily the same way.” *(Laughter)*

The fact is that every time she smiles, actually the smile is different. But because of your experience, you cannot see that. The smile is actually

different every time, but experience prevents you from realizing that. Love and experience do not go together.

Next time when you meet somebody close to you, meet as if you are meeting for the first time. It is no big problem if you even forget the person's name. That is alright. You can ask the name. But the bigger problem is that if you remember the name, then you remember everything.

We remember everything. We are slaves of our memories. This incapacity to forget is a huge burden on the mind.

We live in memories, and experience is memory. If you remember everything that has happened in the relationship in the last ten years, then that relationship is dead. It then really needs revitalization.

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~ Chapter 4 ~

What is unconditional love?

Questioner: All humans in the living body are confined by needs of the body. Isn't it then too much to ask for unconditional love for those who hurt you? When actually you are deeply affected by that hurt, how can one practically take all the hurt, pain, criticism from others and yet love them unconditionally? Is this real and achievable?

Speaker: We have all experienced the excitement, the euphoria, the bliss of the so-called ordinary love, mortal love, *Ishq-e-majazi*, and it is wonderful. It is just that it depends on somebody for its being. It has a particular reason for its existence and that reason, most often, is one particular person. There is a particular person and is usually of the opposite gender. So, there is one particular person, and the presence of that person has opened some doors for me. It has brought the mind to a particular condition. That is our ordinary love, what we call as conditional love.

What then is unconditional love?

Unconditional love is when you are in the same state of mind, and you experience the same euphoria, the same excitement, the same bliss, perhaps even more intense. You experience it even more intensely but with no reason. In ordinary love, there is that feeling of lightness for a reason, and because there is a reason, the reason can be taken away. So consequently, there will always be fear associated with that. The feeling will never be very deep. You would experience bliss, accompanied by fear, so things would be very superficial. There would be boundaries. Fear would be lurking around the corner.

Unconditional love does not mean to love him and love her and love all of them in the same way as if you are loving that one particular person of yours. It is misconception. Unconditional love is not an expansion of conditional love. What we often think is, just as I have feelings and attachment for one particular person, if the same kind of feeling and attachment is there for 20,000 persons or the entire universe, then this is called as unconditional love. No, this is not unconditional love.

Unconditional love means experiencing the bliss of love without any conditions attached, without any reasons. Reason is a condition.

Listener: How do the mind, the body go out of that reason? When the soul is within the body, and with that limitation you are thinking that if somebody tries to cut my hand, it will pain and I may have a problem with it. But ultimately, I am going to be in a lot of pain. Enlightenment asks me to not experience my pain and be devoid of that pain and still love that axe which is cutting. How is it possible?

Speaker: No, it is not saying, “Do not experience that pain.” As long as ‘you’ are there, the physical processes of the body will be there. What is being said is very simple, you need not bring in terms like ‘soul’.

There is one fellow walking on the road appearing very light, very happy, very contented. Why? Because he has that someone special in his life. This is conditional love. And on the same road you have another fellow walking, who is equally happy, probably even happier. His happiness is more intense, it is Joy, very light-hearted, very contented but without any reason.

The first fellow has a reason. What is the reason? I just got my girlfriend. The second fellow has no reason yet he is experiencing the ecstasy of love. This is Unconditional love

Listener: How? Does he know something more?

Speaker: When you say, “How?” what you are saying is that this unconditional love, the state of the second person, is a thing of achievement. So, one can go out and achieve it and ‘how’ pertains to the method of achieving it. You are asking for that.

The state of the second person is not a state to be achieved; it is just a clean slate.

This feeling of ecstasy, this love, this is our natural state, so there is no question of achieving it. One does not achieve it. Yes you can work hard to obfuscate it, to spoil it, to cover it, to run away from it, but you cannot achieve it. So, all ‘how’s’ will only spoil the state. When you say, “How to achieve?” you would *do* something to achieve and you would find a reason and that reason would again be something to do with an object. Get money, get a particular person, get something. ‘How’ will pertain to that. So, there is no ‘how’ in that. In fact, there is only removal of all ‘how’s’ and reasons.

You said, “Does the second person know something more? Does the second person have something more?” The second person does not have something more, the second person does not know something more. In fact, he is poorer than the first person.

The first fellow has a reason. The second fellow does not have a reason. So, it’s not something additional that he has, it’s something lesser that he has. He does have not a reason and reason is ‘ego’. Reason is your calculation.

You don’t have to *do* something to gain that unconditional thing. You, in fact, have to get rid of a few things. Look at the word ‘unconditional love’. Conditions are gained. What do we do? We gain conditions. What is meant

by gaining conditions? We apply conditions. We say, “I will not allow myself to feel contended, to feel ecstatic, unless I have attained something.” You have imposed a condition.

You don’t impose a condition and it is available, simply available.

So, unconditional love does not mean two things. One - loving everybody in the same conditioned way as one loves one particular special person. That’s a great misconception. So, when we say, “Unconditional love”, people often get up and ask, “So does that mean. I have to love all the women in the world in the same way as I love my wife?” First of all you don’t love your wife. Second, even if you love five billion women in the same way as you love your wife, that will not be unconditional love.

Listener: Let’s say you are already in relationship. We always give ourselves a name. Either I am a daughter, wife or a neighbour. So whatever object confronts you in that relationship, you have to deal with that relationship.

Speaker: Love is not something that is applicable to a relationship in particular. Love is not something that has greatly to do with a relationship. Love does not have greatly to do with the other. Love is your own state of mind.

The other does not have much to do with love. That’s another misconception – that for love there has to be a presence of the other. Not needed.

Love is essentially between the mind and the Source, and because the Source is the source of the mind itself, so again it is not between two entities, not between two separate entities.

A condition is something that changes. What is it that changes? Whatever is in the world will change. Whatever is in time and space will change.

So, what is meant by ‘unconditional’?

Something which will remain unaffected by whatever is happening on the outside, the world.

There is a state of the mind which will remain continuously untouched by whatever is happening outside in the world. That is called unconditional.

It doesn't matter what is happening here, there, with that person, in the future or in the past, today or tomorrow, “I have a particular state of mind that does not change” and that is called the unconditional state. You may call it love, you may not call it love. This unconditionality itself is Love.

So, when you are saying, ‘unconditional love’, you are using a redundant word. You may just say, ‘Unconditional’ and it's sufficient. It suffices to say, ‘Unconditional’. You need not say ‘Love’. That state of mind which remains untouched by all the movements in time and space is unconditional, and that alone is Love.

So, contrary to what we usually assume that love is about reaching out to the other, unconditional love is actually not about reaching out to one or thousands or the entire universe. Unconditional love is actually a movement within. It is a closeness of the mind to its own Source and it is so close that it is unaffected by the situations on the periphery.

We will not use sentences or phrases such as, “I love you unconditionally”. No, you do not love a *person* unconditionally. If you love a *person*, condition has already been set. What is the condition? I love a ‘person’. The boundary has already been drawn. So anybody who is making this

statement, “I love you unconditionally”, does not know love and is also foolish. Till the time it has anything to do with the other, it is your ordinary attraction. It has nothing to do with Love.

It would appear quite awkward, initially, to hear that love has nothing to do with the other. You would ask, “Then whom are we loving?” Well, nobody. Because love is not at all about anybody else. Love is primarily your own mind. The mind that is in close contact, in intimacy with the Source, is a loving mind. And that is why it is unconditional. Because when the mind is in contact with its own Source, then whatever is happening on the periphery, all the conditions that are continuously changing on the periphery, do not affect the mind, and hence it is called unconditional Love.

Now what is the quality of such a mind? This mind is at peace. And because this mind is at peace, this peace reflects in its interaction with the so-called others as well. This is not a violent mind, this is not a divisive mind, this is not a cunning mind, this is not an ambitious mind. It already has the maximum that anyone can ever have. So there is no reason for it to feel ambitious. There is no reason to feel dissatisfied. When the maximum is so readily available, then there is no reason for this mind to devise methods and schemes. So this is not a cunning mind, it is a simple mind.

This simplicity, this peace, this lack of ambition, this tendency to generously give and distribute, this shows in the interactions of this mind with the entire world. But these interactions, please remember, are not primary. These are mere symbols. You cannot say that anybody who displays these symbols is a loving mind. The primary thing is the closeness of the mind to its Source. When that happens, then all these signs, characteristics, symbols, symptoms, they all start showing up.

Generosity does not come from nowhere. It comes when you are full and that feeling of fullness comes only when you have the maximum, the ultimate, in your back pocket. So, you can now distribute, and distribute without thinking that it would be lessened. This is unconditional Love. “I can distribute, I can give without thinking that anything can be reduced from me.” But remember before you come to the feeling of distribution, you first come to the stage where you clearly see, the mind clearly sees, that it has attained. There can be no generosity without attainment.

So what is primary? The attainment. The generosity is secondary. We often do not have anything and yet try to be generous. This generosity is superficial, it is intended just to have a particular image, to deceive others, and sometimes ourselves.

Listener: How can one know that they have attained?

Speaker: You will feel like giving. How does one know that the plant is healthy? By the look of the leaf.

Listener: If one feels that one has not attained, then what should they do?

Speaker: They should stop doing whatever they are doing. If you feel you have not attained, it is purely by the virtue of what you are doing.

Is the universe intent upon keeping you deprived? Then what has brought you to a stage where you feel that you have not attained? Your own actions, your own beliefs. Give them up. Stop doing what you are doing. You don’t need to do something extra, you are already doing so much. You are not born poor. We earn poverty, we earn all kinds of diseases. So stop earning.

I am not saying that go on a reverse process. You don’t even need to go on any kind of process because whatsoever process you follow will ultimately

be *your* process. Don't follow any process. Just humbly accept for once, "Whatsoever I do, will be rotten." So, cease doing, stop doing. That is all that is needed and you will stop doing only when you really, really feel the need to be peaceful.

Listener: Is it possible to not do anything?

Speaker: It is not at all possible till you have great belief in your capability. Till the time you keep believing that "I can do something", you will surely keep doing something. It is only when you see the utter stupidity of all your actions and efforts that all your actions will cease. Till the time you don't come to that point where you realize that "Whatever I do will take me two steps behind", you will not stop doing.

You see people ask questions. One question has come up today as well. "Is it possible to understand something and still not accept it?" These are all deceptive questions. It's just that you are still greatly excited by your own calibre. You still want to do this or that. You simply don't want to surrender. That's it. There is no great complexity in your question.

It's just that your arrogant ego is still standing. You have a firm belief that "I am somebody, I will go out and prove myself. Who says that I cannot achieve anything? I have already achieved so much, I am educated, I am earning, I am doing this, doing that, I have a mind which does this, does that." Deep within this belief is holding up. That's it, nothing else. You don't want it.

Don't ask such questions as, "I have understood but I am not accepting" You don't want to accept! That's it. Simple. You have no intention to accept. When we have no intention to accept, then asking this sort of a question is pointless. "Why am I unable to open-up?" Who is keeping it

closed? You are keeping it closed because you have belief in your power and your might. Go ahead keep believing.

That is the reason why in India we believe in endless time. What Kabir calls as '*chaurasi ka phera*'. You will learn, if not in this birth then another birth. Keep believing that you are somebody, and keep pretending that you know. "It is not coming to me, it's not coming". Every time it comes to you, you kick it away and you are saying that it is not coming to you? Do you have any intention of welcoming it when it comes? It has come to you a thousand times. Every time you have turned it back. And here you are, posing as if some evil conspiracy in the heavens is keeping you deprived. There is no conspiracy anywhere in the heavens. You yourself don't want anything to happen. You have a grand ego that has grand delusions about its might. You don't want to surrender. You have great faith in your own capability and cunningness. "I will get it done, I know the ways and tricks." Try. If you will not try then how will we have all the fun?

Do you know what it means to become unconditional? It means becoming like the trees and the river. "If it is hot we take it, if it is cold we take it. From somewhere a lot of stuff comes, we take it. From somewhere nothing comes, we take it. Plenty of rain, we take it. A long drought, we take it. And not for a moment does my faith quiver. For not a moment do I start having doubts". That is unconditional Love. Unconditional Love is not about being fair-weather friends with the Lord. "You keep giving me bounties and you are so nice! And don't give me what I desire, then I've had it".

You know one of the most important reasons why people change religions? When adversity comes, two things start happening in abundance. One, the Sunday attendance at the churches increases. Second, a substantial chunk of people also convert to another religion. Why do they convert? "This God is

not at all good. So many adversities. Let me go to some other God.” “The Christian God is not good, let me go to the Islamic God.” And those who are still trying say, “Alright, let me give two more Sundays to the Christian God.”

This is not unconditional Love.

And remember your interactions with other human beings, your interactions with the entire world is nothing but a reflection of what your primary relationship with your own Source is. “How will I behave with my husband?” That depends on how you behave with your Source. “How will I behave with my neighbour?” That depends on how you behave with your Source.

Listener: If I am driving on the road and my car gets damaged due to somebody else’s fault. At that moment, it is human to say, “Why? Why me?” Call it road rage. To find peace in that situation, when you are in this mental state is very difficult. You find that you are far away from what will actually be considered as ‘aligned to the Source’.

Speaker: That’s a moment of infidelity. You have been disloyal to the *Parampati (The lord Husband)*. Just say, “Sorry”. What else can be done? The total was there to take care of you, and yet you thought that you are on your own. You need to say sorry. You have been infidel. Just say, “Sorry I got angry. Sorry I thought that I needed to manage the affair, you were there to manage and yet I took matters into my hand. Sorry.” That’s it. A humble sorry.

Please remember this clearly. If you have no inner connection with your own essence, you cannot love anybody else. You will be a very, very unloving and violent being. That is the fundamental and monstrous problem

with being an atheist. An atheist cannot love others because he does not love..?

Listener: Himself.

Speaker: And that himself is..?

Listeners: Source.

Speaker: When there is no love within, how can there be love radiating outwards? When there is no brightness within, how will you brighten others? You have babies, you have families, you have fathers, mothers and brothers and you want good relationships with them. Right? Remember you cannot *directly* have good relationships with them. Your relationships cannot be good till your relationship with your God is not good. Conversely, if you find that you have a bad relationship with your wife, husband or neighbour, then it means only one thing. Your relationship with the Source is bad. If that one relationship is good, all other relationships will be good. If that one relationship is bad, all other relationships will be necessarily bad. You may try to do whatever you want to do. Your best love affairs will come to an end.

Listener: It depends on both ends in a relationship.

Speaker: There is no 'both ends'. There is only one end. Remember what we are talking of. We are saying that love is not object dependent. When you say, "Both ends", you are depending upon the object. "I am depending upon her feeling towards me" and this itself is a huge condition. My feeling towards you will depend on..?

Listener: Your feeling towards me.

Speaker: So, you have the power to spoil my mood. Now the world has gained control over you. The world has become your master. The choice is yours. Either have one master, the Source or have a billion masters. Choice is yours. What do you prefer? Having one master or a billion masters? Depends on you. And if you don't have loyalty to that one master, then you will be condemned to have a billion masters. Everything will have the power to leave you astray. Anybody will come and influence you. And if anybody can come and influence you, that is a sure enough proof, that you don't love that one master.

Listener: Is this spirituality? That we will only love that one master. No matter what happens?

Speaker: That is what is called *Advait (Oneness)*.

Listener: Sir, is this the limitless 'Love is all, all is love'?

Speaker: Yes.

Listener: Sir, so if you are walking the path and somebody is throwing stones at you, then you should not bother? Because love is all, all is love.

Speaker: When you are one with the master, then you know the master. Then you know that others are not throwing stones at you, the master himself is throwing stones at you. And when your lover throws stones at you, you know that this is just *Leela*. When your lover throws stones at you, you know that he is just indulging in some kind of playfulness.

Coming close to the master, there are no 'others'. Somebody has thrown a stone at you; it's not 'somebody'. It's the total. It's the will of the universe. It's the Source itself who has thrown the stone. Now how can I feel bad? That does not mean that you will not respond appropriately. You will

respond appropriately but that primary relationship will not be stained. You will not immediately become an infidel. The intrinsic peace will not be disturbed, come what may. That is unconditional love. *Come what may, my intrinsic peace is never disturbed.*

Listener: It is just that we are superficially connected and we are seeing the bodies.

Speaker: And superficially and bodily, I will respond. There will be times when I am required to run away. I will run away. But one can run away in peace. There will be times when I will be required to shout. I will shout. But one can shout without losing his peace. I have not gone bonkers. My head is not spinning.

Listener: You just said that the superficial generosity that “I am giving” would be there but that doesn’t mean that there is a relationship with the Source.

This superficial generosity, will it have a limitation to itself after sometime, because there will be fear?

Speaker: You will give and count. You will give and count, “How much have I given and how much am I receiving back?”

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~ Chapter 5 ~

Love is an opportunity to know yourself

Speaker: Do you understand the difference between creating and building? Mind builds, intelligence creates.

All love starts as nearness, all love starts as an urge for nearness. It will always start in the mental domain, always. It could be sexual; it could be any other desire.

Listener: Emotional.

Speaker: Anything. It could be a social need and emotional need, whatever. Always mental. Always, always mental. But the good part is, whatever be the origin it creates nearness, it creates an opportunity to know. But just an opportunity. After that nearness, after that opportunity whether it blossoms into creativity, whether it enters the zone of creativity, is another matter.

Rarely does it exceed the initial attraction and flower into creativity. That rarely happens. So man and woman comes close to each other, mother and child are close to each other and the reasons are, of course, biological in both the cases, mother and child, man and woman. And that nearness is a great opportunity for observation. But it never happens that way, rarely happens that way.

You remember *Ishq-e-Majazi* (metaphorical love) and *Ishq-e-Haqiqi* (love of God)? It would always start as *Ishq-e-Majazi* but its destiny is to dissolve into *Ishq-e-Haqiqi*. That never happens unfortunately.

It may begin as attraction of the body but it should transcend that. Transcending does not mean that now I do not look at your body. Obviously

the eyes will only look at the body, the hands will only touch the body but something else has also happened and that is the real thing.

Some other event could have taken place, that event does not take place.

Let that happen.

There are people in your life, there are objects in your life that you think you are in a loving relationship with. See whether your love is still that emotional, loose thing, identification, security and all that or whether it has helped you and the other reach somewhere else. What is your effect upon the other's life and what is the other's effect upon your life?

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~ Chapter 6 ~

Aloneness is to see that alone; to see That alone is Love

Questioner: Sir, why do things appear different?

Speaker: The more distracted the mind is, the more it believes in diversity, the more it believes in different things to be different. Taking different things, letting your mind be subject to differences, is what is called as chaos. Understand this clearly.

Letting your mind become a victim of differences, is what is called as chaos.

A chaotic mind sees too many things and takes all of them to be independent of each other. Then comes a mind that is not so amorphous, that is crystallizing a little. It starts seeing a few principles. It starts seeing that even though things, people, time, situations, they appear different and diverse yet there is an underlying principle that unites them, they are not actually different, they only appear different.

It is a little bit like a layman thinking that the wall is qualitatively different from the fan, which is qualitatively different from the air, which is very different from the water. And a scientist comes and says, “No, they are not actually all that different. They are all made up of molecules and molecules are similar, and yes, at the molecular level, they are different but at the atomic level, even that difference vanishes. Alright, even the atoms may be different but the constituents of the atom are not at all different. So, the scientist starts seeing an underlying similarity, an underlying unity. He starts seeing that the moving world that seems to be moving around in a thousand directions, yet is governed by a few basic laws.

Everything appears so random but it is not actually random. Everything appears so different but nothing is discreet. They are all being governed by a few basic laws and even those laws are not very different, those laws are just one.

Similarly, a person whose mind is very-very chaotic, divided, distributed, looks at his relationships with everybody and thinks that he is in different kinds of relationships. He will say, “I have one relationship with my girlfriend, I have another relationship with my parents, I have yet another relationship with my bike, I have a fourth kind of relationship with animals, a fifth with teachers, a sixth with science and technology, a seventh with books and ideas”, and he thinks that there are *diverse* relationships. But a little bit of understanding and he realizes that, “No, relationships are not really different. Ultimately, most of my relations are driven just by two factors – greed and fear.”

So he says, “Why call all these relationships as different. Ultimately, I am operating only in greed and fear, nothing else.”

So, from many, from apparent diversity, the mind starts coming towards a few, or One. The senses always tell you that there are many, many and many. The senses, whenever they perceive, all that they perceive is differences. All that they perceive is limitations. You cannot be perceived if you do not have a limit. A word cannot be perceived if it does not ever stop. If there is something that is always continuing, it cannot be perceived. For example, you can never perceive silence because silence is ever continuous; it is always a background against all noises. So, at the level of the senses, things are very-very divided and amorphous. Then when you look at the mind, you find that there are underlying principles. I gave the example of fear and greed, and then when you go further down then you say that

whatever the mind is doing, is originating from a single Source. *Everything* is the manifestation of that Source. Then, you do not say that things are different at all. Then, at some level, you start seeing that this is the same as this, is the same as this, is the same as this, is the same as everything else (*pointing at different things in the room*). Now, diversity comes to an end, division comes to an end, naming comes to an end. You start seeing a particular Oneness. You start seeing that only that Source exists. It may appear to be diverse but actually only that Source exists. In other words you say, “The Source alone exists.”

Listener: In different forms.

Speaker: The forms may be different but the Source alone exists. When you see that the Source alone exists, even though it manifests itself in a billion forms, this is called Aloneness.

The one who can see That alone in everything and everybody, he is Alone. That alone, only That. Nothing else. He knows then that existence is not divided. He knows then – even though the branches may be different, the twigs may be different, the leaves may be different but the root is one, and the root alone is expressing itself as the huge tree. This is Aloneness; the root alone exists. Leaves will fall; even the branches will come and go. The root alone really exists. This is Aloneness. Is that becoming clear?

Listener: Sir, suppose we know that the root alone exists and that we are the part of the same Source from which everything originates. How would that help us to be alone? Even after knowing all this, you have these gratifying experiences or thoughts that come to your mind, which take you away.

Speaker: When I am saying, “The root alone exists, can you say ‘I’?”

Listener: No, sir.

Speaker: Then, what are you? When the root alone exists, who are you? - The root, That, Alone.

So, why are you asking this question? “What will I do? What can I think?”

Listener: Sir, the root will also come to an end.

Speaker: The root too will come to an end, if the root is the part of the mental world. That is why the root that we are talking of, which alone exists, is beyond senses, beyond the mind. *Whatever is there in the mind, will always come to an end.* Whatever is in the mind, is subject to origination and demise.

Listener: Sir, does Aloneness mean ignoring the world?

Speaker: No, Aloneness does not mean ignoring the world. At a very practical level, Aloneness means ‘the other’ is not very different from me. You cannot be too angry with anybody. The mind is one. “He operates out of fear, but I too operate out of fear. What right do I have to be so angry?” Whatever is happening in the entire world is ultimately the reflection of my mind. How dare I say that the world is corrupt?

Do you understand Aloneness? That things are not different, things are not divided. They are unified, they are one. Do not point fingers at anybody. The chaos in the world is actually the chaos in my mind because my mind and the world are same. If I see that there is war, rape, dishonesty and corruption, it is because my mind too is full of sexuality, violence and greed. This is Aloneness, that it is not so different as it appears. In Aloneness, understand this, you cannot really take or treat anything as

inferior or superior. You cannot claim that something is mine and something is not mine.

In that sense, and we have come to something beautiful, in that sense, Aloneness is a great quality of love. Ego separates, aloneness brings you closer to the entire world. Ego separates, Aloneness brings you close to everything that is perceivable or thinkable.

Listener: Sir, you mentioned that the Source gives rise to everything. I would like to know what is the Source?

Speaker: That pen is the Source, this wall is the Source.

Listener: These are other objects,

Speaker: These are not other objects. This is the only way you can know the Source, by looking at the way the Source manifests. You are asking, “If the Source alone exists, I want to know the Source.” There is no way to know Source, except by looking at the manifestations themselves. The Source manifests itself in you, the Source manifests in the tree, and the source manifests in the sky, in the river. Look at them closely and you will also find the Source.

Listener: Do you mean that all these things look different but actually the Source is same?

Speaker: Yes. And there is no way to know the Source, because the Source does not exist separately. It exists only as the manifested and it is manifesting itself continuously. Look at the manifestation, come close to it and when you look at anything with attention, you will see the Source, you will see That alone. It is great. You are looking at the road and you are looking at That alone. You are looking at the sky and you are looking at

That alone. You are looking at your own face and it is no longer you, it is That alone.

It is That alone.

But let me also guarantee that when that will happen, you will not *know* that this is happening. So, anybody who says that I have had an experience of ‘That’ is lying, because when ‘That’ will happen, ‘you’ will not exist. So, there is no way you can register it. There is no way you can register it.

Listener: Sir, different people say that they have experienced ‘That’ in different forms.

Speaker: Thoughts and imaginations, nothing else. It has got nothing to do with senses. It has got nothing to do with eyes. Yes, the eyes will look at the road but there is something else that will be perceived differently, there is something else that would be known and that which would be known, that would not be known as a thought.

You would not be thinking that you are knowing something, “Yes, now I am seeing That alone. Alright, what is the time? At this time, I am seeing That alone.”

“And you come here, I am seeing That alone, you too are seeing That alone?” “Yes, I am also seeing.” “Come, give me a hug. We both are able to see That alone.”

These are self-deceptions.

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~ Chapter 7 ~

Free from lovers, You become free to love

*“I am your lover, come to my side,
I will open the gate to your love.”*

~ Rumi

Questioner: Sir, how does love begin? Who is this ‘I’? Who is this lover? What is Rumi saying?

“I am your lover, come to my side, I will open the gate to your love.”

Speaker: Love is your very being. The moment, the day, the place, the point you come into being, love too comes into being. You cannot *be* without loving. It’s just that you do not *know* your lover. *You do not know for whom your heart beats.* You know ‘somebody’ calls.

In fact you do not know that ‘somebody’ calls, ‘somebody’ is just your language. All you *know* is that there is a call. And you do not know what that call is all about. And you are experiencing that call since ever. It pulls you. All your movement is dictated by that call. The smallest step that you take in the course of the day is nothing but a response to that call. Each and every action, every single breath, every single thought, every single step that you take is because you are being called. There is nothing else that energizes you. There is nothing else that motivates you. There is the call, that ancient primordial call that has been there since the time you have been there, the call that comes into being the moment you come into being.

The call is there and you are there and it has a strange, miraculous charm and pull. It’s a music that you do not understand; still its enigma has a

mystery that connects to your heart. You are powerless in front of it. You are helpless and you are pulled. But you do not know what is pulling you. So then you enter a strange situation, there is ‘something’ that you want and everything that you doing, is just to get that ‘something’; but you do not know what that ‘something’ is.

Your situation is like that of a woman, who is being called by the flute of her lover and the lover is distant, very-very distant. But the call is close, very-very close, present all the time. The music is calling and she is going in the direction of the music. And in between she meets a shopkeeper on the way and she thinks that this shopkeeper might be the one playing the flute. So she starts living with the shopkeeper.

Now obviously the shopkeeper was not playing the flute, the call is coming from somewhere else. The result is disappointment. And so after sometime she again sets off towards the lover who is calling. And this time great scenes and pictures and landscapes await her. She thinks that maybe the call is arising from here. She does not know who is calling, so she can only guess and attribute. “Maybe he is calling, maybe he is calling.” “He might be my lover, may be my restlessness will be quenched by being there.” And in this way, the woman is roaming here and there and it’s an infinite land. And there are infinite objects to whom the call can be mistakenly attributed and then life is nothing but a series of mistakes and subsequent disappointments.

You make a mistake by going to someone thinking that this fellow might be the lover who calls. All you get is sorrow. You go to the next one, thinking that this might be the one who calls. All you get is even deeper sorrow. That’s the story of love. *Love is your being, love is your breath, love is your energy.* Wherever you are going, in whichever direction, towards whichever

person, it is love that you want, it is love that pushes you, it is love that calls you.

Now what is Rumi saying? Rumi is saying, “I am your lover, come to my side, I will open the gate to your love.”

Strange words? He is saying, come to me first and then I will open the gates for you. Now what kind of statement is this? If I had already come to you, then what is the need for opening any gates anymore? But Rumi is saying that.

He is saying, “I am your lover, come to my side. I will open the gate to your love.”

Understand this.

The ‘One’ who calls is not a body, is not a person, is not an entity. That’s it, full stop. When you know this clearly and remember this constantly, then you can never, never attribute love to a body or a person or an entity. Then you can never delude yourself into thinking that an object, a name, a person, a body is what you want. When the mind is free of wrong notions about love, then the lover who sits right in your Heart shows you the way to love.

Go again to what Rumi is saying. He is saying, “Come to my side, I will open the gate to your love.” “Come to *my* side”, what does it mean to come to *my* side? It means do not go to somebody else’s side. You are always, always beside somebody. You always have a lover and that is the reason why you never find **Love**.

It’s strange, right? Most people complain of loveless lives. And this is why they have loveless lives; because they have lovers. *Till the time you have a*

lover, you will never, never find love. When you stop having a lover, when you see the foolishness of hankering after lovers, then the gate to love opens, then the real lover sitting at your centre opens the gate to love.

Now, love is independent of lovers. Once that gate is opened, now love is something within you. Now, you will not be like the woman running hither-thither searching for lovers. Now, love is your own being, it's a state, quality of your own mind. Now, you can say that you are the lover you had been looking for, so far.

Rest assured till the time you are looking for a lover, you will never find love. A lover you may find, but lovers are worthless. Those who have had lovers and many lovers, know that. But their foolishness is that having had lovers they become habituated to having more lovers. It becomes an obsession with them, a dirty habit, that "I must have a body by my side."

Get rid of the promise of lovers and you will get love.

Rumi is saying, "I will open the gate to *your* love." "I will open the gate to your love." You will not be then able to say that you love 'X' or 'Y'. But then you will be able to authentically say, "*I love. Not 'X', not 'Y', well not 'Z' either, but I love.*"

"I love."

You know hearing the words of Truth can have only two effects upon you: either you will feel deeply, deeply light and blissful or you will be scared. It depends on who you are.

Listener: Sir, there is this line that says, "Work is love made visible." What does this mean?

Speaker: We talked about it. Didn't we say that, your every step is nothing, but the call of love?

But the question is, are you able to understand that call. "Work is love made visible."

Yes of course, but that does not mean that *your* work will bring you closer to Love. It is strange that one works because of the call of Love, otherwise there is no reason to work.

And work does not mean paid work. Every single work, even this act of asking a question is work; breathing is work. So, one works only because Love calls. But if the mind is not attentive and faithful then the work can take you further away from the call.

It's like you are standing and somebody is calling from far, far away and if you do not listen attentively to the call, it is possible that he is calling from the east and you start running towards the west. But still, even if you are running wrongly, your running is because of 'the call'. So, work is Love made visible. Your running is the call made visible.

You know, we are 'smart people'. What happens is, it is not that we do not know from where the call is coming. It's like this. Let's say I am calling you but you are quite 'smart'. I am calling you and in between there is a hurdle. I am sitting straight in front of you and I am calling you and there is a hurdle in between. So, you say, "I will take a fifteen degree detour." What will I do? "I will not take a straight road. I will turn by fifteen degrees to avoid the hurdle in between". That's what you say. So, you turn by fifteen degrees. Now, when you turn by fifteen degree you find that there is...?

Listeners (*in unison*): Another hurdle.

Speaker: Now you are so smart. You don't want to face the hurdle, you don't want to take the bull by the horns, you want to devise clever methods of avoiding the trouble and yet getting what you want. So you take another fifteen degree turn and then you find there another obstacle.

So what do you do? You take another turn. All the while you were thinking that after taking all these turns, you will turn back towards the one who's calling. Like you have diversions in the roads that have been built, so you keep taking those diversions. And fifteen degree diversion, taken fifteen times and where you end up reaching? It's a U-turn!

But you are so smart, you are still thinking that you are going towards that call. It's your smartness that defeats you.

When love calls, move straight. Do not try to act smart. And if you meet a hurdle in between, fight it, jump over it, cross it but do not change your track even by fifteen degrees. Do not apply methods and cleverness.

Listener: Sir, it is always fear that doesn't let us face the hurdle or grab the bull by its horns and always a greed too because you want to enjoy something at that moment and not really attend to that hurdle.

Is this a promise that in the future I will get over this habit or this too is an illusion and the mind will always remain in fear and greed?

Speaker: When the obstacle comes, then obviously you take a diversion because you feel incapable of overcoming that hurdle, right?

So, let me give you a small mantra. Why did you come to that obstacle? Because 'somebody' called. Well, it's obviously not 'somebody' but just for the sake of language, let's call it 'somebody'. So, you came to the obstacle because somebody called. Now, let the caller take care of the obstacle. Why

do you think that you have to surmount the barrier? Why do you think that your energy and effort will be needed to defeat the obstacle?

When you come to it then say, “You called, so now I am facing this problem.” Tell the lover, “You called, so now I have come to this obstruction. And I am facing this threat. You called, you take care of it.” And then test whether or not the problem is taken care of. Test!

But you do not do that. You say, “I will overcome this problem using *my* energy, *my* cleverness and *my* methods.” You do not call Him. You apply your ‘own’ power.

And your power is exhausted. Your power is so little. He creates this obstruction, because he likes to hear from you. You will not call him if that problem is not there. So he puts that problem so that you may call him but you are cleverer than he is. He thinks that by doing this, he will be able to get your attention. But still you do not pay any attention.

Try, test him out. It’s a fundamental rule. When you come to a problem because the Truth called you, if your problem has been given to you by Truth, then only the Truth can solve the problem. It’s a very fundamental rule. Not your cleverness!

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~ The Call ~

*“To know the false as false
is the movement into the Truth.”*

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~ Chapter 1 ~

What takes you to your beautiful Heart is beautiful

Question: What is beauty?

Speaker: So, we are talking about beauty. There is beauty in the dualistic sense – where something is beautiful, only if correspondingly there is something ugly, to compare it with. And then there is the non-dualistic, ‘*advaitik*’ beauty, where there is no opposite of beauty, where Beauty alone is - independent and all-encompassing.

Since in this non-dualistic Beauty, there is nothing except Beauty, so obviously there is nothing to compare beauty with. Beauty alone is. What would you compare it with? Hence, it leaves no space for the ugly. That which alone is – is the Truth. And in the non-dualistic sense – Beauty alone is. There is nothing ugly.

Truth alone is. And in the real definition of beauty, Beauty alone is, because there can be nothing ugly, given that it is a non-dualistic definition. Now combine these two, and what do you get?

Truth is beautiful. Truth alone is Beauty alone. Truth alone is Beauty alone. That is the purport of the statement that you often hear, ‘*Satyam, Shivam, Sundaram*’ (Truth, Godliness, Beauty). Truth is Beauty.

But when Truth is Beauty, remember, there is nothing ugly. If you still are seeing the world in a divided way, where you see things still as ugly, then one really does not have the right to utter this statement. This is about the non-dualistic beauty.

I will want to come back to the dualistic world. Something fine needs to be understood there. When we look at the world around, there are differences. What we call as 'human life,' is a life of discrimination, differentiation and discretion. We have to differentiate between 'white' and 'black'. We have to differentiate between 'day' and 'night', between 'being' and 'non- being'. That is what human life as a body is all about, right?

Your eyes do not look at the non-dual Truth, they only look at differences. Your ears do not hear the non-dualistic Silence. They only hear wave forms comprising of differences, changes, modifications. So, when we talk of *this* world, we have to talk about the art of discrimination, because discrimination will be there.

Beauty might be sitting in your Heart, but when you look outside through your eyes, you will have to differentiate. And the moment you say, "Differentiate", beauty cannot be all-encompassing, at least externally. Internally it might be, internally it might be your life-breath, internally it might be your very life-force, but your eyes, I repeat, can only see duality. Your mind can only *think* by way of inclusion and exclusion. Your entire process of living as body-mind, is dualistic. Or is it not? Your very sense of 'I am' as body-mind is dualistic.

So then the question that arises is, "Even if there is an all-encompassing beauty sitting in my heart, how to differentiate between the 'beautiful' and the 'ugly' in the external world?" The world is always external. I repeat the question, and it's a very pertinent question. The question is: "Even if the Beauty, the Truth is sitting in my heart, how do I differentiate between 'beauty' and 'ugliness' in the external world? How do I differentiate between the 'Truth' and 'falseness' in the external world?"

The answer is actually, pretty simple and obvious. There will really be no need of asking for a ‘how to’, ‘how to differentiate’. If Beauty is sitting in your Heart, that enables you to find Beauty outside. How?

There are only two kinds of minds, and there are only two kinds of sensory inputs that you receive. The mind is a dislocated child. The mind is a wanderer, looking for its home. There are only two kinds of inputs that can come to this lost and wandering child. First kind of input is – the one that takes it back to its Home, the second kind of input is – that which takes it further away from its Home.

‘Beautiful’ is the input that takes you towards Beauty.

How do I decide that what is beautiful in this world? We said, “The Heart is always beautiful.” We said, “Beauty alone exists, Truth alone exists.” But Truth alone exists only to the Truth itself. We as creatures of falseness, we as lost minds, for us both true and false exist. Otherwise, there is no question of being lost. So for us, in the world, not only beauty, but also ugliness exists. The question that we are probing is, “How do I know that what is beautiful and what is ugly in this world.” The answer we said is simple.

The Heart is beautiful, the Heart is the center of all Beauty, and you are receiving inputs all the time from this world. *Whatever takes you towards your beautiful Heart is Beautiful. Do you get this? Whatever takes you towards your beautiful Heart is beautiful. And whatever takes you away from the Beauty in your Heart is ugly.*

You read a book, and it disturbs your already disturbed mind, you are justified in calling it ‘an ugly book’. Are you getting it? You go to a place, you are disturbed already, otherwise you wouldn’t have gone to this place.

You go to a place which disturbs you, you are justified in calling that place 'ugly'. Now remember, I am cautioning you, that place is not actually ugly. That place is ugly for *you*. It is just a subjective labeling that you are doing. But you are justified in doing that labeling, because for you, it is indeed ugly. Why is it ugly? Because as far as you are concerned, that place is taking you away from the Heart, away from Silence, away from Truth and Peace. So you are justified in calling that place 'ugly'.

Do not take this labeling very rigidly. Do not think that this is a universal and absolute Truth that the place is ugly. But it is simultaneously alright to say that as far as you are concerned, for you obviously, that place is not auspicious. You must avoid it. Yes, there may be somebody else who does not need to avoid that place. There may be somebody else who might feel actually nice being in that place. There may also be somebody else who might actually start feeling peaceful in that place. He need not say, "The place is ugly." Let him say, "The place is beautiful." And you need not quarrel with him, because all labeling is anyway subjective.

We are talking right now about the 'beautiful' and 'ugly' in the world, and the world itself is subjective. So, no wonder that whatever we are talking of is just subjective. Are you getting it? This is how you should look at the world. *What is beautiful? That which takes you towards the Beautiful. What is ugly? That which takes you away from the Beautiful.*

Which place is a temple? That which reminds you of the Truth. Any place that reminds you of the Truth is a temple. And even if a place is labeled as a 'temple', but it disturbs you even more, you have no need to call it a 'temple,' because it is not a temple for *you*. And all that matters is, whether it is a temple for *you*.

Absolute definitions do not matter in the world. *The absolute matters only to the Absolute.* And to creatures of non-duality, only non-dualistic definitions are useful. To them, an Absolute Truth makes no sense.

What I am talking of becomes more important when you contrast it with your classical definition of the 'beautiful' and the 'ugly'. How do you conventionally decide, what is 'beautiful' and what is 'ugly'? You say, "That which pleases my conditioning is beautiful." Don't you say that? And, "That which violates, and hurts, and breaks my conditioning is ugly." Don't you do that? You have been conditioned to hear one particular kind of music, since childhood. And what do you do? You start finding it beautiful.

In the world you always differentiate between the 'beautiful' and the 'ugly', we are trying to see that what is the right way of making that differentiation. Usually how do you differentiate? Usually you say, "What pleases my conditioning is beautiful. Being born in this milieu, looking at particular kind of faces, I think that a brownish complexion is better than a blackish complexion, a wheatish complexion is better than a brownish complexion." Don't we carry all these prejudices?

A fair face comes in front of us, and given that we are sitting in this part of the world, when a fair face comes in front of our eyes, we are more likely to call it 'beautiful', which is nothing but conditioning and prejudice. But it happens all the time, does it not happen?

Even today, if you look at your popular actors and actresses, are not most of them cut out in similar ways? There may be a little bit of divergence here and there. But do you see radically different personas? Look at actresses, for example. Are not most of them ticking the same boxes? "She must have a particular height, she must have a particular body-type, and she must have

a particular kind of face.” Is that not happening? And that’s what you call as ‘beautiful’. This is an *ugly* way of deciding between ‘the beautiful’ and ‘the ugly’.

I will come back to the fundamental issue. What I am saying is, in the world, because we are creatures of duality, so we have to differentiate between the ‘beautiful’ and the ‘ugly’. It will inevitably happen. Even if we grandly declare, “Beauty alone is”, it is a meaningless statement. In the world we keep on differentiating, don’t we differentiate? We differentiate between ‘blue’ and ‘green’, we differentiate between ‘hot’ and ‘cold’. So we will end up differentiating between ‘beautiful’ and ‘ugly’.

So, we have taken up the issue of how to rightly differentiate between ‘the beautiful’ and ‘the ugly’? The conventional way is – “What suits my conditioning is beautiful, what hurts my conditioning is ugly”. That is the conventional way of deciding. We are saying, “Let’s come to a more spiritual way, more real way of making this distinction.” So, we are saying, “That which takes you towards your Heart is Beautiful, that which takes you away from your Heart is ugly.”

That is not beautiful which pleases your senses. That is not ugly which your mind repulses. Let that not be a criterion at all. Criteria should be, “Reading this book, did I get to peace? Sitting in front of this man, did I experience silence?” If such is the book, call it ‘a beautiful book’. If such is the man, call him ‘a beautiful man’. A man is not beautiful, if he *looks* a particular way. Whether or not a person is beautiful, is to be determined by how you feel near that person. It’s a very subjective definition. But yes we are talking of subjectivity. We are talking of this dualistic world, where everything is subjective.

Whether or not your wife is beautiful, is not determined by the way she talks and looks. It is determined by how you feel when you are next to her. Does she bring you to that beautiful silence, or do you get further agitated by being in her company? Does she excite you? Then she is disturbing you. Or does her very presence calm you down? If her presence calms you down, then she is beautiful.

Are you getting it?

I do not know how *Kabir* might have looked as a person, but I *know* that he is Beautiful, and there is nobody more beautiful than Kabir. I keep calling Jesus 'handsome'. It is not because he was young, and tall, and fair, and muscular. I keep calling him 'handsome', for what he was. *Meera* is indeed so beautiful, not because she had sharp features, or she was an attractive young woman. *Meera* is beautiful for her devotion. *Meera* is beautiful, because when you are with *Meera*, then some of her devotion simply rubs-off on you. Sitting next to *Meera*, you get a taste of *Krishna*. That is why *Meera* is beautiful.

Buddha is so handsome, so is *Mahavira*. They are not handsome because they are attractive personalities. They are handsome because of what they are. They are handsome because when they are in front of you, you cannot be violent anymore. It is said of these people, that when they would walk, even animals would lose their violent tendencies for a while. Next to them, even animals would cease to be violent. And that is why they are handsome.

Do not just praise the eyes of your girlfriend. Her eyes are beautiful, if they can carry you into the Beyond. If her eyes just seduce you sensually, then they are very ugly eyes, very-very ugly eyes. But looking her eyes, if you are transported beyond your everyday problems, if you forget all about the

trivial matters that occupy your mind, then her eyes are indeed beautiful. That is the way to decide, whether or not something or somebody is beautiful. Are you getting it?

Look at most of the things that people usually call as 'beautiful'. Do they calm you down, or do they excite you more? When you call somebody 'beautiful', what happens when you are in his or her company? Are you calmed down, or do you become more excited and agitated? Yes? What happens? It only results in more excitement. If in somebody's presence, you become excited, then that presence is not really good for you.

Now, we will try to be more watchful and alert when we utter these words: beautiful and ugly. You may look at a landscape and say, 'beautiful'. The moment you say, 'beautiful', ask yourself, "Was it because it excited me, or was it because it calmed me down?" If it calmed you down, only then you are justified in calling it as 'beautiful'. Usually, if it calmed you down, then you will not be excited enough to say 'beautiful', for *Beauty is Peace and Peace is Silence*.

If you are uttering 'beautiful', chances are, it didn't calm you down. It excited you. Had it really calmed you down, why would you have been excited enough to say 'beautiful'? You may still say, we are not ruling out the possibility, but chances are, when you will really experience beauty, you will become silent. The thought of praising it, or saying something about it, will not come to you. It would only probably be later, in some other context that you would want to attach a word or label to it. Only when somebody would ask, "Was it a beautiful experience?" then you would reply, "Oh indeed it was!" Only upon probing, would you want to give it a name, otherwise you won't want to even give it a name.

Live cautiously in this world which uses sacred terms in profane ways. In this world, 'beauty' has become a cheap word. 'Beauty' is a sacred word, as sacred as 'Truth'.

You purchase a new gadget, hold yourself from calling it 'beautiful'. You look at a skyscraper, a new building, check yourself if you feel like calling it 'beautiful'. You look at a song, which is giving you a semi-erotic experience, and what do you do? You call it 'beautiful'.

This is sacrilege.

**'Beautiful' is that which takes you towards your Beautiful Heart.
That's what Beauty is.**

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~ Chapter 2 ~

The Total calls only in Silence

Question: Sir, mind is saying, “You should not do this,” or “You have to do this,” holding onto something else. One part of the mind is saying, “You have to do this?” Other part is saying, “It is okay, you can do that.” There always seems to be a choice and the voice of the Heart is faint.

Speaker: See, the right action has no voice. Maybe I said that the voice of the Heart is very faint. It is actually more faint than faint. It has no voice at all. Whenever there is a voice, it is the voice of the mind.

The right action happens voicelessly. It comes from nowhere, it goes into nowhere.

You don’t even know that you have acted. In fact, if somebody tells you that, “You have made a choice just now”, you would be a little surprised. You would say, “But was there a choice? Have I really made a choice?”

Whenever the mind is divided into two parts or ten parts and the parts are going in this direction or that direction, none of the directions is your direction. It is the direction of that particular part, right?

See, you are being pulled in ten directions, one of the pullers become strong enough to overpower the other nine, and carry you towards himself, drag you, pull you towards himself.

Does it mean that, that puller is you?

Does it mean that going in that one’s direction is your freedom?

It does not mean that.

Similarly, if one of the forces pulling you is too weak, too faint, and it is not able to exercise any control over you, does it mean that, this really is the force of the Heart?

As you said that the voice of the Heart is faint. So, that means, whenever there is a faint pull, that must be the real you.

It's not really so.

None of the divisions of the mind represent the essence of the mind. It can be a large force; it can be a small force.

So, when you come to this dilemma of, "What to do? The mind is being pulled in this direction and that direction!" it is not imperative for you to act. You have the freedom to not to go in either direction. You have the freedom to just stay put.

Why must you move? Let both the pullers tire down by themselves. Let them keep trying and become exhausted. And then you will spontaneously know which direction to go. The movement will happen on its own. You will not need to decide and choose.

Isn't it obvious? There is one entity that is pulling to the right. There is one entity that is pulling to the left. And then there is a third entity that is deciding whether to go to the right or go to the left. Even the third one is divided into two parts – one is biased towards the right, one is biased towards the left.

Where are you in all this? And even the decision maker is under the influence of lobbying. This one is lobbying for his interest. The other force is lobbying for its own interest. When all this circus is going on, whatever

comes out from this circus will be a joke. (*Laughingly*) So, let the joke stay as a joke. You don't need to become a character in all that.

Let the forces play out. Let them get tired. Let their power come down a little. And then you can see when movement happens on its own.

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~ Chapter 3 ~

Pay the price of living by the Heart

Question: What are memories? We are happy, we get sad, and we get flashbacks. What are they? What do they mean?

Speaker: Memories are residues.

I would like to put it this way. There are two kinds of memories. Capacitor memories and current memories. What are capacitor memories?

Listener: The memories are stored. There is no circulation of current. There is no resistance.

Speaker: What if the circulation is happening due to resistance? This is current memory.

Seeing is not resisting. To see something is to just observe what is happening. It is not about adding to the resistance. What if the circulation is happening precisely because you are resisting something?

If something is continuously there in the mind, it is circulating in the form of the thought. Then rest assured that there is something that you are resisting. Either you are doing something per force or there is something that needs to be done, but you are not doing it per force.

Only these two options are there, nothing else. You have the solutions. Just do not resist the solutions. It is that simple.

Listener: What if there are side-effects?

Speaker: There will be side-effects. Take them, nothing will happen. It is guaranteed that there will be side-effects. Somebody will say something,

somebody will take away something, you may lose some money, somebody may get upset. These things will happen but take the side-effects. It is worth it.

Living by the Heart is always worth it, whatever be the side-effects, whatever be the price you have to pay.

Listener: Sir, is it right to say that the life of an average human is the result of the force between the Heart and the mind?

Speaker: Well said! Beautifully said! And that is why there is always some tension. One thing pulls you in one direction; another thing pulls you in another direction. The result is tension. Now do you know that why our lives are infested with stress? Now do you understand what is ‘stress’?

Stress is – mind versus mind, mind versus Heart.

Listener: Sir, you often tell us to pursue that thing as our profession that comes from the Heart. How to know that a particular thing is coming from the Heart?

Speaker: It is the result of the kind of life you are living. One does not choose a profession in isolation. Just the way you choose your T-shirt, just the way you choose your girlfriend, just the way you choose the model of your bike, just the way you choose your wrist watch, is also the way you choose your profession.

When you go to an eatery and order something to eat, you have made a choice. Have you not? There is a basis to that choice; there is a foundation of that choice. You always have choices, right? You always have a choice to do this, to do that, to watch TV, or to meditate, or to watch a movie, or to go to friends or to play cricket or whatever. There is always a choice involved.

There is always a reason behind that choice; there is always a basis to that choice. That same basis will be applicable when you make your job choice as well.

The man who cannot choose his T-shirt wisely, would also surely not choose his girlfriend wisely; neither would he choose a job wisely because the choice-maker is the same, the entity that is deciding is the same. If you do not know what to eat, you will also not know where to work. If all my other choices are misplaced, then is it possible that my one particular choice will be right? Is it possible? A program that always gives faulty output, can it give a right output in one isolated case? It cannot.

So you have to look at the entirety of life. You have to be careful of every single, small decision that you are making. When these small, small decisions will be alright, then your so-called big decisions will also fall into place. But what do we want? We say, “The small decisions can continue as they are but I want the big decisions to be taken care of.” This is impossible.

Make small decisions correctly. For example when you enter this room, decide rightly where to sit. If you keep making these small decisions rightly, you will also know how to choose your partner and how to choose a job. It is such a small thing.

Listener: Sir, this means that right decisions can be made only if you are living in the present.

Speaker: Yes. Do not ignore the small things because everything is a small thing. Do not ignore. Do not say, “Placement matters, but small unit tests do not matter.” They matter. The one who will sit in the placement is the same one who is not writing the unit test. Or is he a different fellow?

Listener: We have been taught that whatever comes from the mind has characteristics such as ambition, greed and fear. But whatever we see around us, whatever we do always has a motive, or an objective of profit, the first kind of negotiation which we call. So this means that all of us mostly act from the mind then?

Speaker: Yes. But why does that surprise you? That is the way the world is. My question to you is, even if the world is that rotten, do you want to live that way? The world may be that rotten, but do you want to live that way? That is the question.

Do you want to live that way? If everybody around you is diseased, would you say, “Because everybody is diseased so I should also fall sick”? Or would you say, “Now the onus is on me to not to allow the disease to hit me. I will let Health flow through me”? What would you say?

It is extremely important to realize that we live in an extremely sick world. What you read in the newspaper is sick. What you see around yourself is sick. The markets are sick. The shopping malls are sick. The streets are bustling with sickness. Educational institutions, political social and economic institutions, they are all brimming with sickness. That is disappointing. But one cannot evade the fact that when one is Healthy, only then one can help others be Healthy, see that others are sick, and see that their sickness has affected you as well. And see that you do not want to be sick anymore. That will be the beginning of your recovery. And when you recover, you will be able to help others recover.

Don't you want to recover? When you open the television, do you see Health? Or you see the same game of ambition, loot, fear, insecurity, competitiveness, greed, jealousy, possessiveness? What do you see? And do

you want to participate in all that? Do you want to spend your life in all that? But if you are surrounded with that all the time, it is bound to affect you.

When life gives you opportunities, take them. If you come to a small oasis of Health, take shelter there. It is a barren desert of sickness. A small oasis is a very-very fortunate place. If you by-chance come to it, thank God for it, and stay put. Such a chance may not come again to you. Remain associated.

Listener: Sir, who is God? What if I do not believe that there is one almighty who is controlling everything?

Speaker: But you believe that there is a totality of things? That is something you do not need to believe. That is a fact. Some people call this totality as 'God'.

'God' is obviously not a figure or a person, or a unit, or an entity. This entire, overwhelming, immense, infinite totality is sometimes named as 'God'. That is it. Some people call it as 'God', which is there, obviously.

~

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~ Chapter 4 ~

To whom does the world belong?

3:45 am on a particular night: Just found *Koham*, *Soham* – the two pet dogs – romping merrily vigorously on the terrace.

As I went to them they made all efforts to include this third one – an ‘outsider’ who keeps sitting inside – in ‘their’ sport, on ‘their’ playground.

To whom does this terrace belong, really, right now?

To the landlord who is the legal owner? To me who pays the rent?

Not at all. It so obviously belongs to this pair of canines who have made it their playground.

To whom does the world belong? To the ones who own its corporations and countries and power and monies?

The world belongs to the naked man who is enjoying it.

The world is really owned by the innocent man who finds a playground and a dance floor everywhere.

The world is ruled by the Joyful secure insider who is at home everywhere.

Rest are all fooling themselves and missing the game.

~

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Shri Prashant

Prashant Tripathi, known as SHRI PRASHANT, was born on March 7, 1978 at Agra, India. Eldest of three siblings, his father was a bureaucrat and mother a homemaker. His childhood was spent mostly in the state of Uttar Pradesh.

Parents and teachers found in him a child who could often be quite mischievous, and then suddenly, deeply contemplative. Friends too recall him as having an unfathomable temperament, often not really sure whether he was joking or serious. A brilliant student, he consistently topped his class, and received the highest commendations and prizes possible to a student. His mother fondly remembers how she was honored several times as “Mother Queen” for the academic performance of her child. Teachers would say that never before had they seen a student who was as brilliant in Science as in Humanities, as adept in Mathematics as in Languages, and as proficient in English as in Hindi.

The prodigal student was a voracious reader since he was five years of age. His father’s extensive home library consisted of some of the world’s best literature, including spiritual texts like the Upanishads. For long hours, the child would be tucked away in the most silent corners of the house, immersed in stuff that was meant to be understood only by men of advanced age and maturity. He would skip meals and even hours of sleep, and would be lost in reading. Before he had turned ten, Prashant had read everything that was there in the father’s collection, and was asking for more. The first signs of the mystical appeared when he started writing poetry at the age of eleven. His poems were imbued in shades of the mysterious, and were asking questions that most grown-ups could not grasp.

At the age of fifteen, after being in the city of Lucknow for many years, he found himself in the city of Ghaziabad near Delhi, owing to his father’s transferable job. The particular age and the change of city accelerated the process that had already taken deep roots. He took to waking at night, and

besides studying, would often be staring silently at the night sky. His poems grew in depth, a lot of them devoted to the night and the moon. Rather than academics, his attention started flowing more and more towards the mystical.

He had been sensing since long that there is something fundamentally amiss in the way most people perceive the world, the way our minds are conditioned to operate, and hence something amiss in the way the relationships between people are, the way the worldly institutions are designed, the way we relate to each other – basically the very way we live. He had started seeing that this faulty perception was at the root of human suffering. He was deeply disturbed by man's ignorance and cultivated inferiority, the evils of poverty, the evils of consumption, violence towards man, animals and environment, and exploitation based on narrow ideology and self-interest. His entire being was raring to challenge the all-pervasive suffering, and as a young man, he guessed that the Indian Civil Services or the Management route might be an apt one to take.

At the age of twenty-eight, he bid goodbye to corporate life and founded Advait Life-Education for '**Creation of a new humanity through Intelligent Spirituality**'. The method was to bring a deep transformation in human consciousness. The initial audience chosen was college students who were offered self-development courses. Wisdom from ancient literature was taken to students in form of simplified texts and engaging activities.

Around the age of 30, Shri Prashant started speaking in his *Shabd-yoga* sessions, *Samvaad*, or clarity sessions. These were in the form of open discussions, essentially pure *satsang*. Soon it started becoming clear that these sessions were deeply meditative, brought the mind to a strange peace, and had a miraculously curative effect upon the psyche. Shri Prashant's voice and videos would be recorded and uploaded on the internet. And soon this site too was developed to publish his writings and the transcriptions of his talks.

Around the same time, he started organising Self-awareness camps or *Aatm-smaran shivir*. He would take true seekers with him to the Himalayas, in groups of around 30 each, for periods of around a week.

These camps turned out to be deeply transformational events and the frequency of the camps increased. Scores of camps have been organised so far providing immense clarity and peace in relatively short spans of time.

Shri Prashant's unique spiritual literature is at par with the highest words that mankind has ever known. He remains engaged sharing himself in the form of *shabd yoga* sessions, *shoonya-smaran* activities, self-awareness camps, and one-to-one meetings with the many seekers who visit him, from all parts of the world. He attacks the mind so vigorously, and simultaneously becalms it with such love and compassion. There is a clarity that radiates from his presence and a soothing effect from his being. His style is forthright, clear, mystical and compassionate. The ego and the falsenesses of the mind do not find a place to hide in front of his innocent and simple questions. He plays with his audiences – taking them to the very depths of meditative silence, laughing, joking, attacking, explaining. On one hand, he appears as somebody very close and approachable, and on the other hand, it is obvious that the words coming through him are from somewhere beyond.

The thousands of videos and articles uploaded by him on the internet are precious spiritual resources, available to all those who seek them. Personally too, he is ever open to meeting sincere seekers of Truth. Today, the Advait movement has touched the lives of more than a million individuals. Through his direct contact with people, and through various internet based channels, he continues to bring clarity, peace and love to all.

PrashantAdvait Foundation is a unique organization working towards promoting intelligence and awareness among individuals. To this effect, Advait harnesses the power of scriptures and works of saints.

Advait is, in the words of **Acharya Shri Prashant**, a movement towards a new humanity.

Acharya Shri Prashant is a contemporary young mystic whose **Shabd-Yoga** sessions, **Shoonya-Smaran** methods and **Anahad-Kriya** celebrations are bringing peace, wisdom and love to the world.

After education at IIT and IIM, and years of relentless spiritual pursuit, time brought him to the service of the timeless. He engages himself in leading Advait Life-Education, conducting clarity sessions, leading reflections camps in the Himalayas, and in the process, creating a unique body of spiritual literature.

Today, the **Advait movement** has touched the lives of more than a million individuals. Through his direct contact with people, and through various internet based channels, **Acharya Shri Prashant** continues to bring clarity, peace and love to all.

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